The Fifth Sun Is Running Out of Batteries

Book One of the Obsidian Mirror Chronicles

Working draft, Book One: Chapters 1 to 27 (revised versions)

Chapter One: My Substitute Teacher Is a Dog

Look, if you're reading this, you're probably in danger.

I'm sorry. I know that's a terrible way to start a book. But the first rule of surviving the gods is that the sooner you know they're real, the sooner you can start running, which is a rule I wish someone had told me before I'd picked my shoes based on how they looked.

My name is Mateo Quetzal Ibarra. I'm twelve, I live in San Antonio, and until last October my biggest problems were fractions and a sixth grader named Brock, who told me my lunch smelled "weird," which is funny considering he once ate a sandwich off the gym floor because he'd "called it."

Then came the field trip.

When Ms. Delgado announced we were visiting the new exhibit at the Museum of Mesoamerican Antiquities, I put my head on my desk and made a noise like a leaking air mattress.

"Mateo," she said, "you might actually like this one. It's about *your* heritage."

My dad's side of the family is from Puebla, and my abuela has told me about a thousand stories about the old gods, the ones from before the Spanish came: feathered serpents, jaguar warriors, a sun that has to be fed. I always figured they were stories, in the same category as La Llorona, who Abuela mostly uses as a curfew.

When I was eight, she told me the sun would stop moving if people forgot to feed it, and I laughed so hard I got milk up my nose. She didn't laugh. She just crossed herself and refilled my glass.

Spoiler: they were not just stories.

The museum was freezing and smelled like old pennies. Our guide was a tall, thin man in a

gray suit who introduced himself as Mr. Xavier, with ears that couldn't decide between pointy and floppy, and he kept sniffing the air like he'd heard the word "barbecue" from two rooms away.

I noticed. I ignored it.

"Welcome," he said, in a voice like gravel being poured into honey. "Today you will learn about the people who called themselves the Mexica. You call them the Aztecs. They believed something very interesting about the world."

In the back, Brock yawned loud enough to echo.

Mr. Xavier turned his head toward him, slowly. For a second, and I swear on my abuela's rosary, the shadow of his head on the wall had a snout.

Brock closed his mouth so fast I heard his teeth click.

"They believed," Mr. Xavier went on, "that the world had been created and destroyed four times. Four suns, four ages. Jaguars devoured the first people. Hurricanes swept away the second. Fire rained from the sky on the third. A flood drowned the fourth." He paused. "We live in the Fifth Sun. The Sun of Movement. And it is destined to end in earthquakes."

"Great," Danny whispered. Danny Okafor is my best friend. "I'll pencil that in after math."

"Is that true?" Priya asked from the front. "Like, the earthquake thing?"

Mr. Xavier smiled.

"The Mexica believed the sun needed to be fed to keep crossing the sky," he said. "Fed, and remembered." His eyes drifted across the class and landed on me, and stayed there one second longer than they should have. "Without both, it would stop."

Something cold slid down my back, because I'd heard that exact idea before, in a kitchen, over a glass of milk.

I stopped listening after that, because that's when I saw the mirror.

It sat alone in a glass case at the end of the hall, under one spotlight, a black stone disk about the size of a dinner plate and polished so smooth it looked like somebody had punched a hole in the room. The placard read:

OBSIDIAN MIRROR, TEZCATLIPOCA ("SMOKING MIRROR"). CENTRAL MEXICO, C. 1500. ON LOAN FROM A PRIVATE COLLECTION.

I don't know why I walked over. The rest of the class was clustered around a giant carved stone calendar. My feet just went.

The closer I got, the quieter it got. The AC hum faded. Danny's whispering faded. I could hear my own heartbeat, and under it, something else: a slow *tap, tap, tap*, like fingernails on a tabletop.

I looked into the mirror.

I expected my own face, messy black hair and the chocolate smear on my collar from that morning's pan dulce. Instead there was smoke, gray and curling, and in the middle of it a pair of eyes.

Yellow. Spotted, like a jaguar's. Looking right at me.

There you are, said a voice.

It didn't come from the mirror. It came from inside my skull, smooth and amused, the voice of a cat who has found a mouse and has the whole afternoon free.

Little Quetzal. Born on One Reed. We have been looking for you for twelve years.

I didn't have a joke for that. I couldn't feel my hands.

Then I screamed, stumbled backward, and took out an entire rack of brochures on the way down, which in a silent museum sounds a lot like a car crash.

"Mateo Ibarra!" Ms. Delgado hissed, hurrying over. "What on earth..."

"The mirror talked," I gasped. "There were eyes. It said I was born on One Reed..."

I trailed off, because three things hit me at once.

One: nobody else had heard anything.

Two: the glass case sat perfectly still, and the mirror inside it showed nothing but the reflection of some ceiling lights.

Three: I had no idea what day I was born on, in any calendar, and I'd definitely never told anyone.

"Deep breath," said Ms. Delgado. "Maybe sit down."

A shadow fell over us. Mr. Xavier stood there with his hands folded and his head tilted, studying me like a crossword he'd been stuck on for centuries.

"The boy needs air," he said. "I'll walk him to the courtyard."

"Oh, I couldn't ask you to..."

"I insist."

He never raised his voice. But for half a second his eyes flashed amber, flat and bright, like a car's headlights in a dark road. Ms. Delgado's sentence stopped in the middle, as if she'd reached for the next word and found the shelf empty. She blinked twice, looked around the room like she'd just woken up in it, and wandered back toward the calendar without a single question about where her student was going.

That was the moment I should have been more scared of him than of the mirror.

The courtyard had a dry fountain, a few skinny potted trees, and way too much sun. Mr. Xavier sat me on a stone bench, sat down next to me, and said nothing for a full minute, just sniffed, and then sighed.

"You smell like him," he said. "Smoke and bad decisions. I was hoping I was wrong."

"Like who?"

"The one who is, at this moment, trying to crawl out of that mirror and say hello." He tapped the side of his nose. "Mateo, I'm about to say some things that will sound insane. I need you not to run. Can you do that?"

"No," I said.

"Fair. Try anyway."

He held out his hands, and in the middle of a perfectly normal Texas afternoon the gray suit rippled like a pond. His face stretched and darkened. His nose lengthened into a black muzzle. His ears flopped forward and sprouted fur, and his eyes lit up the color of coals.

A man-sized dog sat on the bench next to me, still wearing a tie.

"My name," he said, in the same gravel and honey, "is Xolotl. God of lightning and twins and things that go wrong. Guide of the dead through the nine levels of Mictlan, the underworld. I have lived in your world for roughly five hundred years and I would like a nap. Unfortunately, I have a problem."

I opened my mouth. Nothing came out. My fingers were clamped around the edge of the bench so hard my knuckles had gone pale, and my heart was pounding like I'd run the mile after all.

Xolotl waited. He didn't rush me. He just watched, ears low, until my breathing slowed down a little.

"Screaming is common," he said kindly. "You went with brochures. Bold."

"You're a... you're a..."

"Dog. Yes. Please don't pet me. I have a reputation."

My voice returned from somewhere around my shoes. "Why are you telling me this?"

The ember eyes went grim. He glanced back at the museum doors, and for the first time I saw that a god could be scared.

"Because the Fifth Sun is failing, Mateo. The offerings stopped. The stories faded. The fire that moves the sky is down to its last embers." He leaned in close. "And Tezcatlipoca, my brother, the Smoking Mirror, lord of the night and every lie ever told, has decided the world would be better off ending. The mirror was a door, and you just knocked on it. He has been waiting for you to do that for twelve years."

"But *why* me? What does he want from me?"

"That is a longer answer than we have time for." Xolotl's ears twitched. "Ask me when we are not about to be eaten."

From deep inside the museum came a long, low crack, like ice splitting on a pond.

Xolotl's ears went flat.

"Ah," he said. "I was afraid of that."

"Afraid of *what*?"

The courtyard went dark. Not cloudy dark. *Smoke* dark. Gray tendrils poured through the museum doors like water through a broken dam, and in the middle of the haze, two yellow, spotted eyes opened.

Hello again, little Quetzal, the voice purred. *I did say we'd been looking.*

Xolotl grabbed my arm. "Mateo," he said, "how fast can you run?"

"I faked a sprained ankle to get out of the mile," I said.

"Then today," said the god of the dead, "you will learn."

And that, my friends, is how I ended up sprinting across a parking lot behind a talking dog while a living cloud of night chased us, on what had started out as the most boring Tuesday of my life.

Chapter Two: I Commit Grand Theft School Bus

Here's what nobody tells you about running from a living cloud: there's no dramatic music. There's just your own wheezing, which sounds like an accordion getting stepped on.

"Left!" Xolotl barked, and I do mean barked. "No, your *other* left!"

"I only have one left!"

"Then use it correctly!"

We burst out the courtyard gate into the museum parking lot, a baking slab of asphalt with maybe twenty cars and one very yellow school bus parked by the curb. Behind us, the smoke poured over the courtyard wall like someone had tipped over a bathtub of night. It didn't move like smoke. Smoke drifts. This was *hunting*.

"Mateo!"

I almost died of fright, which would have made the rest of this book very short.

Danny came sprinting around the corner of the building, his backpack bouncing against his spine. The smoke was all around him, curling past his ankles, brushing his arms. And it was *parting*. Like he was a rock in a river. It slid around him and closed up behind.

"Okay," Danny panted, skidding to a stop. "So everyone in the museum is standing perfectly still with their eyes open, Brock is drooling, and Ms. Delgado is holding a brochure like she's about to read it to the void. I figured you'd know something. Why is there a dog in a tie?"

"I prefer *god*," Xolotl said.

Danny looked at him. Looked at me. Looked at the smoke.

"Cool," he said. "I'm going to have my breakdown later."

Xolotl was sniffing the air near Danny with a frown. "You smell like rain on hot iron," he said slowly. "That is not the smell of any god I know." He shook himself. "No time. Mateo. The bus."

"What about it?"

"Can you drive it?"

I want to be clear that I was twelve. My driving résumé was Mario Kart, plus one time in my abuela's Buick, in an empty church parking lot, where I hit a recycling bin.

"Yes," I said.

"You are lying," said Xolotl.

"I'm *confident*."

"That's worse."

Danny grabbed my sleeve. "Mateo. Smoke."

It had reached the edge of the lot. And now it was changing. The gray tendrils were thickening, bunching into shapes taller than a man. Shapes with long thin arms, with wide skirts, with grins too wide for their faces. Tiny points of white light twinkled across their bodies like stars.

"Tzitzimime," Xolotl whispered, and his ember eyes went wide. "He's sent the star demons. They only come down when the sun is dying. They eat people. Mostly the loud ones."

"I'm loud," Danny said. "I'm *so* loud. Run."

We ran.

The bus door was open. The driver, Mr. Pruitt, sat frozen at the wheel with a half-eaten burrito in his hand and a look of pure peace on his face. Danny and I hauled him out of the seat. He weighed about as much as a refrigerator. We laid him on the curb as gently as we could.

"Is he okay?" I gasped.

"He sleeps," said Xolotl. "They all sleep. They will wake with a headache and a very strange story that nobody will believe."

"Keys are in it!" Danny yelled.

I jumped into the driver's seat. The wheel was the size of a hula hoop. The pedals were somewhere in a distant land. I slid forward until my toes found them and prayed to any god who wasn't actively trying to kill me.

Xolotl hopped into the front passenger seat and crouched there, ears flat. "Turn the key."

I turned the key.

The engine coughed once, then roared. The whole bus shook.

On the roof of the museum, six tall shapes made of smoke and starlight turned their heads toward us in perfect unison. And grinned.

"Hold on," I said.

"To what?" asked Danny.

"Anything!"

I stomped the gas.

Chapter Three: Danny Gets Rained On (Indoors, Mostly)

The first thing you learn about driving a school bus is that the brake pedal has a *personality*. The second thing you learn is that a bus doesn't turn like a car. It turns like a cruise ship having second thoughts.

We tore out of the museum lot in a series of lurches, sideswiped a decorative cactus, and ended up in the middle of Broadway Street with the speedometer climbing and Xolotl clinging to the dashboard with his claws.

"You are driving like a dog in a car," he said.

"Aren't *you* a dog?"

"I'm a god of the dead. We drive much better. We are just very patient about the dying."

"Mateo," Danny said from the seat behind me, in the flat voice of someone watching something terrible in the rearview mirror. "They're running."

I glanced up at the big mirror. The tzitzimime were pouring off the museum roof and loping down the street, legs bending the wrong way, covering ground faster than any car. Their star-lights flickered like Christmas lights in a thunderstorm.

"How long till they catch us?" I yelled.

"At this speed?" Xolotl said. "Forty seconds."

"At *what* speed?"

"This one. It's a bus."

I drove faster. We blew through a red light. A man in a Spurs jersey at the crosswalk dropped his nachos and stared.

A thump came from above.

Then another. Then a long scraping sound, like someone dragging a rake across the roof.

Four black, star-speckled claws punched through the ceiling, directly above Danny's head, and peeled the metal back like the lid of a sardine can.

Danny looked up. A grinning face the color of a dead moon looked back down.

"Hi," Danny said, with great dignity.

"Eat the loud one," whispered the face.

I'll be honest, I froze. I wish I could tell you I did something heroic. But my brain had stopped at *face in the ceiling* and gone for a coffee break.

It was Danny who moved. He grabbed the emergency fire extinguisher bolted to the wall and swung it up at the tzitzimitl like a baseball bat. It connected with a sound like a gong. The demon recoiled. But more claws were coming. Two, three, five. The roof was coming off in strips.

"Mateo!" Xolotl snapped. "The sun is in you. That's what he fears. Call it!"

"I don't know how!"

"Say the name of your day!"

"I don't even know what day I was..." I stopped. Because I did know. Somewhere deep, in the same place I know my own phone number without thinking, a word had been sitting there my whole life.

"*Ce Acatl,*" I said. One Reed.

Nothing happened.

Then Danny's head turned. Slowly, like it was being pulled on a string, he looked straight at me, as if I'd called his name instead of mine.

His whole body went rigid. His eyes rolled up to white. The air in the bus went thick and electric, and every hair on my arms stood straight up.

"Oh no," Danny said faintly. "Oh *no*. I think I'm about to..."

The clear blue Texas sky above San Antonio went black in the space of a heartbeat. A crack of thunder shook every window on the street. And then it *poured*, a wall of water so heavy it flattened the tzitzimime and sent them tumbling down Broadway in a river of rain and starlight.

Through the hole in the roof, rain hammered down on Danny's head.

He sat there, soaked to the bone, hands out at his sides, staring at his own fingers like they'd betrayed him.

I stared at him. My best friend since second grade had just made the sky open up, and the scariest part was how normal he still looked, same crooked backpack, same wet sneakers.

"Mateo," Danny said. "I did not do that on purpose."

Xolotl's head turned very slowly toward him.

"That," said the god of lightning, "was not me."

"I know it wasn't you," Danny said. "It was *me*, apparently."

"That," Xolotl went on, more quietly, "is the problem."

I wanted to ask what he meant. I wanted to ask a lot of things. But a road sign flashed past that I recognized, and every part of my body clenched, because I knew exactly where my feet were taking this bus.

"I know a place," I said. "It's safe."

"How do you know?"

"Because it has a lock on the door, a statue of the Virgin Mary, and my abuela."

Abuela's house is a little yellow bungalow on Zarzamora Street, with a chain-link fence, a lemon tree that produces roughly four lemons per decade, and, as I discovered that afternoon, a bus-sized hole in the fence where I introduced my vehicle to her front yard.

I turned off the engine and the bus stopped on its own, with a sigh, like it was relieved to be done with me.

The rain had followed us the whole way, though it was thinning now into a gentle drizzle. Danny sat soaking wet in the back seat, staring at nothing. Xolotl had one paw over his eyes.

"I will never complain about the underworld's traffic again," he said.

I'd been to this house a thousand times. I knew the crack in the third porch step and the squeak of the screen door. But sitting there in a ruined bus, with rain dripping through the roof, it looked like a house from somebody else's photograph, a place I'd only ever seen from the outside.

The front door opened.

My abuela stood on the porch. Five feet tall in her slippers, in her faded blue housedress, with her gray hair pinned up in a braid. In her left hand she held a smoking clay bowl of copal incense. In her right hand she held a very large, very ancient obsidian knife.

She looked at the bus. She looked at the hole in her fence. She looked at the god-dog in the passenger seat, who gave her a weak little wave.

"Mateo Quetzal Ibarra," she said, in the voice she uses when I've tracked mud on her floor. "*Ya era hora*."

It's about time.

Chapter Four: My Grandmother Has Been Feeding the Sun

Abuela made us take our shoes off.

I want you to understand that a god had just tried to eat us, a bus was parked in her rosebushes, and the first thing she said after *ya era hora* was, "Zapatos. *Afuera.*"

So we stood on the porch in our socks, dripping, while she examined the three of us like a customs agent. Danny got a long look. Xolotl got a longer one.

"Doña Remedios," Xolotl said, with a little bow. It was the most formal I'd ever seen him, and he was wearing a tie.

"*Perro,*" said Abuela. "You are three weeks late."

"The traffic..."

"Three weeks. I put the water out." She pointed her obsidian knife at a dented steel bowl at the end of the porch, the one I'd always assumed was for the stray dog who showed up every few months and left again without so much as a thank-you. "Every night. For forty years. You think a stray drinks from the same bowl for forty years?"

Xolotl's ears went flat. "I did not know it was for me."

"Who else would it be for?"

I looked at the bowl. I looked at the god. "You've been *drinking out of Abuela's porch bowl*?"

"It was very good water," said Xolotl, with as much dignity as a dog in a tie can summon.

Her kitchen smelled like cinnamon and smoke, same as always. She sat Danny at the table with a towel and a mug of champurrado, put a second mug in front of me, and set the knife on the counter next to the salt shaker like it lived there.

Maybe it did. I had a lot of new questions about my grandmother.

"Okay," I said. "Start talking."

"Eat first."

"Abuela."

"Mateo Quetzal." She sat down across from me, small and straight-backed, and folded her hands. "The mirror at the museum. You looked in it."

"How did you..."

"Because I have kept you from every mirror like that one for twelve years." She said it like she was reading me a grocery list. "Your father thought I was *loca*. 'Mamá, why is there no mirror in the hallway? Why is the bathroom mirror so small?'"

"I thought that was feng shui," Danny said into his mug.

"I thought you were just bad at decorating," I added.

"It was *protection*," Abuela said. "And it worked, until your school took you to a museum I did not know was there." Her jaw tightened. "I read every permission slip. That one said *Mesoamerican Antiquities*. I thought it was about *pots*."

I'll be honest: the thing that finally broke my brain wasn't the god, or the star demons, or the storm. It was picturing my abuela, in her blue housedress, squinting at a permission slip and missing the one that mattered.

"Why?" My voice came out smaller than I wanted. "Why did you hide the mirrors? Why does he want me?"

Abuela looked at Xolotl. Xolotl looked at the floor.

"You were born on the day *Ce Acatl*," she said. "One Reed. It is the day sign of Quetzalcoatl, the Feathered Serpent, who is the brother and the enemy of the Smoking Mirror. Their war is older than your grandfather's grandfather." She reached over and touched my cheek with a rough, warm hand. "I named you Quetzal on purpose, mijo. And he heard me say it."

It was quiet. Danny's mug had stopped halfway to his mouth.

"So I'm a... what, a reincarnated snake?"

"I did not say that."

"Then what am I?"

"I do not know." She said it flatly, without flinching, and somehow that was scarier than if she'd had an answer. "Some of it I do not know. Some of it I will not say in front of a dog. But I know that on the night you were born the sun flickered, and I know who was watching when it did."

Then she turned to Danny.

She didn't speak at first. She just stood up, walked around the table, and put her hand flat on top of his wet head, the way you'd check a loaf of bread. Danny held perfectly still, like a kid being scanned by a very kind airport.

"The storm," she said. "That was you."

"I'd like to say it wasn't," said Danny. "But everyone saw."

"It was not *Tláloc*." She frowned. "I know Tláloc's rain. It smells like wet earth and corn. This one..." She sniffed, and her eyebrows climbed. "This one smells like iron. Hot iron."

"That's what *I* said," Xolotl muttered.

"Where is your family from, mijo?"

"Sugar Land," said Danny.

"*Before* Sugar Land."

"Also Sugar Land. We're very committed."

Abuela's mouth twitched, but only for a second. She patted his head twice and let go. "*Ay,* niño. You did not come from anyone I know." She said it gently, without suspicion, but it was not exactly a comfort. "That does not mean you are a danger. It means you are a *surprise*. And in my experience, the gods do not make surprises by accident."

Danny stared at his champurrado like it might have answers. "That," he said, "is the most terrifying thing anyone's said to me today. And I've been chased by *star demons*."

It was late afternoon by the time Abuela finally let Xolotl sit down, and the rain had stopped completely, as if Danny's storm had decided to behave itself. Danny had fallen asleep with his head on the table. I could hear the old clock ticking over the stove.

"There's one more thing," I said.

Abuela didn't look up. She was at the sink, scrubbing a clay bowl that was already clean.

"Mr. Xavier... Xolotl... said the offerings stopped. He said that's why the sun's failing. But you told me when I was eight that somebody has to feed it." I heard my own voice crack. "That wasn't a story. You were telling me what you *do*."

The water kept running.

"Every morning," she said, so quietly I almost missed it. "Before you wake up. Copal, marigolds, a little of whatever we are eating. I set it on the roof, facing east, and I say the words my grandmother said to me." Her shoulders moved, just slightly. "I am the last one in this city who does. As far as I know, I am the last one anywhere."

I tried to picture it. My abuela, five feet tall in her slippers, climbing a ladder at dawn for twelve years, holding a candle up to the sky because nobody else would.

"This morning," Abuela said, "it did not take."

She turned around. Her face was calm. Her hands were shaking.

"The sun is tired, Mateo. And I am tired. And in the middle of all that tiredness, a dog and two boys and a stolen school bus have arrived at my door." She dried her hands on her apron and, for the first time all day, she smiled, a small, worn-out, real smile. "So I think it is time we found out what you were born to do."

On the counter, beside the salt and the obsidian knife, the little flame in the clay lamp on her altar flickered once, twice, and went out.

Chapter Five: The Smoke Goes the Wrong Way

Abuela's roof access is a ladder bolted to the back wall of the house, and for twelve years I thought it was for cleaning gutters.

"Mateo, you first," she said. "I want to see you don't fall."

"That's comforting."

"It is not meant to be."

The roof was flat, patched with tar, and smelled like old sun. In the middle, facing east, sat a clay bowl on a ring of bricks, with a single marigold wilting beside it. Abuela climbed up behind me, slow, one hand on her hip, and I realized I'd never once wondered how she could get up here every morning at that age.

"Look," she said.

I looked. The copal she'd lit that morning had burned down to a black crust. The marigolds were gray, dry as paper, and curled in on themselves like they'd been dead for weeks. And the smoke, a thin, stubborn thread that she'd relit just to show me, wouldn't rise. It crept over the lip of the bowl and ran down the bricks like water, then pooled on the tar and slid toward the west, away from the sun.

"Smoke goes up," I said.

"Smoke goes up," Abuela agreed. "Every day for forty years. Today it ran away."

I stood there for a while. The wind moved the marigold petals around, and I couldn't think of a single thing to say that wouldn't be stupid.

"Your knees," I said finally.

"What about them?"

"You've been climbing that ladder every morning. Since before I was born." My voice did

something weird. "You could have told me. I could have helped."

"You would have laughed."

I opened my mouth to argue, and closed it again, because I had. I'd laughed so hard I got milk up my nose.

"I'm sorry," I said.

Abuela put her hand on the back of my neck, the way she did when I was little and had a fever. "You were eight," she said. "You were *supposed* to laugh. That was the whole point of me doing it."

We stayed on the roof a minute longer. Neither of us said anything.

Danny was awake when we got back to the kitchen, sitting very straight, with an expression I'd only seen on him during pop quizzes.

"Okay," he said. "I've been thinking."

"That's never good," said Xolotl, from under the table.

"The mirror was in a museum, right? And a museum doesn't just *own* a mirror like that. The placard said 'on loan from a private collection.' So somebody gave it to them. On purpose." He looked around the table. "And I keep thinking about the field trip."

"What about it?" I asked.

"It was supposed to be the Alamo." Danny tapped the table. "Remember? Ms. Delgado had the permission slips for the Alamo in September. Then last Thursday she hands out new ones. 'Museum of Mesoamerican Antiquities, new exhibit.' Nobody asked for that. Nobody even knew it existed."

Abuela had gone very still. "I read that slip," she said slowly. "It came home on Friday. It was printed on *thick* paper."

"Thick paper," Danny said. "Who prints a permission slip on thick paper?"

I want to say that I figured this out, because I'm the main character. I did not. Danny, who'd been chased by star demons and rained on in a school bus, was the only person in the room who'd noticed a detail about stationery.

"So somebody *wanted* us there," I said.

"Somebody wanted *you* there," said Danny. "I just like the Alamo."

Xolotl climbed out from under the table. His ears were low. "I felt the mirror stir three weeks ago," he said. "I could not tell where. I assumed it was a collector's cellar, a dusty crate. I did not think to look in a *museum*." He sneezed. "I have not had a good three weeks."

"Nobody has," said Abuela, drying her hands.

It took Danny about ninety seconds on his phone to find the exhibit page. In small gray print at the bottom, under a photo of the obsidian disk, it said:

Generously lent by the Valdivia Trust, San Antonio, TX.

Abuela read it twice. Then she read it a third time, with her lips moving.

"I do not know that name," she said.

She said it quietly, but I'd heard her say a lot of things in my life, and this was the first time she'd ever sounded frightened by a stranger.

"That's good, right?" I asked. "If it's not one of the people you know?"

"It would be better," said Abuela, "if it were someone I knew. Then I would know what they wanted."

Danny scrolled. "There's an office. King William district, by appointment only." He frowned. "It's open until six."

"What time is it?" I asked.

Danny checked his phone. Checked the clock above the stove. Checked it again.

"Four forty-seven," he said.

"That's what it was when we got here," said Abuela.

Nobody said anything.

We walked outside, all four of us, and stood in the yard with our hands over our eyes. The sun hung a hand's width above the roofline, thick and orange, exactly where it had been when I'd climbed off the bus. Danny's phone and the stove clock still said 4:47. The shadows on the lawn hadn't moved. Somewhere down the street, a dog was barking, and its bark sounded like it was on a loop.

"It stopped," I whispered. "It's not moving."

"It is moving," Xolotl said quietly. "Just slower. Every hour, it will move a little slower. Until..." He didn't finish.

"Until it doesn't," said Danny.

Abuela walked to the porch, picked up her purse and her car keys, and slipped on her good shoes.

"Mateo," she said. "Danny. Perro. Get in the Buick."

"I thought we were making an appointment," I said.

"We are," said Abuela. "We are making one very *loudly*."

She drove. I want you to know that an eighty-year-old woman in a faded blue housedress can reach thirty-eight miles an hour in a residential zone with a god in the back seat and a stolen school bus abandoned in her rosebushes, and she did it with her chin up and both hands on the wheel. In the rearview mirror, I watched her house shrink behind us.

And above it, hanging in the same place it had been for an hour, the sun held perfectly still, like it was waiting for something, and I had a bad feeling it was me.

Chapter Six: The Lock That Was Also a Door

The Valdivia Trust was a gray limestone house in the King William district, with a wraparound porch, a brass plaque the size of a cookie sheet, and an enormous live oak that had grown around the iron fence like it was trying to hug it to death.

Abuela parked the Buick across two spots and one flower bed.

"Abuela."

"It is an emergency, Mateo."

"The flower bed did not know that."

Inside, the house was cool and dim and smelled like beeswax and old paper. There was no receptionist, no gift shop, no pamphlet rack. Just a long hallway lined with framed maps and a staircase going up into shadow. Every mirror in the place, and there were a lot of them, was covered with a black cloth.

"They are hiding mirrors too," Abuela murmured. "*Ay,* I like her already."

"Who?"

"Whoever lives here."

A voice came down the stairs, dry and unhurried. "I would've been disappointed if you'd knocked."

The woman who followed it was somewhere in her sixties, small and straight-backed, in a gray cardigan with the sleeves pushed up past her elbows. She had reading glasses pushed into her silver hair and an ink stain on her thumb. She looked like the kind of person who got mad at librarians for shelving things wrong.

"Ofelia Valdivia," she said. "I'm the Trust. Or what's left of it." Her eyes went to Xolotl, who was standing very stiffly in the hallway with his tie askew. "You're the dog."

"I am a god of..."

"I know what you are. Sit." Xolotl sat. I'll admit that I enjoyed that more than I should have.

Her eyes moved to Abuela. "Doña Remedios Ibarra. We've never met, but my father mentioned your name. He said there was someone on the south side who still did the dawn offerings."

"He knew of me?" Abuela's voice had gone thin.

"He kept a list," said Ofelia. "It was a short one."

She led us into a study at the back, a room full of ledgers and glass-fronted cabinets, with a long wooden table where a single lamp burned. On the wall, over the fireplace, was a huge framed document written in brown ink in a language I couldn't read.

Danny, to his credit, didn't stare at the document. He stared at the doorframe. Little iron nails had been driven into the wood all the way around it, hundreds of them, rusty and bent, and as Danny walked under them, every one of them began to hum. It was the sound of a wet finger on the rim of a glass, one that built and built, and every nail was leaning toward him.

He stopped. The nails stopped.

"I swear I didn't touch anything," said Danny.

"I know you didn't." Ofelia was watching him with a strange, careful expression. "Those nails are older than this house. They were meant to ring when something dangerous crossed the door. They've never rung for a child." She tilted her head. "They don't seem frightened of you, Mr. Okafor. They seem to be *greeting* you."

"Great," Danny said weakly. "Everyone keeps telling me I'm special, and nobody tells me why."

"How do you know my name?" he added, a beat later.

"The school sent a permission slip," said Ofelia. "To me, as a courtesy. Your name was on

the roster." She pulled out a chair for him. "Sit down, please. Everyone sit down."

It took her twenty minutes to tell us the story, and she told it the way my favorite teacher tells things, in order, without hurrying, and with no wasted words.

The mirror had been in her family for almost three hundred years.

"My ancestor Tomás Valdivia was a clerk for the Spanish crown," she said. "He wasn't a good man. He took the mirror from a temple in Puebla, and a woman followed him all the way to San Antonio and told him what it was. He didn't believe her. By the time he did, he was dying, and the mirror had already killed his brother." She folded her hands. "My family has guarded it ever since. Not because we're clever. Because we owed a debt, and a debt like that doesn't go away. It gets inherited."

"What does the mirror *do*?" Danny asked.

"Our records call it a *cerradura*." She glanced at me. "A lock."

Xolotl's ears flicked.

"A lock?" I said. "Xolotl said it was a door."

"It's both," said Xolotl, a little too quickly.

Ofelia raised an eyebrow. Abuela raised the other one. The room got very quiet.

"Doors open two ways," Xolotl said stiffly. "Locks are closed doors. It is a matter of *perspective*." He stared at his paws. "I did not lie. I simply did not give the full lecture."

I wanted to push, but I could see Abuela watching him with her lips pressed tight, and I knew that look. It was the look she gave me when I said I'd already done my homework. I decided to let her handle it. Later. In private. With the knife.

"The records say the mirror was built to keep something *in*," Ofelia went on. "For three hundred years it did its job. Then, twelve years ago, my father started acting strange."

She went to a drawer and drew out a single sheet of paper, brown at the edges, folded in thirds.

"He died that winter. This arrived three weeks ago, in the mail, in an envelope with a postmark from the week he passed. I don't know who mailed it. It's his handwriting."

She laid it flat on the table. The ink was faded, but I could read it:

Ofelia. On the third week of October, lend the mirror to the new exhibit at the museum. Do not ask why. The boy will come.

Under that, in smaller letters, as if the writer's hand had slipped:

Forgive me. I could not find another way.

Nobody said anything for a long time.

"My father spent forty years guarding that mirror," said Ofelia quietly. "Then he wrote me a letter telling me to hand it to the one person it was never supposed to touch. For three weeks I've asked myself whether he was betrayed, or whether he was the betrayer." She looked straight at me. "I still don't know. I sent the mirror to the museum because it was the last thing he ever asked me to do. I don't know if that makes me loyal or a fool."

I wanted to say something comforting. I'm twelve. I said, "Maybe both?"

For some reason, that made her smile. Small and tired, but real.

"There's one more thing," Ofelia said. "I called the museum an hour ago. They told me the display case is empty."

"Empty?" said Xolotl.

"The security cameras show it clearly. At 4:46 this afternoon, the mirror simply... wasn't there. No one touched the case. No alarm went off." She turned her wristwatch around so we could see the face, and I felt my stomach drop, because it said 4:47, and it hadn't moved. "One minute before the clocks stopped."

"Then it's still *loose,*" said Abuela.

"It's not loose," said Ofelia. "That's what I keep trying to tell you. I don't think the mirror is the problem anymore. I think it was only ever the lock."

Underneath us, from somewhere deep in the floor, there came a sound.

Tap. Tap. Tap.

I knew that sound. I'd never forget it. It was fingernails on a tabletop, patient and slow.

But the mirror was gone, and the sound wasn't coming from a mirror.

It was coming from the house's cellar.

Ofelia went pale. "That," she whispered, "is *not* the mirror. We've never had anything else down there."

Every iron nail in the doorframe began to hum.

Chapter Seven: Danny Gets a Name He Never Gave

"We are not going down there," said Ofelia.

"We are absolutely going down there," said Abuela.

They had been saying versions of this for about four minutes. We were standing at the top of the cellar stairs, which began behind a door in the pantry that Ofelia swore she had never seen open. It had been painted over so many times that the paint was thicker than the door. Under the paint, someone had scratched a little spiral into the wood. Every few seconds, from somewhere below us, the knocking came up the stairwell like a slow heartbeat.

Tap. Tap. Tap.

"My family has lived in this house for three hundred years," Ofelia said. "My father never mentioned a cellar. There is no cellar on the blueprints. I have *checked*."

"The blueprints also don't mention a mirror that unlocks the end of the world," said Abuela.

"That is a fair point."

"Then we are going."

I tugged Xolotl's sleeve. He'd been silent since the knocking started, which was unusual for him. He sat on the top step with his ears low, listening.

"I know that rhythm," he said quietly.

"From where?"

"Not from where. From *whom*." He didn't look at me. "It is the knock of someone who does not expect an answer."

"That's the most depressing thing you've ever said."

"It was not meant to be cheerful."

Danny was standing a little behind us, hugging his elbows. I noticed it first in his shoes. He wasn't looking at the cellar. He was looking at the iron nails someone had hammered into the pantry doorframe, and they had started to hum again, leaning in his direction like iron filings toward a magnet.

"I think I should go first," Danny said.

Everybody turned.

"I don't *want* to," he said quickly. "I'm just saying the nails keep picking me. So if something's down there that's going to react to somebody, it's probably going to be me,

and I'd rather know ahead of time than get surprised by a stranger."

Abuela looked at him for a long moment. Then she took the flashlight from Ofelia, handed it to Danny, and put her own hand on his shoulder.

"I go with you," she said. "Mateo behind us. The dog behind him. Ofelia last, to run if she must."

"I'm *not* going to run," said Ofelia.

"You will be the fastest," said Abuela kindly.

The cellar stairs were stone, worn into dips in the middle by a lot of feet, none of them recent. It smelled like cold limestone and something else, something dry and old and faintly sweet, like a closet full of someone else's clothes.

At the bottom, the cellar was just a cellar. Shelves of jars, none of them labeled. A rusted bicycle. A crate of Christmas ornaments. A dusty armchair with a crocheted blanket folded over one arm, like someone had sat there recently and gone upstairs for coffee.

Then Danny swung the flashlight to the far wall and the beam found the door.

It was iron, black and heavy, set into the stone like it had been there before the house. There was no handle on our side. No keyhole. Just a thick horizontal bar bolted across the middle, wrapped in what looked like dried marigold stems and strips of faded red cloth.

Tap. Tap. Tap.

The sound came from behind it. Right behind it. Like whoever was knocking had their knuckles an inch from the metal.

Danny walked toward it. One step. Two. On the third step, the knocking stopped.

The silence was worse.

Danny stood completely still. Then, very slowly, he took one step back.

Tap. Tap. Tap.

He stepped forward.

Silence.

"It's doing it on purpose," Danny whispered. "It knows where I am."

"Of course it does," said a voice.

It came from the other side of the door, and I'll be honest, it wasn't what I expected. It was dry and quiet and tired, like a very old teacher at the end of a very long day. It didn't sound like a monster. It sounded like someone who'd been waiting in a hallway for a bus that was late.

"*Danny,*" the voice said. "Oh, thank the *sky.* They finally sent the right one."

Danny went pale. I'd never seen anybody go pale that fast.

"I never told you my name," he said.

"No," the voice agreed gently. "You never did."

Nobody moved. Abuela's hand was on Danny's shoulder. Ofelia had one hand pressed over her mouth. Xolotl had gotten up off the stairs and was staring at the iron door, his ember eyes wide.

"Who are you?" I called.

"You don't need to know that yet, little Quetzal." The voice sounded amused. "I'm very pleased to meet you, by the way. You're smaller than I expected."

"I get that a lot," I said, and I'd swear Danny almost laughed.

"You're the one who's been knocking," Abuela said, in her flat, no-nonsense voice. "What do you want?"

"What I've always wanted. I want to stop knocking."

"That's all?"

"For three hundred years, Doña Remedios, that has been *all*."

It was the first time I'd ever heard a god-sized silence come from something that wasn't a god. I looked at Xolotl. He was staring at the door the way you'd stare at a ghost you recognized.

Danny took a deep breath. He lowered the flashlight. And then he did something none of the adults had thought to do.

"Are you hurt?" he asked.

The silence that followed lasted so long I thought the thing behind the door had gone away.

"No one," the voice said at last, and it had gotten a lot smaller, "has asked me that in a very long time."

"So are you?"

"Not in the way you mean." A pause. "I'm only tired. And a little lonely. And I'm very, very sorry that you've inherited this."

"Inherited what?" Danny asked.

"That," said the voice, "will have to wait."

It took us another ten minutes to get anything useful out of it. The thing behind the door answered questions the way Abuela answers my questions about my report card: with as little as possible, and only when it was sure you could handle it.

But here's what we learned.

The mirror upstairs had been a lock on one door. This iron door was a second lock, on a different door. The mirror had kept something *in* for three hundred years, and the thing behind the iron door had been the one keeping the mirror *there*.

"A watcher," Ofelia whispered. "My family never knew."

"Your family was never supposed to," said the voice. "That was the point."

When someone took the mirror out of its case at 4:46, the watcher's job ended. And the sun, which had been holding steady only because both locks were closed, finally slipped.

"Whoever removed the mirror knew exactly what they were doing," the voice said. "They didn't open this door. They didn't free me. They left me exactly where I was." It paused. "That is what frightens me. If they wanted me gone, I'd be gone. They wanted me to stay here, listening, while the sun slowed."

"Why?" I asked.

"So that I'd be too weak to stop what comes next."

"Which is what?"

"I don't *know* what comes next, Mateo. That's the whole trouble." The voice sounded suddenly, painfully old. "I only know that the slower the sun moves, the thinner this door gets. And when it finishes stopping..." It hesitated. "It opens on its own. And I cannot promise what I'll be when it does."

"Can we open it now?" Danny asked, very quietly.

"You could."

"Should we?"

"No."

Danny let out a breath I think he'd been holding since the stairs. "Okay," he said. "Then I'm not going to."

"Thank you," said the voice, and it sounded so relieved that I felt a strange, cold ache in my chest. "That is the first sensible decision anyone has made about me in three centuries."

We backed away from the door one slow step at a time. Just before we reached the stairs, I heard it, soft as breath through iron:

"Hurry, Danny. Please."

Abuela waited until we were all back in the study, with the cellar door shut and Ofelia's kettle on, before she turned to Xolotl.

"Perro. Sit."

He sat. He was a god and had been alive for five hundred years, and he sat like a dog who knew he'd chewed a shoe.

"You told the boy it was a door," she said. "You knew it was a lock. And I think you knew about the one downstairs too, or at least suspected."

"I suspected," Xolotl said.

"Which part were you hoping he wouldn't ask about?"

For a long time he didn't answer. The kettle began to whistle. Ofelia took it off the burner without a word.

"I have watched a brave child walk into a lock before," Xolotl said finally.

Nobody spoke.

"He was born on the same day. He was twelve. He was very kind, and very certain, and he thought he could fix it by being good." His voice cracked on the last word. "I was too late to stop him. I decided that if I ever found another One Reed, I would make sure he never learned what the lock needed. I would take him away from the mirror before he ever looked into it."

"And you were three weeks late," said Abuela.

"I was one *minute* late." He stared at his paws. "I stood in that museum for three hours. I told

myself I would walk you out of that room before you reached the case. And you looked into the mirror, and you screamed, and I thought: *it is happening again*."

I'd never seen a god cry. It turns out it looks like a dog trying not to.

"It was not my decision to make," said Abuela. Her voice was gentle, but it didn't bend. "You did not ask him. You did not ask me."

"No."

"It cost him the truth. And it cost us time."

"Yes."

"Then you will tell us everything from now on. Even the parts you think we cannot bear."

"Even those," said Xolotl, very softly.

"*Bueno*." Abuela patted his head once, like you'd pat a stubborn mule, and looked away. "Drink your tea."

I looked at Danny to see if he'd caught any of that. He hadn't. He was staring at his hands in the lamplight, turning them over and over.

"It knew my name," he said. "I never said it. And it was *relieved* to see me." He looked up at me, and his eyes were enormous. "Mateo, why would anything be relieved to see me?"

I didn't have an answer. I wanted one more than I've ever wanted anything.

Upstairs, behind a locked iron door, something that had been alone for three hundred years started knocking again. This time it was only once.

Tap.

Like it was saying goodnight.

Chapter Eight: Brock Has a Theory

Abuela dropped us at the museum with the engine running.

"Fifteen minutes," she said. "If you are not out, I come in."

"With the knife?"

"With the Buick."

Behind her, Ofelia sat very straight in the passenger seat, clutching a ledger. She'd spent

the whole drive muttering in Spanish about three hundred years of paperwork, which I think was her way of not screaming.

The museum parking lot was a disaster. Yellow tape stretched across the entrance, and half the cars had been left at angles, like their owners had fainted. A police officer sat on the hood of a patrol car, staring at his watch, and for a second he moved his arm so slowly I thought I was imagining it.

I wasn't. The whole lot was moving at the speed of syrup. A pigeon flapping near the fountain lifted off its wings one beat at a time. Even my own heartbeat felt a little behind.

"It is slower than an hour ago," Xolotl said quietly. "Do not stand still too long."

"What happens if I stand still?"

"I do not know, and I would like to keep it that way."

Our class was sitting on the curb by the front doors, waiting for parents who were late because every traffic light in San Antonio was stuck on red. Ms. Delgado was counting heads with a pencil and getting a different number every time. And at the end of the row, eating the last Takis from a crumpled bag, sat Brock.

He saw us before we could duck.

"*Ibarra*." He stood up and pointed a red-stained finger at Xolotl. "That dog was *in the museum*."

"What dog?" I said.

"The dog in the tie."

Danny, next to me, made a small, strangled noise.

"I'm not crazy," Brock went on, which is exactly what people say right before they sound crazy. "I saw a dog in a tie standing behind the guide. Then the guide wasn't there. Then I fell asleep, and I woke up, and my sandwich was *gone*." He leaned closer. "And I never lose a sandwich."

"It's a different dog," said Danny.

"It's got the *same tie*."

Xolotl cleared his throat politely. "I assure you," he said in his gravel-and-honey voice, "I am merely a service animal."

Brock stared at him. Then at me. Then, very slowly, he sat back down and put the Takis bag over his head.

"I'm going to pretend I didn't hear that," said a muffled voice.

"Good plan," I said.

The museum lobby was dim and cold and quiet. The air smelled like old pennies, same as before, but now there was something else underneath, like the smell of a room where someone had just stopped talking.

The exhibit hall was worse. The brochure rack I'd knocked over was still on its side. The glass case at the end of the hall stood open and empty, a clean rectangle of dust where the obsidian mirror had been. On the placard, somebody had set a single wilted marigold.

"That's new," said Danny.

"It is an offering," said Xolotl. "Or an apology."

"For what?"

"I would like to find out."

We went through the door marked STAFF ONLY, because I'm twelve and a god told me it was fine. Past a break room and a supply closet and a very sad fern, we reached a small office with a nameplate on the door:

DR. LEONARDO QUIROGA, CURATOR

Inside, it looked like someone had left in the middle of a sentence. A mug of cold coffee. A stack of thick, cream-colored paper on the desk, the same paper as my permission slip. A framed photograph of a smiling man in a suit standing next to a giant stone calendar, with his arm around a very small, very serious little girl.

"That's Ofelia's father," said Danny, pointing to a second photo. "Remember the face from the study? He's in this one too, in the back."

"Quiroga knew him," I said.

"Knew him *well,*" said Xolotl, sniffing a pile of folders. "These are letters. Dozens of them."

Danny picked up the top sheet and read it out loud, slowly, like it might bite.

"*Dr. Quiroga: The mirror belongs to the people who made it, not to a trust that stole it. You have my permission to display it publicly. Tomás Valdivia's descendants have kept their secret for three hundred years, and it is time the truth was told.*"

"Whose signature?" I asked.

Danny turned it over. "Ofelia's father."

I stared at him. "That's not possible. He's been dead for twelve years."

"The date says *last Tuesday.*"

Nobody said anything. The sad fern dropped a leaf.

Xolotl found the answering machine first. It was one of those ancient ones, the kind with an actual tape, and a little red light was blinking on the front.

"Do not touch that," he said.

I touched it.

The message began with a click, and then a man's voice, low and shaky and very close to the phone.

"*Ofelia. It's Leo.*" A long, ragged breath. "*I have it. I'm standing in front of the case. I took the glass off myself, nobody's here, I thought... it would be heavier than this. It's so* light." A pause. "*He said the sun would only pause. That's what he told me, Ofelia. He said it would only pause for a moment, long enough to return it to where it came from, and then everything would go back to normal. He said no one would be hurt.*"

Another pause. Somewhere behind him, faintly, I heard a sound I knew.

Tap. Tap. Tap.

"*I think I made a mistake,*" said Dr. Quiroga, so softly I almost didn't catch it. "*Forgive me. I'm going to...*"

The tape clicked off.

The little red light stopped blinking.

None of us spoke. Danny's hand was pressed over his mouth. Xolotl's ears had gone flat against his skull.

I looked at the thick cream paper. At the photograph of a dead man smiling with his arm around a little girl. At the date on the letter that said *last Tuesday.*

"Somebody wrote that letter," I said. "Somebody who's been dead for twelve years."

"Or something wearing his handwriting," said Xolotl.

Outside, beyond the walls, I heard Abuela's horn honk three times, slow and long, like a foghorn in syrup.

"Fifteen minutes," said Danny.

"I think we need all of them," I said.

Chapter Nine: Thirty-One Names

Ofelia's father kept his list in a ledger so big it needed its own table.

It was bound in cracked green leather and spread open across the study, and every page was ruled into columns in the same careful handwriting: a name, a city, a name of the person who'd taught them, and a date. At the top of the first page, the ink had gone brown.

"Four hundred and six names," said Ofelia. She had a pencil behind each ear and one in her mouth, and she'd been counting for twenty minutes. "Dating back to my grandfather's grandfather. Every one of them did the dawn offerings. Every one of them is in this book because my family wanted to know who was still keeping the sun moving."

"How many are still crossed out?" asked Danny.

"Three hundred and seventy-five."

Nobody said anything. Outside the study window, the sun hung at the same exact angle it had been at for what my body insisted was about six hours. A bee hovering near the glass had been stuck mid-wingbeat for a good minute, like the world was buffering.

"That leaves thirty-one," I said.

"Thirty-one people," Ofelia agreed. "In the whole country. Maybe in the whole world."

Abuela put her finger on a line near the bottom of the last page. I leaned over her shoulder and read it.

Remedios Ibarra. San Antonio, Zarzamora St. Taught by her mother. Still faithful.

The words *still faithful* had been underlined twice.

"He knew about you," Ofelia said softly. "He was *watching* you, Doña Remedios. All these years. Not to harm you. To make sure someone was keeping the fire lit."

"I know," said Abuela. "A man in a gray hat used to stand across the street on Sundays. I thought he sold insurance."

It was Danny who noticed the last entry.

He'd been quiet since the cellar. He wasn't the kind of quiet that means a person is sulking, more like someone carrying something heavy up a staircase and trying not to spill it. But he was a kid who noticed things, and he'd been staring at the bottom of the final page for a full minute before he reached out and touched it.

"Um," he said. "Is this supposed to be wet?"

Ofelia took the pencil out of her mouth. "What?"

Danny held up his thumb. A black smear of ink lay across the pad of it, bright and glossy.

Everyone leaned in. Under Abuela's name, in a space that had been empty ten minutes earlier, someone had added a new line. The handwriting was the same careful, slanting script as every entry in the book. But the ink was still shining. It had been written *just now*.

Joaquín Ibarra is not in the mirror. He is below. Ask the dog.
—A.V.

Ofelia's face drained of color. She grabbed the edge of the table.

"That's my father's hand," she said. "That's his *initials*. Aurelio Valdivia. He's been dead for twelve years. I buried him, I..." She stopped. "That ink is *wet*."

I looked at Xolotl. For the first time since I'd met him, he looked like he was going to be sick.

"A man who goes through a lock," he said slowly, "does not always die."

"You think he's *alive* in there?" I asked.

"I think time in that place does not behave. A letter written twelve years ago can arrive last Tuesday. A line of ink can dry slowly enough to be wet today." He swallowed. "I think Aurelio went into the mirror looking for another way. And I think he found something."

"And Joaquín?" said Danny. "Who's Joaquín?"

Nobody answered. Abuela had gone completely still.

Then she said, so quietly I barely caught it:

"My brother."

I stared at her.

"My little brother," said Abuela. She was still looking at the page, and her fingertip had moved to a different line, higher up the margin, where a name had been written in black and then crossed out in red, in a different pen, by a different hand. *J. Ibarra, One Reed.* "He was

twelve. I was sixteen. He looked into a mirror at a museum in Mexico City and he was gone before supper."

My knees did something strange. I sat down on the nearest chair.

"You never told me you had a brother."

"No."

"You told me about La Llorona. You told me about the sun. You *didn't tell me you had a brother.*"

"Because you would have asked," said Abuela, "where he went."

"I'm asking now!"

"I know." She finally looked at me. Her eyes were wet, but her voice was steady, the way it gets when she's carrying a very hot pot to the table. "I wanted one more year of you laughing, Mateo. That's all it was. One more year of you being a little boy. I thought I had time."

I didn't know what to say. So I did the only thing I could think of. I got up, walked around the table, and put my arms around my abuela, who was five feet tall in her good shoes. She smelled like cinnamon and copal. She held on to me like I was the only handle in a very large world.

Behind us, I heard Xolotl whisper, "*Forgive me,*" and I don't think he was talking to either of us.

"There's a telephone number," said Ofelia, a little later, turning to the margin of Abuela's page. "Next to the first entry in Mexico City. *Doña Citlali Xochitl.* She's the only one on the list with a number that works."

Danny had his phone out before anyone asked. "Speaker," he said, and held it up.

It rang six times. Slowly. Each ring dragged out like a note played on a record that was running down. Then somebody picked up.

"*Bueno?*" said a voice, and it was the oldest voice I'd ever heard, thin as paper and bright as a bell.

"Doña Citlali?" Abuela leaned toward the phone. "My name is Remedios Ibarra. I keep the dawn on Zarzamora Street. I..."

"*Ay,*" said the voice. "*Finalmente.* I thought nobody was left. I thought it was only me." A wheezing laugh. "Yesterday my candle went out, mija. After fifty years. And I thought, well,

Citlali, now they're all gone."

"Mine too," said Abuela. "This morning."

"Then you know." The voice grew sharper. "Listen, because I can't talk long, the line is slow. You are thinking the offering is a rope. You pull and the sun moves. No. It is a *flame.* You do not carry the fire alone, you light one candle from another candle. You never light from nothing. If your candle goes out, you go back to whoever gave it to you."

"My mother gave it to me," said Abuela. "She's gone."

"Then you go back to *her* mother, and her mother's mother, until you reach the first candle." A pause, a rattle of breath. "The first telling, mija. That is where the flame comes from. That is where it must be lit again."

"Where is the first telling?" asked Danny.

"*Quién es?*"

"I'm Danny. I'm a friend."

"Come to me, Danny," said Doña Citlali. "Bring the boy with the Quetzal on his face. Bring the dog. I will tell you what I can, but I cannot leave my kitchen. The line is..." The phone gave a long, drowsy beep, and the voice slid down an octave, like a tape slowing, and was gone.

I looked at Abuela. She was holding the ledger against her chest.

It took us ten minutes to decide, and about ninety seconds of that was Danny saying, "Okay, but why does it always have to be underground."

Here is what we had. A wet line of ink from a man everyone thought was dead. A boy who'd been missing for sixty-odd years. A chain of thirty-one people who'd forgotten how to light each other's candles. And a sun at 4:47 that was getting a little slower every hour.

"Below," said Xolotl. "Aurelio says Joaquín is *below.* The mirror's time and the underworld touch at the very bottom of Mictlan, where the ninth level meets the road that has no name. If your brother is not in the mirror, Doña Remedios, then that is where he went. That is the only place he *could* have gone."

"Can you take us there?" I asked.

"I can open the road." His ears flattened. "I cannot carry anyone. And I cannot stay long. A god of the dead who lingers below is soon a god of the *dead.*"

"How do we get in?"

Xolotl looked toward the window, toward the river that ran under every bridge and past every patio in San Antonio, the one the tourists take pictures of with margaritas in their hands.

"Every river in this country has an older name," he said. "That one has a very old name, and the oldest road into Mictlan begins at the place where a river and a dog meet. I know where."

"And I stay," said Abuela.

We all turned.

"It must be said to Mateo, so I will say it." She put the ledger on the table, flat, with both hands. "A chain is not a rope. It is hands. If everyone lets go, it falls. Somebody has to hold the first link, the one on the roof, and somebody has to call the thirty-one and tell them to light their candles tonight. I can do that. You can't. You have a different road."

"Abuela..."

"I am not afraid to stay, Mateo. I am afraid to be *useless.* Two different things." She cupped my face with her rough hand. "Ofelia and I will hold the house and the roof. You and Danny and the dog will hold the dark."

"That's not fair," I said. "I've been a hero for a day and a half."

"No," said Abuela. "You have been a *kid* for a day and a half. Now you are a hero. It's different. Ask the dog."

"It is quite different," said Xolotl, sounding very small.

She reached into her apron pocket and pulled out a tiny clay bowl, no bigger than a teacup, with a crust of black copal in the bottom and a single dry marigold petal on top.

"Light this every sunrise," she said. "If you cannot find a sunrise, light it anyway."

I took it. It weighed almost nothing.

Danny put his hand on my shoulder. Behind him, in the doorway, hundreds of tiny iron nails were humming, very softly, like a lullaby from a very long way off.

"I guess we're doing this," he said.

"I guess we are," I said.

Chapter Ten: My Reflection Doesn't Blink

We walked to the river, because the Buick had a sun to save.

"Downtown is twenty minutes on foot," Danny said, studying his phone. "Maybe forty. The map keeps buffering."

"It is the slowing," Xolotl said. He trotted ahead of us in his tie, tail low, ears pricked. "Distance is stretching. Do not trust any clock."

I wanted to trust something, so I trusted my sneakers and kept walking.

The streets were weird. Cars sat at green lights with their drivers frozen mid-yawn. A guy in an apron stood outside a taquería holding a tray of tortillas, and I swear the steam rising off them hung in the air in perfect curls, like cotton candy. Every shop window we passed showed a little scene that had stopped moving, and our reflections walked across them as we went, three kids' worth of shadows and one very dignified dog.

That's how I noticed.

It was a bus shelter, one of those glass ones with an ad for a personal-injury lawyer on the side. I glanced at it the way you glance at anything shiny, and my reflection looked back at me. Messy hair, a chocolate stain from that morning's pan dulce, wrinkled shirt.

Then I blinked, and it didn't.

I stopped walking. So did the reflection, a half second late, like a video call with bad signal.

"Danny," I said.

"Mm?"

"Does my hair look longer to you?"

"Your hair always looks like that."

"In the *glass*."

He looked. His whole face did a little thing. He took a very slow step to the left, and in the shelter window his reflection stepped to the left too, perfectly in sync. Mine just stood there watching me, one corner of its mouth curling up.

I hadn't smiled.

"It's just tired," I said, mostly to myself. "I'm tired. It's been a long day and a half."

"Mateo," Xolotl said, very softly, "step away from the glass."

My reflection winked at me. And then, with a sound like someone peeling a sticker off a window, it stepped out.

I want to be clear that it didn't look like a monster. That was the worst part.

It looked like *me.* Same sneakers, same shirt, same chocolate stain. But the hair was a little longer and the eyes were a little too bright and the whole face had a kind of polish to it, like a photograph of a person instead of a person. It looked at me the way you'd look at a very old, very sad joke.

"Hi," it said, and it had my voice, only calmer. "Don't run."

"Why would I run?" I said. I was already running.

I got about two steps before it appeared in front of me, in the exact spot I'd been about to dive toward. I changed direction. It was there. I faked left and went right. It was *there,* grinning, one hand outstretched.

"It's not fast," Danny yelled. "It's *ahead.* It knows where you're going before you go!"

"That's not helpful!"

"I'm *observing!*"

The double swung at me. I ducked. It was already swinging at the place I'd duck *to.* The punch grazed my shoulder and I spun into a trash can, which is the kind of thing that happens when you plan your moves in a fight and it knows exactly what the plan is.

Danny threw up both hands. The air smelled like hot iron, and the sky above downtown went the color of a bruise. Fat, heavy raindrops began to fall in a crooked line, aimed straight at the double.

They never landed. The double raised one palm, and every raindrop stopped in front of it, reflected back up at the sky in a thousand glittering threads.

"Sorry, Danny," it said gently. "I've seen that one."

Danny's knees buckled. The rain stopped like someone had turned off a faucet. He sat down hard on the curb with his hands shaking, and a thin line of blood ran from his left nostril.

"I'm okay," he said, in the voice of a person who very much wasn't. "That one was small. It's just... it *takes* something. Every time. It's like I'm lending the sky my own breath."

Xolotl was between us instantly, lightning crackling along his shoulders. He loosed a fork of it at the double, and it bent like a bad idea and went back into the clouds. He tried again and got the same result.

"I cannot strike what knows my strike," he said grimly. "Mateo. Think. What can it *not* see?"

"I don't know! It sees everything I'm going to do!"

"No." Xolotl's ember eyes narrowed. "It sees what you *intend*. There is a difference."

Here is a thing I know about myself.

When something scary happens, I run. I'm not proud of it. In sixth grade, when the fire alarm went off during a pop quiz, I beat three teachers and a janitor to the parking lot. I once faked a sprained ankle to get out of the mile, and I *kept* the crutches for two days because they were cool. My whole life, the plan has been the same.

Run.

And standing there in the street with my shoulder aching, looking at a version of myself that already knew it, I got a very cold, very clear idea.

The double wasn't predicting me. It was reading the plan I'd already made. It had read it a thousand times, in the school hallway, at the museum, in my own bedroom at night.

I didn't have to follow it.

I took one deep breath. I made my body do the thing it had never done once, in twelve years, when I was scared.

I stopped running.

I turned around and walked straight toward my own reflection, right through the hole in the plan, and I didn't dodge or raise my fists. I just kept walking until I was standing right in front of it.

The double stared at me. It didn't swing. It didn't block. For the first time, it looked less like it knew what I was going to do and more like it was waiting for me to tell it.

"You can't," it said. "That's not what you do."

"Yeah," I said. "I know."

I'd love to tell you I did something brilliant. What I did was grab the front of its shirt with both hands and shout, "*BOO!*" directly in its face, because it was the only thing I could think of that wasn't on any plan.

The double flinched. It really flinched, like I'd thrown a bucket of cold water at it. It blinked, which was new, and its edges rippled like heat on a highway.

"Danny," I said. "*Now.*"

Danny was kneeling on the curb with blood on his lip and both hands shaking. He looked at the bruise-colored sky. He looked at me. I could see him doing the math, the way he does

with a quiz he isn't sure he can finish.

"I've got maybe one drop," he whispered. "If I use it, I might not be able to do anything else tonight."

"Then don't," I said. "We'll figure something else out."

He thought about that. Then he shook his head. "No. It can stop a big storm. It's never seen a small one." He raised one trembling finger. "Last one."

A single raindrop fell from the sky and landed squarely on the double's forehead.

It hissed like a hot pan. The whole figure folded in on itself, sheets of silver peeling off in layers, and in a heartbeat it had curled back into the bus-shelter glass and become an ordinary reflection of an ordinary street.

The glass went still. Then, very faintly, from somewhere behind it, came a sound I knew by heart.

Tap. Tap. Tap.

"It can reach outside the mirror," I whispered. "It can come out of any glass."

"Then we should not linger near glass," said Xolotl.

"Or windows. Or water. Or my *phone*." Danny wiped the blood off his nose with the back of his hand and tried to smile. "Great. I love having a new phobia."

We reached the river an hour or maybe a minute later. There's no telling anymore.

The San Antonio River Walk is a long green path that winds along the water with restaurants on the banks and little bridges and tourists in sun hats. Now every umbrella was frozen mid-turn and every boat sat motionless on the surface like toys in a bath. The water itself still moved, but only barely, as if it were deciding whether to bother.

The sky above the cypress trees hadn't changed since 4:47. It never would again unless we did something about it.

Danny was leaning on a railing, pale and quiet. I stood beside him and tried not to look at the water, but I couldn't help it. In the dark surface, my reflection looked back, calm and ordinary, with one corner of its mouth turned up.

I hadn't smiled.

I looked away fast.

"It will not follow us down," said Xolotl, who'd been watching me. "Not past the first gate. Mirrors cannot cross the river, because the dead have no reflections."

"That's really comforting," said Danny.

"It was not meant to be."

We walked along the bank for a long time, past a closed-up taco stand and a bridge covered in ivy, until the path split off toward a set of old stone steps that went down to the water. At the bottom, half in the shadows of a cypress tree, a dog was sitting.

It wasn't a god. It wasn't wearing a tie. It was a plain brown dog, medium-sized and a little scruffy, with one white ear and a patient look, like someone who'd been waiting at a bus stop for a very long time.

Xolotl stopped. He lowered his head and, for the first time since I'd known him, bowed. Not to me or to Abuela. To the dog.

"The river and the dog," he said quietly. "They are here."

The dog stood up. It looked at Xolotl, then at Danny, then, for a long moment, at me, and I felt it look straight through the sneakers and the sprained-ankle story and all the plans I'd ever made.

Then it turned around and walked into the river, and the water, very gently, began to run backward.

Chapter Eleven: Say Your Name

The river ran backward, and we walked into it.

I'd like to say I was brave about it. Mostly I was holding the little clay bowl Abuela gave me against my chest, like a football I'd been told not to fumble. The brown dog trotted ahead of us down the stone steps and stepped onto the water without making a ripple.

"Do we swim?" I asked.

"We walk," said Xolotl. "Do not look down."

I looked down.

Under my sneakers, the surface wasn't water anymore. It was something darker and denser, like glass poured over a night sky, and the stars underneath were moving, slowly, in the opposite direction from the river. Behind us, the lights of downtown San Antonio shrank to a smear of orange, then to a single bead, then to nothing.

I turned around. The steps were gone. The riverbank was gone. There was only a long, dim road stretching away in both directions, and the dark closing over it like a lid.

My heart started to hammer. The air felt too thin, and my hands were shaking so hard the little bowl rattled.

"Hey," I said. "Hey, maybe we should go back. Just for a second. Just to check on..."

"There is no back," said Xolotl, not unkindly. "Not yet."

That was the moment I almost lost it. I want to be honest about that. I'd stopped running from a reflection an hour ago and felt like a hero. Now I was standing on a road made of stars with every part of me screaming to bolt, and there was nowhere to bolt *to*.

Danny stepped up beside me. His face was gray and there was dried blood under his nose, but he bumped my shoulder with his, hard enough to knock the panic loose.

"Hey," he said. "I haven't been scared since this morning. I scheduled it for after math."

I laughed. It came out as a hiccup. But my hands stopped shaking.

"Courage isn't a switch," Danny said quietly. "I read that somewhere. I think it was on a poster in the counselor's office. You just keep doing it."

"That poster had a kitten on it."

"It was *good advice*."

Xolotl made us stop at a flat black stone, where a single marigold grew out of a crack. He sat down, and his ears went low in the way that means *lecture*.

"Three rules," he said. "I will say them once, and then I will say them again, because the living forget."

"We *haven't* forgotten anything," said Danny.

"You will."

That shut us up.

"One. Time below is not time above. One night here is about one hour on the surface. You may think this is a gift. It is not." He tapped the stone. "Mictlan takes a toll in memory. The longer the living stay, the more they lose. First their smallest things, the names of streets, the taste of a favorite food. Then bigger things. Faces. In the end, their own names."

My stomach dropped. "And then?"

"Then they are very polite residents."

"*Xolotl.*"

"Two." He ignored me. "Say your name at every gate. Out loud. The gates will ask, and what you say must be true, because a name that is spoken is a name that is kept."

"The gate asks only who you are *now,*" he added. "The toll takes what you carry."

"Three." His ember eyes found mine. "Do not lose each other. The dead walk very well on their own. The living do not."

Danny raised a hand. "Question. Can't we use the time difference? Like, spend a day down here and only lose an hour up there?"

"You could," said Xolotl. "You would also lose a day's worth of yourself."

"So no."

"So *no.*"

I thought about the sun, stuck at 4:47. I thought about Abuela on her roof with a candle and a phone. I wondered how many of my days I'd be willing to trade. It was a weird, quiet kind of math, and I didn't like how fast I could do it.

We walked for what felt like a long time and might have been a few minutes. The road wound through a landscape that looked like a dream of a desert. There were no stars and no moon, just a kind of dim, steady glow, like a night-light in a very big house.

We weren't alone.

The dead walked beside us, quiet and unhurried. A woman in an apron, carrying a bundle of marigold petals. A man in a work uniform, humming. A little girl holding the hand of a big brown dog that wasn't ours. Each of them had a dog. None of them looked scared. They looked like people on their way home from a very long day.

"It's so *polite,*" Danny whispered.

"They are going where they are going," said Xolotl. "It is only the living who rush."

Our dog padded along without a word. Danny had been eyeing it for ten minutes, and finally he sidled over and asked, in a very serious voice, "Can I pet this one?"

Xolotl glanced at the brown dog. The brown dog glanced at Xolotl. Something passed between them, patient and ancient and entirely wordless.

"Briefly," said Xolotl.

Danny knelt. The dog sniffed his hand, then pressed its forehead into his palm. Danny's whole face softened, and for a moment the shaking in his shoulders stopped.

"What's its name?" he asked.

"It has one," said Xolotl. "It is not mine to say."

I wanted to ask more. But the road made one last wide curve, and there, at the end of it, rose a wall of black stone, enormous, rough, and old as the sky. Set into it was a gate, and carved over the gate in a language I'd never seen but somehow understood:

Tell the dark who you are.

"Who goes first?" asked Danny.

Nobody said anything. The brown dog sat down at the foot of the gate and waited. The dead walked past us, each stepping up to the stone, whispering something, and passing through without a sound.

I handed Danny the clay bowl. I stepped up to the gate.

It was cold. Up close, it smelled like wet stone and old pennies, and the carved letters seemed to move when I wasn't looking directly at them.

"Say it," said Xolotl, very softly.

"My name is..."

And nothing came.

My mind went blank. It was like looking for a word on the tip of my tongue and finding a wall. I knew I had a name. I knew it started with M. I stood there with my mouth open and my heart beating a thousand times a minute and the dead lining up behind me, patient and silent.

"Mateo," whispered Danny, behind me. "It's *Mateo*."

"Mateo," I said, and the stone shivered. "Mateo Q... Quetz..." I swallowed. And then, far down in the dark, in a voice I'd known since I was a baby, I heard my grandmother laugh at my kitchen table with milk on my face. "*Mateo Quetzal Ibarra*."

The gate swung open without a sound.

I stumbled forward, and Danny caught me. He was gray and shaking and grinning like an

idiot.

"It took you a second," he said.

"It was a *long* second."

"I know." He handed back the bowl. "It was a long one for me too."

Beyond the gate, the road dropped into a valley full of dim fire, and in the distance, two black mountains were slowly, deliberately beginning to move toward each other.

Behind us, the river closed like a book.

Chapter Twelve: The Mountains Clap

The valley rearranged itself while we weren't looking.

One second the three of us were standing at the top of a gentle slope, looking down at a road that wound between two black mountains. The next, the ground gave a long, grinding shudder, like a giant turning over in bed, and the slope split into two levels. Danny and Xolotl rose on a high ridge of rock to the left. Mateo and the brown dog sank on a lower trail to the right, down into the shadows between the mountains.

"*Mateo!*" Danny yelled. His voice came down to me from about thirty feet up, thin and slightly echoing.

"I'm okay!" I yelled back. "The floor reorganized!"

"I noticed!"

Xolotl peered over the ridge, ears flat. "The valley chooses its own paths. It always has." He looked at the brown dog, and the dog looked back. "The low road is for the living and the dead. The ridge is mine. I cannot walk where you walk, Mateo, and I cannot carry you."

"So I'm just supposed to..." I looked at the mountains. "Walk through that?"

I should explain about the mountains.

They were each about the size of a small city, black and glossy, shot through with veins of glowing orange, like cooling lava under glass. They hung on either side of the trail, a few hundred feet apart. And every so often, with a groan like an old ship, they leaned toward each other.

BOOM.

They met in the middle with a sound that shook my teeth. Dust rolled down the valley. A few

seconds later, with the same groan, they slid back to their places, and the path between them stood wide open again.

Then, after a pause, they did it again.

I watched them for a long time, because the other option was to start crying, and I wasn't ready.

"How long between claps?" asked Danny, from above.

"I don't know. Nine seconds? Ten?"

"Don't *guess.* Count." He'd crouched at the edge of the ridge, chin in his hands, wearing the face he gets when a teacher hands back a test. "Count breaths. Mictlan isn't regular time, so seconds won't work. Count how many times you breathe."

I breathed in. I watched the mountains. I breathed out.

Boom. One, two, three, four, five, six, seven, eight, nine. *Boom.*

"Nine!" I called up.

"Nine," Danny agreed. "Every time?"

We waited for three more claps. It was nine every time.

"Okay," said Danny. He sounded a little relieved. "That's a pattern. Patterns are good. We can work with a pattern."

Below me, a woman in an apron walked past with a bundle of marigolds in her arms. She didn't hurry. She didn't look up. She stepped out from the edge of the trail right as the mountains slid apart, and she strolled between them like it was a hallway at school. Behind her, the mountains came together and ground against each other with a sound like a thousand thunderclaps, and she was already out the other side.

"They don't hurt the dead," said Xolotl. "The living are another matter."

"How do I cross?"

"The same way she did," said Xolotl. "At the right moment. And without fear."

"That is *not* a plan," I called.

"It is the only plan I have!"

I'd like to tell you I did the smart thing.

What I did was wait for the next gap, take a running start, and dash straight at the opening, because running is the thing I do best. I got about four steps in, with the mountains sliding apart on both sides of me and the whole valley rumbling, and then I heard something that stopped me cold.

Not Danny's voice. Mine.

In my head, from a long way off, I heard myself saying the words I'd heard at the gate. *Mateo Quetzal Ibarra.* I heard Abuela laugh, with the milk on my face.

I reached for it. I reached for the comfort of her voice, the thing that had pulled me out of the dark an hour ago.

And it wasn't there.

I knew what she'd said. I could remember every word. *Mateo Quetzal Ibarra. Light it anyway. I am afraid to be useless.* But I couldn't *hear* it. The words were there, flat and silent, like text on a screen. The sound of her voice, the warm rough scrape of it, the way she rolled her *r*s, was just gone.

I stood there in the middle of the path with my mouth open.

"*Mateo!*" Danny was screaming. "*Mateo, get back!*"

I turned. The mountains had started to lean.

I ran. Not forward, back, the way I'd come, and I made it to the edge a heartbeat before the walls met behind me with a *BOOM* that picked me up and threw me onto the gravel. The brown dog was at my side before I'd stopped rolling. It licked my chin once, calmly, like a nurse.

"I'm fine," I said, into the dirt. "I'm totally fine. I'm having a great time."

"Mateo." Danny had climbed down the ridge, which I hadn't known he could do, and was crouched next to me with a scraped knee. He looked terrible. His eyes had gone a little glassy, the way they do when he hasn't eaten. "What happened?"

I told him. I didn't have the energy to joke about it. I said I'd tried to remember Abuela's voice and couldn't hear it, and it was the only thing that had kept me from freaking out.

Danny didn't say anything for a minute.

"That's the toll," Xolotl said gently, from the ridge. "It begins small. It does not ask permission."

"It's not *small,*" I said. "It's her *voice*."

"I know." Xolotl lowered his head. "It will not be the last. I am sorry."

I got up. I brushed gravel off my shirt. And I realized, standing there, that I was doing it again. The thing I do. The plan I'd made at the top of the slope had been the same plan I'd made all my life: *run, and hope*. And the thing I'd leaned on to feel brave, the sound of Abuela's laugh, had been taken away, and I'd been left standing in front of a mountain with nothing but my own legs.

"I can't do this on my own," I said, quietly.

"No," said Danny. "That's kind of the point, isn't it?"

I looked at him. He had a bleeding knee and gray lips and a cut on his chin, and he was grinning, a little crooked, like I'd just said the most obvious thing in the world.

"Okay," I said. "So tell me what to do."

He talked me through it.

It sounds so simple I'm embarrassed. Danny stayed on the lower trail with me, at the edge of the pass, where he could see the mountains and where I could hear him. He pressed his hand flat against his chest, and I understood that he was counting his own heartbeat in time with the breaths. Then he put a hand on my shoulder.

"They clap every nine breaths," he said. "You've got nine to cross. I've timed how long it takes you to run it. It's six."

"That's not a lot of margin."

"It's three breaths of margin. I'm going to count out loud, and you don't go until I say. If you go early, you get crushed. If you go late, you get crushed. You can't use your gut. Your gut is a *liar*."

"My gut has been right my entire life."

"Your gut told you to fake a sprained ankle."

"...Fair."

He took a breath. "Ready?"

I nodded. The mountains slid apart. The valley went quiet.

"*One,*" said Danny. "*Two*."

Every cell in my body screamed *go.* My legs were shaking. The path stretched out ahead of me, wide open, the gap between the mountains growing like a mouth.

"*Three. Four.*"

I could hear the mountains groaning, getting ready to lean.

"*Five.*"

"*Danny.*"

"*Not yet.*"

"*Danny!*"

"*Mateo,*" he said, in the calmest voice I've ever heard from a twelve-year-old with a bloody chin. "I've got you. *Wait.*"

I waited.

"*Six.* Go."

I went.

I ran like I'd never run before, across stone and gravel and orange veins glowing in the dark, with the brown dog streaking beside me and the mountains tilting toward each other on either side. I could feel the wind they made. I could feel the dust in my teeth. I counted my breaths: seven, eight.

I burst out of the far side of the pass on the ninth, and the mountains came together behind me in a thunderclap that blew me clean off my feet.

I landed in a pile of dirt, coughing. The clay bowl was still clutched against my chest, unbroken. The dog was already standing beside me, panting happily, tongue out.

"*YES!*" Danny whooped from somewhere behind the wall of dust. "That was *three whole breaths of margin!*"

We found the second gate at the end of a long ramp of dark stone, not far from where the pass opened. Xolotl and Danny came down off the ridge to meet us. Xolotl moved slowly and kept looking at me, and I could tell he was thinking about the voice.

The gate was the same as the first, black and rough and carved with the same message. *Tell the dark who you are.*

"Danny Okafor," said Danny, loudly, before anyone could ask. The stone shivered, and he

grinned. "I like this part."

"Xolotl," said Xolotl.

"Mateo Quetzal Ibarra," I said.

It came out smooth, without a hitch. The gate opened. My name sat in my mouth easily, like a coin I'd had my whole life.

But I noticed something as I walked through, and I didn't say it out loud, because I didn't want anyone to worry.

I knew every word Abuela had ever said to me. I knew the story of the milk, and the ladder on the roof, and the water bowl on the porch. I could repeat all of it.

I just couldn't hear her say it.

Chapter Thirteen: The Wind That Cuts

The third level of Mictlan sounded like a hundred pairs of scissors snipping at once.

We heard it before we saw it. Past the second gate, the road ran out onto a plain of black glass that stretched to the horizon, flat and shiny and cold, and all across it, low to the ground, something was moving. Not dust. Not smoke. It was a thin, bright, whistling glitter, like someone had ground up a thousand mirrors and thrown them into the air.

"Obsidian wind," said Xolotl. "Itzehecayan. It blows without stopping, and it cuts what it touches."

"Cuts like how?" asked Danny.

Xolotl didn't answer. A gust swept across the plain, and a stone the size of a suitcase near the road split cleanly in half, neat as a sliced tomato.

"Like that," said Danny, in a very small voice.

Ahead of us, the dead walked into it. The woman with the apron went first, the marigold petals tucked under one arm. The man in the work uniform followed. Every single one of them was carrying something white, held flat against their chest like a shield: sheets of folded paper, pale and heavy-looking, the kind you'd use for a school project that mattered.

The wind hit them. The paper didn't tear. The blades slid off it in long, bright sparks, and the dead strolled on, humming.

"That's their offering," said Xolotl. "The living bury their dead with paper for exactly this. The paper takes the cuts so they don't have to."

I looked at my hands. I had a clay bowl, a sprained pride, and a shirt with a chocolate stain.

"We don't have paper," I said.

"No."

"We're going to have to turn around."

"There is no turning around," said Xolotl. "You know that."

I did. I just wanted to say it out loud anyway, the way you say *I don't want to* before you do it.

It was Danny who started rummaging in his backpack.

"Hold on," he said. "I *might*. My mom makes me keep every permission slip, in case the school ever lies about me, and..." He pulled out a crumpled sheet, thick and cream-colored, folded in thirds. He stared at it. "Huh."

"That's the museum slip," I said.

"That's the *thick* slip." He held it up. In the dim glow of the plain, it was the exact color of the paper in the dead's arms, a pale warm cream, grainy, with little flecks of fiber running through it. "I told you. Nobody prints a permission slip on thick paper."

"Do you have another?"

"I only get one. I mean, you got one too, right?"

I dug in my back pocket. And there, folded in four, next to a napkin I'd been saving since lunch, was my own. It was crushed and a little greasy, but it was the same stuff, thick and rough and strong.

Xolotl took the slip from my hand with his teeth, very delicately, and sniffed it. His ears went straight up.

"This is not school paper," he said.

"What is it?"

"*Amate*." He said the word like it tasted like something he hadn't had in a hundred years. "Bark paper. Pounded from the fig tree, made for offerings, for books, for the dead. The Mexica made it. No machine makes it like this." He looked at me. "Mateo. Who gave you this?"

"Ms. Delgado. It came home in a folder."

"Who gave it to *her*?"

I opened my mouth. I shut it again.

I thought about the thick, cream-colored letters in Dr. Quiroga's office. I thought about a dead man's handwriting, still wet in a ledger. I thought about a field trip that had been switched, quietly, on a Thursday, from a place Danny liked to a place somebody needed us to go.

"Somebody planned this," I whispered. "Somebody *knew* we'd need paper."

"Somebody knew a lot of things," said Xolotl, and his voice was very quiet. "I am beginning to wonder how many of them were on our side."

We had two sheets. That was all. Two slips of paper, and a half mile of black glass and wind.

"One each," said Danny.

"One each is not enough." Xolotl glanced at the nearest dead man, whose paper was nearly three times the size of ours. "A sheet that size can take a hundred cuts. Yours can take twenty. Perhaps."

"So we put them together."

"Together is better," Xolotl admitted. "But still not enough."

Danny looked at the sky. The black, empty sky of Mictlan, with no stars and no clouds, a ceiling made of nothing. Then he looked at his hands, and I knew exactly what he was thinking.

"Don't," I said.

"I'm not saying I'm going to. I'm saying paper is stronger when it's wet." He bit his lip. "Wet paper doesn't tear as easy. It's dense. It takes the cuts better. And I can make rain, Mateo. I can make the *right* kind of rain, small and steady, just enough to soak it through."

"I got a little back while we walked," he added. "Mictlan's weird. I think the rain likes it here."

"How long can you hold it?"

"I don't know."

"How long will it *cost?*"

"I really don't know." He glanced at Xolotl. "That's the part that's weird. The drop I used on the double was one second. This is a *lot* of seconds."

Xolotl was quiet for a moment. "The cost is not in the size of the storm," he said slowly. "It is

in how long you keep it from stopping. The sky wants to finish what it begins. Holding a storm in place is a kind of lie. And you are not yet good at lying."

"That's the nicest thing anyone's said to me today," said Danny.

"It was not meant to be nice."

"It was a little bit nice."

I stepped in front of him. "We'll do this together. We hold the paper between us, back to back. You do the rain. I do the walking. And the second you wobble, I carry you."

"You can't carry me. You're the size of a hamster."

"I'm a *very determined* hamster."

Danny laughed, and then he stopped, and then he nodded.

It was the longest half mile of my life.

We stood back to back, with the two slips of amate overlapped over our heads and the clay bowl tucked in the middle. Danny raised one hand and the air went thick and warm and smelled like a hot iron skillet. A fine, steady mist began to fall, so light I could barely feel it on my neck, and the paper darkened as it drank.

We stepped into the wind.

I'd like to tell you it was brave. Mostly it was loud. The wind came in waves, shrieking and whistling and tapping on the paper like a thousand tiny knives, and every time a gust hit, a spray of sparks scattered across our little tent and burned out in the dark. The brown dog trotted ahead with its nose low, picking a path. Xolotl walked on my other side, close enough that I could feel the heat of his fur, taking the worst of the blasts on his shoulders. He made a low sound each time one hit, like a man trying not to wince.

"Count," Danny whispered behind me. "Count your breaths. It helps."

"One. Two. Three."

"Louder."

"*Four. Five.*"

It was around breath three hundred that Danny started to shake.

I felt it through his back first, a tremor, small at first, then growing. The mist overhead thinned. A gust slid through the gap and sliced the corner off our paper, and a long splinter

of black glass whistled past my ear.

"Danny."

"I'm okay."

"You're not."

"I'm *fine,* I just need..." His voice cracked. "I need a second. I can't keep it up. It's like trying to hold a door shut against a bus."

"Then stop."

"If I stop, the paper goes."

"Then I'll hold it."

"You can't hold it by yourself!"

"I can hold it better than you can hold the rain."

I don't know where it came from. I just knew that I was done with the plan where one of us carries the whole weight. I slid my shoulder under Danny's arm and took the weight of the paper in my free hand and shouted, "*Stop the rain!*"

The mist cut off. Danny's knees buckled. I caught him.

And a gust hit.

It came through a gap I hadn't even seen, low and fast, and tore across my forearm like a hot wire. I yelped. The sleeve split from elbow to wrist, and a thin, bright line of blood welled up along the cut. It didn't hurt at first. It was more like a surprise.

"Mateo!" Xolotl lunged, spreading his body across our side of the tent like a wall.

"I'm fine," I said. "I'm *fine.* It's a scratch."

I hauled Danny forward, step by step, with Xolotl taking the hits, and the brown dog leading us through the glitter. I don't remember the rest of the crossing. I remember counting. I remember the sound of Danny breathing hard against my shoulder. I remember the clay bowl, still warm, still in my hand.

I remember the moment the wind stopped.

We collapsed on the far side, on a ledge of soft gray sand, in front of a third gate. Danny lay flat on his back with his eyes shut and his chest going up and down like a bellows. There was a thin line of blood under his nose again, but he was grinning at the ceiling like he'd won

a prize.

"Three hundred and seventy-two," he panted. "I counted. That's the most I've ever... held a rain for."

"That's amazing," I said.

"That's *terrible,*" said Xolotl, but he sounded proud.

I sat up and looked at my arm. The cut was long and clean, already beginning to close, leaving a thin silver line along my forearm like a pencil mark, and when I touched it, my fingertips came away shining with something that wasn't quite blood. It looked like blood. It smelled like old pennies.

"Xolotl," I said slowly. "What does obsidian cut?"

He didn't answer right away.

"What it touches," he said. "And what that thing is carrying."

I tried to think of something I'd been carrying. I started with my breakfast: pan dulce. My grandmother. Her little yellow house. The street where it sat, with its chain-link fence and its lemon tree that made four lemons every ten years.

"Danny," I said. "What's the name of Abuela's street?"

He turned his head. "Zarzamora."

"Right." The word landed in my ears and went nowhere. I could repeat it, the way you can repeat a phone number somebody reads you, but it didn't feel like mine. "I can say it. I just can't find it by myself."

Danny sat up slowly. He looked at me for a long, quiet moment, and then he held out his hand, palm up, like he was waiting for a coin.

"Okay," he said. "So we'll remember it together. I'll remember yours. You remember mine."

"That's not how this works."

"It's how *friends* work." He wiped his nose. "What's my phone number?"

I blinked. "What?"

"I can't think of it." He frowned, and I saw the slight panic come into his face. "It was right there. And I've had it since the third grade. It's gone. *Mateo.* My own number."

I took a breath. And it came, instantly, like a song I'd heard a thousand times.

"Two-one-oh," I said, and I gave him the rest of the number, all seven digits, in the right

order, with the little rhythm he always has when he says it, the way he rushes the middle.

Danny repeated it back to me, slowly. "It's still not mine," he said. "But it's yours. And you gave it to me."

"See?" he said, and a slow, wobbly smile spread across his face. "You've got mine. I've got yours."

"That's a terrible system."

"It's a *chain*."

I looked at him, and for a second the whole thing felt very simple, like I'd been holding one end of a rope for a very long time and someone had finally picked up the other.

The third gate was the same black stone as the others, with the same carved words. We all said our names. Xolotl said his. I said mine, loud and clear, and the stone shivered. Danny stepped up last.

"Danny Okafor," he said.

The gate didn't open.

Danny glanced at me. He said it again, louder. "*Danny Okafor.*"

The stone stayed shut. The wind, far behind us, whispered across the plain. The dead stood patiently on either side of us, waiting, not looking.

"It asks who you are *now,*" said Xolotl, very quietly. "And who you are now is not finished."

"That's the only name I've got." Danny's voice cracked. "I'm Danny Okafor. I'm from Sugar Land. That's all I..." He stopped. He stared at the stone, and I saw it in his face, a thing he hadn't let himself feel since the cellar.

Somewhere, very far away, in the cold, a hundred tiny iron nails began to hum.

"I don't know the rest," Danny said. "I'm sorry. I don't *know* it."

For a long moment, nothing happened.

Then, with a groan like a very old door, the gate began to open anyway, slowly, grudgingly, the way you'd let someone in when you've decided to wait for the rest of him.

Chapter Fourteen: What the Dog Saw

Past the third gate, Mictlan gave us a courtyard.

It was small and round, floored with smooth gray stone, with a dry fire pit in the middle and a few crooked trees growing out of the cracks like they'd been waiting a very long time for company. Nobody had told us it was there. The dead walked right past it without turning their heads.

"A resting place," said Xolotl. "Every level has one, if you know where to look. The dead do not need them."

"But the living do," said Danny, and sat down so fast his knees clicked.

"A place of rest is not a place of safety," Xolotl added. "It is only a place where nothing hunts you *yet*."

"That's super reassuring," said Danny, from the ground.

Nobody argued. I sat on the other side of the fire pit and set the clay bowl in front of me and watched my arm, where the silver line had stopped hurting. The brown dog curled up near the edge of the courtyard and rested its chin on its paws. It didn't sleep. It watched.

"How long have we been down here?" I asked.

Xolotl tilted his head, the way he does when he's doing math. "A little over a night. Perhaps an hour, above." He paused. "Perhaps a little more."

"Perhaps?"

"The wind took longer than I expected."

A little more than an hour. I tried to picture the sun at 4:47, hanging on Abuela's roof like a coin in a vending machine. I thought about the thirty-one candles she was calling, one by one. I wondered if any of them had picked up.

Danny hadn't said anything in a while.

He was sitting with his back against a tree, hands open on his knees, staring at them. His nose had stopped bleeding. His shoulders had stopped shaking. But there was a tight, closed-up look on his face that I'd never seen before, like he'd locked the door on a room and wasn't going to say what was in it.

"Hey," I said.

"I'm good."

"You're really not."

He didn't answer. I scooted around the fire pit and sat next to him, not too close, the way you do with an animal that might bolt.

"The gate," Danny said finally. "It asked for the rest of my name."

"I know."

"I've been saying 'Danny Okafor' my whole life. Like it was the whole thing." His voice was very quiet. "My mom had this thing, when I was little. She'd tell me, 'Daniel, you come from people.' I thought that was just a thing moms say. Like, *you come from people who go to church* or *you come from people who don't quit.* But what if she meant..."

He didn't finish.

"What if you did?" I said.

"What if I'm not who I thought? What if there's a whole other... person in here, and I just never met him?"

I thought about that for a minute. I thought about the kid who'd said "I'm going to have my breakdown later" while a god-dog looked on. The kid who'd noticed a permission slip. The kid who'd stood on a bus with a fire extinguisher and a ruined roof.

"Okay," I said. "So there's more. That doesn't mean the part you already know isn't real."

"That's not..."

"You're the guy who figured out the Alamo thing. You're the guy who counted nine breaths for me. You told me to wait." I shrugged. "I don't know what the rest of your name is. But I know the first part. It's good."

Danny made a noise that was half a laugh and half something else. He wiped his face on his sleeve.

"That's the nicest thing anyone's said to me today," he said.

"It was not meant to be nice," I said, in my best Xolotl voice.

"It was a *little* nice."

Across the fire pit, Xolotl pretended not to listen. His ears gave him away.

I'd been holding the question for two levels. I'd tried to ask it twice and lost my nerve both times. But sitting in that gray courtyard, with the dead walking past in the dark and the brown dog watching us, it suddenly seemed like the kind of thing you shouldn't carry down any further.

"Xolotl," I said. "Tell me about Joaquín."

The god of the dead went still.

"I've been thinking about it since the kitchen," I said. "You said you watched a brave kid walk into a lock. You said he was kind and twelve and thought he could fix it by being good. You said you were too late." I swallowed. "That was my great-uncle."

"Yes," said Xolotl.

"I want to know what happened. Not the short version. I think I've had enough short versions."

For a long moment, he didn't say anything. The dry fire pit made a sound like a distant, patient wind. Then he lowered himself onto the stone, slowly, like an old man sitting in a church pew, and began.

"Sixty-four years ago," he said, "I was in Mexico City, in the museum where the mirror had been moved for a ceremony. A great many people were there. A great many of them were praying. They did not understand what they were praying to."

"Sixty-four," said Danny. "That's fifty-two plus twelve."

"The cycle," said Xolotl. "The Mexica counted their years in bundles of fifty-two. At the end of each bundle, they put out every fire in the world, and waited in the dark, and lit a new one. They believed that if the fire was not lit, the sun would not rise." His ember eyes were far away. "The old priests knew how to do it. By the time of your great-uncle, almost nobody did. So the gods made a substitute. A child, born on the day of the first fire, would stand in the lock, and hold it closed, and the sun would be safe for another bundle of years."

"A child," I said.

"Not forever," said Xolotl. "That was what they told themselves. *Not forever.* It was only supposed to be until someone remembered the old way."

"And nobody did."

"And nobody did."

"Joaquín was twelve and a month," said Xolotl. "I did not tell him about the other children. I thought... I thought he was not ready. So I told him only what the priests told him: that it would be a great honor, and that it would not hurt."

"Did it hurt?"

"I do not know. He did not go all the way in." Xolotl's voice cracked, just slightly. "That is the

part I have never told your grandmother."

Danny and I looked at each other.

"He walked up to the mirror. Everyone was watching. He put out his hand, and the glass rippled like water, and he stepped through it, one foot, then the other, up to his waist. And then he stopped."

"Stopped?"

"He stood there, half in the mirror, half out, with the whole room silent. And he turned his head and looked at me." Xolotl took a long, shaky breath. "He mouthed two words. I could see them clearly. *It won't.*"

"*It won't*..." I frowned. "Won't what?"

"I do not know. He did not finish. A great crack of light split the glass, and when it faded, the boy was gone, and the mirror was whole again, and there was nothing in the room but a silver mark on the floor, in the shape of a child's footprint."

"That is what I saw," said Xolotl. "What I decided it meant, I have been wrong about for sixty-four years."

I felt very cold.

"I thought it was the lock *eating* him," said Xolotl. "I thought he had begun the Binding, and been taken. I thought that was all there was. And I made a decision, then, in that room." He stared into the dry fire pit. "I decided that the next One Reed child must never walk up to that mirror. That I would keep the truth from them, and keep them from the glass, and if it came to it, I would keep them from the whole world."

"So when you found me," I said slowly.

"I tried to walk you out of the museum before you reached the case. I was three hours too late." He lifted his head. "I have never forgiven myself for either failure."

I didn't know what to say. A part of me wanted to hug him, which seemed very strange, because he was a god, and a dog, and also he'd lied to me.

"I'm sorry," I said at last. "About Joaquín."

"You need not..."

"I'm sorry. But I'm also kind of mad at you."

Xolotl's ears went flat. "That is reasonable."

"You decided for me," I said. "Before I was born. You decided that I wouldn't get to know. You and Abuela both did. And I get why. You both loved somebody you lost, and you didn't want it to happen again." My voice was shaking, and I didn't try to stop it. "But I'm not Joaquín. I'm not a thing you can protect by hiding stuff from. I'm the one who has to walk up to the glass."

"Mateo..."

"That's all I'm saying." I looked at him. "I'm not saying you were wrong to be scared. I'm saying that if you're going to keep walking with me, I need to know everything. Even the part about the footprint."

Xolotl was quiet for a long time.

"Your grandmother said that to me," he finally said. "In nearly the same words."

"She's very smart."

"She is terrifying," said Xolotl, and in spite of everything, I laughed.

"I will tell you everything," he said. "From here until the ninth level. I swear it on my brother's mirror." He paused. "I have not been very good at swearing on things that matter. I would like to try."

"Okay," I said. "Then here's a question you can start with."

He waited.

"Why did he stop?"

Xolotl turned his head to look at the dog, and the dog looked back at him, and I could feel something pass between them that was bigger than I could understand.

"Because," he said slowly, "I think he found out something. And I think it is down there, at the bottom of everything, waiting for you to ask him."

We rested for another hour, or what felt like one. Danny slept for a while with his head on his backpack, breathing slowly, one hand curled around nothing. I stayed up and watched the dead pass, quiet and patient, one by one.

That's when I noticed him.

At first he was just one more shape among the others, far out on the plain beyond the courtyard, where the dim glow was thin. But he wasn't walking the way the dead walk. He wasn't heading toward the next gate. He was standing still, with his hands in his pockets, perfectly upright, looking straight at us.

He was tall, and he wore a gray suit. He wore a gray hat, with a brim pulled low.

My heart skipped. *A man in a gray hat used to stand across the street on Sundays,* Abuela had said. *I thought he sold insurance.*

"Xolotl," I whispered.

He was already on his feet. "I see him."

The man in the gray hat lifted one hand. Not a wave, more like a man tipping his hat to someone across a very large room. Then he turned and walked slowly away, into the dark, toward the bottom of the world.

On the stone where he'd been standing, as I watched, a single line of wet ink spread across the floor, curling and writing itself in a thin, shining line.

I couldn't read it from there. But the brown dog stood up and whined.

Chapter Fifteen: A Cable Is Not a Plan

The ink was still wet when I got to it.

It had pooled across the gray stone like spilled tea, a long, curling line that kept moving even after the man in the gray hat had vanished. I crouched next to it. The silver line on my forearm, the one the wind had left, began to glow faintly, soft as moonlight through a curtain. It brightened as I leaned closer.

"That's new," said Danny, who had woken up and was standing behind me with sleep-creased cheeks and his backpack on crooked.

"I didn't do anything."

"It likes the ink."

"Great," I said. "My arm has a *crush*."

The ink finished writing itself. The words were neat and slanting, the same handwriting as the ledger on Ofelia's table. I read them out loud, because it was the only way I could make them feel real.

He did not stop because he was afraid. Ask him what the priests never asked.

—A.V.

Below that, in smaller letters, as if the writer had squeezed the words in before the ink dried:

Hurry. The road is open only where I have walked.

Nobody said anything. Far off on the plain, the dead went on walking, quiet and unhurried.

"Aurelio," said Xolotl. His voice was careful, like a man testing ice. "He is ahead of us."

"Alive?"

"I do not know what he is. I know he has written in a place where writing should not hold." He knelt next to the ink and sniffed it, ears twitching. "It smells like old paper. Like a library after a flood."

Danny crouched beside me. "'Ask him what the priests never asked.' Ask *who?*"

"Joaquín," I said.

"Right. But what's the question?"

I didn't know. I sat there with my arm glowing and my head full of a dead man's handwriting and tried to think what a twelve-year-old boy might have wanted to be asked, sixty-four years ago, in a museum in Mexico City, with a hundred people watching and a god-dog begging him with his eyes.

"They never asked him if he wanted to," I said slowly.

Xolotl didn't move.

"The priests told him it was an honor. You told him it wouldn't hurt. Nobody asked him whether he *wanted* to do it." My throat tightened. "Nobody asked him what he thought."

"No," said Xolotl, in a very small voice. "I never did."

I put my hand, the unglowing one, on his shoulder. It was the first time I'd touched him on purpose. His fur was warm and a little rough, like a very old rug.

"You can ask him when we find him," I said.

"I would like that," he said.

"Also," said Danny, "the gray-hat guy owes us a longer letter."

We were fifteen minutes into the next stretch of road when I stopped trusting the dark.

Past the courtyard, the ground dropped away in a long, curving slope, ringed with low black hills. The air changed. It stopped smelling like old pennies and started smelling like a wet dog that had been somewhere it shouldn't have, a thick, warm, hungry smell. The dead had thinned out. The ones still walking moved quicker, heads down, as if they knew something.

"Xolotl," said Danny. "What's the next level?"

"Teyollocualoyan," said Xolotl. "The place where hearts are eaten."

"That's a *name?*"

"It is a description."

"Does it mean literally..."

"It means that wild beasts hunt here," said Xolotl. "They hunt what the living carry. They do not much care about the dead, who have nothing left to take."

I looked at Danny. Danny looked at me.

"Okay," said Danny. "New rule. We don't split up."

"We *never* split up," I said.

"I'd like that in writing."

He started rummaging in his backpack again. I assumed it was another miraculous piece of Mictlan survival gear, a magic scroll, a sacred feather, something.

What he pulled out was a long white phone charging cable.

"Hold on," I said. "What is that?"

"It's a six-foot charging cable."

"We're in the *underworld*."

"I know." He tied one end around his wrist in a clumsy bow. "And my mom said never to leave home without it. She's right a lot." He held out the other end. "Rule three. Do not lose each other. Hand."

I stared at it. I'd like to be able to say that I laughed, but in truth my eyes got a little hot, and I had to look at the ceiling for a second before I could hold out my wrist.

"A cable is not a plan," I said, as Danny knotted it.

"It's a *tether.*"

"It's a charging cable."

"It's got a USB end," said Danny. "That's three prongs of protection."

The first beast showed itself at the bottom of the slope.

It was a jaguar, or something that had been a jaguar once and had given up on the idea. It was huge and sleek and the color of old smoke, with spots like dark coins and eyes like two wet embers. It didn't growl. It didn't crouch. It sat at the edge of the road with its tail curled around its paws and *looked* at us, the way a cat looks at a fish tank.

A second beast stepped out of the shadows on the other side. Then a third, a thing like a wolf, with too many teeth. A fourth, low and long, like a dog with the face of an owl.

"They don't look hungry," I whispered.

"They always look like that," said Xolotl, very softly. "Do not run. Do not clutch anything. Walk as if you have nothing worth taking."

"I've got a clay bowl."

"Then walk as if you do not care about it."

I did not care about it. I cared about it so much I could feel my pulse in the palm of my hand.

We took one step. Another. The jaguar's head turned, slowly, tracking us. We took a third, and a *whoosh* of warm, wet air breathed across the back of my neck, and I knew, with a clarity that would make anyone proud, that something was behind me.

"Danny," I whispered. "Don't turn around."

"I'm *not turning around*."

"There's something behind me."

"I know. There's something behind *me*. We're tied together, Mateo, it's the same something. They're circling."

Xolotl dropped into a crouch, ears back, sparks crackling along his shoulders. "They hunt in pairs. One to be seen. One to strike. Do not look at the one you see."

"Which one do we look at?"

"Neither."

"*Xolotl!*"

"I am *thinking!*"

Here is the thing I learned about plans: they work until the exact second you need them.

The owl-faced dog lunged first, from the left, and Xolotl met it with a crack of lightning that lit the whole valley white and sent the thing howling into the dark. The jaguar sprang from

the right. Danny yanked the cable, hard, and I stumbled sideways into his arms just in time for the cat to land where I'd been standing, claws scraping stone.

"They go for what you're holding!" Danny yelled, over the roar. "They're not looking at us. They're looking at your *hands*. Mateo! It's the *bowl!*"

I looked down. The clay bowl, which I'd clutched against my chest like a football for two levels, was glowing. A faint, warm, golden light was spilling out of the crust of black copal, steady as a night-light. The beasts hadn't been tracking *us*. They'd been tracking *that*.

"It's the offering," I said. "It's Abuela's flame. It smells like the sun."

"Give it to them!" Xolotl shouted. "A heart for a road! It is the only bargain the priests ever taught!"

"*No!*"

I don't know where it came from. I'd made promises to the dead guy in the ledger and the grandmother on the roof and the god on the stone, but I'd also made one to myself, back in the museum parking lot with a smoking cloud at my back: I was done being a kid who ran away from the hard part. This was Abuela's candle. This was the thing she'd climbed a ladder for every morning of her life.

"I'm not giving it up," I said. "And you can't make me."

Xolotl's ears went flat. For one second I thought he was going to argue. Then Danny's voice cut through the dark.

"Don't give it. *Share* it."

"What?"

"*Hold it open.*" Danny was gasping. "Don't clutch it. Don't hide it. Hold it up so everybody can see. It's not a thing they're supposed to take, it's a thing they're supposed to *smell*. You said it, Mateo. It's a flame, it's not a rope."

I didn't understand. But I had a charging cable tied to my wrist and a best friend yelling in my ear, and for the second time in two days I made myself do the thing I'd never done in twelve years of being scared.

I stopped clutching. I stood up, and I held the little clay bowl straight out in front of me on my open palm, the way you'd hold a bird, and I let the golden light fall across the floor of the valley.

The beasts stopped.

They didn't back away. They just stopped, one by one, as though somebody had flipped a

switch. The jaguar blinked at the flame. The wolf thing with too many teeth sat down. The owl-faced dog, singed and furious, put its head on its paws and made a long, shuddering sound that was almost a sigh.

They'd been hungry for something. I didn't know what. But it wasn't my heart.

The brown dog stepped forward then.

It had been standing behind us the whole time, silent and patient, and I realized I hadn't heard it make a single sound since the river. It padded to the front of the line and sat down in the road between us and the beasts, one white ear flicking, calm as a church on a Tuesday.

The jaguar looked at it. The jaguar's head dipped, just slightly, the way you'd lower your eyes in front of a teacher.

One by one, the beasts turned around and slunk off into the dark.

"Okay," said Danny, breathing hard. "I'm going to need somebody to tell me what just happened."

"I believe," said Xolotl slowly, "that you were correct."

"I *was?*"

"The beasts hunt what is clutched. What is held tightly, what is hidden, what is hoarded. That is what a heart *is*, in the old teaching. A thing that is clenched." He looked at me. "What is held open cannot be taken. It can only be shared."

I looked at the bowl. The flame had burned down to a tiny, steady ember, but it hadn't gone out.

"That's the Chain of Hands," I whispered.

"It is," said Xolotl, and there was something in his face I hadn't seen before: not guilt, not fear. Hope, maybe, as dim as the ember in my palm. "It is what the priests forgot."

"I have walked this level a thousand times with the dead," he added quietly, "and I never once asked whether the bargain was the only one."

We found the next gate half a mile down the slope, and it was the strangest one yet. It wasn't a gate at all. It was a spiral ramp, curling downward into the dark, with no wall and no door. A line of wet ink led down the middle of it, a single trail of shining footprints, one after

another, as if someone had walked this way not long ago in boots wet with ink.

"He's walking ahead of us," said Danny.

"He's *marking the road,*" I said.

"The road is open only where I have walked," Xolotl read, and shook his head slowly. "He is telling us we cannot find this path without him."

"Do we trust him?" I asked.

Xolotl was quiet for a long moment.

"I do not know," he said. "And I promised to tell you everything. So that is the truth. I do not know if Aurelio Valdivia is a friend. I know he wrote in ink where ink should not hold. I know he spent forty years guarding a lock and then wrote a letter telling his daughter to open it. I know he brought you paper." His ears flicked. "I do not know what he wants."

"But we're following him anyway."

"We are following him *because* we do not have a better road."

"That ramp was not here when we passed the courtyard," he added. "It runs below the road the dead walk, to a place no gate opens onto. The ink is the only thing holding it open."

I looked at the brown dog, sitting at the head of the ramp, tail wagging once, slowly. It looked back at me, and I got a strange, sudden feeling that it was waiting for me to make up my mind.

"Okay," I said. "Then let's go."

Danny wiggled his wrist. The cable jingled.

"Rule three," he said.

"Rule three."

We stepped onto the spiral together.

Chapter Sixteen: Two Sets of Footprints

The spiral ramp went down for a very long time.

It wasn't like a normal staircase. There were no railings and no walls, just a ribbon of black stone winding round and round into the dark, with nothing on either side but air and a faint, cold draft that smelled like a library. Every few steps, a fresh wet footprint of ink gleamed on

the stone, pointing the way down.

Xolotl walked first, nose low. Danny and I came next, tied together by his charging cable, which made us walk like a very bad three-legged race. The brown dog padded along at our heels.

Except it wasn't at our heels. It was beside us, on the bare stone to the left of the footprints, and every time the trail curved, the dog curved with it, without once setting a paw on the ink.

"Have you noticed that?" Danny whispered.

"Yeah."

"It's like it doesn't trust the guy."

"It's a dog. Dogs don't trust people who stand across the street in hats."

"That's actually a really good policy," said Danny.

We'd been walking for what felt like a quarter of an hour when the argument started.

I'd like to say it was dramatic. It was mostly three tired people with different opinions.

"I'm not saying he's a villain," said Danny. "I'm saying we keep following people because they know the way. The museum guy knew the way. The paper guy knew the way. And every time, there's a *surprise*."

"Aurelio's the reason we have the paper," I said.

"Which means he planned something. Which means he planned *us*."

"He planned something to help us!"

"Maybe!" Danny threw up both hands, which tugged the cable and nearly pulled me off the ramp. "I'm just saying that 'trust me, follow the ink' is how horror movies start."

"We're in a horror movie," said Xolotl, without turning around.

"*Thank* you."

"I did not say I disagreed." The god stopped on the stairs, ears low. "I have been thinking about Aurelio Valdivia since the courtyard. He wrote to his daughter to give the mirror away. He left ink on the floor. He brought paper to a place where we would need it. These are the actions of a man who knows a great deal. They are also the actions of a man who made a bargain."

"What bargain?" I asked.

"I do not know. That is the trouble." Xolotl glanced back at me, and for the first time his ember eyes looked genuinely afraid. "My brother does not take payment in coin. A man who bargains with Tezcatlipoca pays in what he loves. And Aurelio loved his daughter, and his family's mirror, and a great many secrets."

"So you think he sold something."

"I think he *spent* something. I do not know what." He started walking again. "I promised to tell you everything I know. That is everything I know. It is not much, and I do not like it."

Nobody said anything for a long time after that.

I held my wrist out in front of me. The silver line along my forearm was glowing a little brighter than it had at the top of the ramp, a soft, steady pulse, like a very slow heartbeat. I'd been trying not to look at it. Every time I did, I could feel something tugging at the edge of my mind, like a word I couldn't remember and couldn't stop trying to.

I realized I couldn't tell what the toll had taken this time. That was the worst part. I knew my name. I knew Abuela's street, or at least I knew that Danny knew it. But somewhere in the last hour, something small had slipped out of my pocket, and I'd never know what.

"Hey," said Danny quietly, as if he'd read my mind. "Anything?"

"I don't know."

"Okay." He bumped my shoulder. "Then I'll keep an eye on the list."

I didn't ask what list. I just knew he meant it.

The ramp ended at a fork.

It was a plain stone landing, wide enough for four people, with two ways onward. On the left, the path continued the way we'd come: a smooth, broad ribbon of black stone, lined with wet ink footprints that kept going into the dark. On the right, a narrow ledge ran out into nothing, thin as a diving board, and it looked like it hadn't been used in a long time.

On the ledge, one after another, glowed a line of small silver footprints.

They were child-sized. They were faint, flickering, the color of moonlight on water. Each one was only a little bigger than my own hand.

I'd seen a mark like that before. Xolotl had described it, sixty-four years ago, on the floor of a museum.

"Joaquín," I whispered.

The silver line on my arm blazed up like a flashlight. I gasped and clutched it with my other hand, and for one second I swear I felt a pulse in my wrist that wasn't mine, small and quick and a little scared.

"It's pointing at them," Danny said. "Your arm is pointing at the footprints."

"I know."

"The ink goes left," said Xolotl. His voice was tight. "That is Aurelio's road. It is wide, it is safe, and it is open. The silver prints go right. That ledge is nothing. It is a path that was made and then forgotten, and I do not know whether it will hold."

"Can we do both?"

"No."

I looked at the two roads. I thought of Aurelio's message: *Ask him what the priests never asked.* I thought of Abuela on the roof with a candle. I thought of a twelve-year-old who had stopped halfway through a mirror and said two words nobody had understood for sixty-four years.

"I want to follow the footprints," I said.

Xolotl didn't answer right away.

"If we follow the ink, we know where we are going," he said. "If we follow the silver, we are guessing."

"Yeah."

"It may be a trap."

"Yeah."

"It may be your great-uncle's last trail."

I met his eyes. "Yeah."

Danny looked at the narrow ledge, then at the ink road, then at the cable on his wrist. He let out a very long, very tired breath.

"If this is a horror movie," he said, "this is the part where we split up."

"We're not splitting up."

"Obviously. That's why I'm saying it." He held up his wrist. "I'm just saying I want credit."

We went right.

I don't know how else to describe it. The ledge was barely a foot wide, and I could feel the cold draft pulling at my sneakers. Below us was a gulf so deep it looked like a smear of ink. The cable hummed between Danny and me, tight as a guitar string.

The brown dog went first.

It didn't hesitate. It trotted out onto the silver prints without a pause, tail wagging, one paw in each glowing footprint, as steady as if it had been there a hundred times. At the third print, it stopped and glanced back at us. I swear it looked impatient.

"Okay," said Xolotl. His voice was shaking. "The dog thinks it will hold."

"The dog knows something we don't."

"The dog has *always* known something we do not," said Xolotl, and then, quietly, almost to himself, "which is exactly what I am afraid of."

We stepped onto the ledge, one at a time, and the silver prints flared under our feet like warm stones. They were small. My sneakers barely fit. At each step, I felt a faint, tingling pulse in my arm, like a hand squeezing mine.

I counted breaths. *One. Two. Three.*

"Mateo?"

"Yeah?"

"Do you hear that?"

I listened. Behind us, from the fork, there came a faint scratching, like a fountain pen on rough paper.

I turned my head.

A man was standing at the fork.

He hadn't been there when we left. He stood at the edge of the wide road, exactly where the ink trail ended, in a gray suit and a gray hat with the brim pulled low. He was perfectly still, one foot lifted slightly off the ground, as if he'd been caught mid-stride.

"Aurelio," said Xolotl.

He wasn't frozen. I realized that when I looked closer. He was moving, just very, very slowly. His chin lifted a quarter of an inch while I watched. His right hand rose from his coat pocket

like a leaf falling upward, and the fingertips of it were dripping black.

"He's in slow time," Danny whispered. "Like the sun, like the clocks, like..."

"Like the mirror," I said.

The man's hand reached up, slow as sap, and began to write on the air. The ink hung there, trembling, shaping itself into words I could read from forty feet away. Each letter took a full breath to form.

N...

O...

T...

"Not *what?*" Danny hissed.

"Not that way," said Xolotl. "He is telling us not to..."

...M...

E.

Not me.

We waited. The ink hung there, dripping, and I realized I'd forgotten to breathe. Aurelio's face was in shadow under the hat, but I could see his jaw working as he fought through the thick, syrupy air to get the next word out.

H...

I...

M.

Not me. Him.

I stared at the words. The silver line on my arm went completely still, as if it were holding its breath, too.

"He isn't leading us to himself," I said. "He's leading us to Joaquín."

Xolotl didn't speak. I'd never seen him look so lost.

The ink began to fade. The man in the gray hat lowered his hand, slowly, back into his pocket, and turned his face, just slightly, toward us. For one second I saw his eyes under the brim. They were wet and bright and very tired, and I understood something I hadn't before.

He couldn't come any further.

Whatever Aurelio Valdivia had done, whatever he'd paid, this was the end of the road for him. He could write on air and leave ink in the dark, and he could mark a trail for a boy who wasn't his own. But he couldn't walk where Joaquín had walked. That was another door.

He lifted two fingers to the brim of his hat, the way you would to a stranger across a street.

Then he vanished.

We walked the rest of the ledge in silence.

The silver footprints led down, and down, and then around a long curve, and after a very long time the ledge widened into a stairway, and the stairway sloped into a tunnel, and the tunnel ended in a round stone chamber with a low, slow pulse of light at the center.

I stopped on the threshold.

Danny's cable tugged on my wrist. I felt his shoulder against mine, warm and solid, and I heard Xolotl's quick, shallow breathing behind us.

In the middle of the chamber, on a plain stone floor, stood a single silver footprint.

It wasn't a flat print. It was deep, as if somebody had stepped here and kept standing, and it glowed brighter than all the others, a pale, steady silver, and inside it, like a coin at the bottom of a well, shimmered a tiny reflection of a face.

It wasn't mine.

Chapter Seventeen: The Boy Who Stopped

At first I thought the chamber was empty.

It was a round room of smooth gray stone, about the size of Abuela's kitchen, with a low ceiling and no furniture. In the center, the deep silver footprint glowed like a coin on the bottom of a pool. Beside it, against the far wall, stood something I'd taken for a stone arch: a tall, narrow frame of black glass with nothing in the middle of it, like a window with no house behind it.

Then the silver line on my arm gave a little tug, the way you tug a friend's sleeve, and I saw him.

He was sitting on the floor against the frame with his knees pulled up, so still I'd mistaken him for part of the wall. He was a boy, maybe fourteen, thin as a coat hanger, with black hair that stuck up in the back and a gray shirt buttoned all the way to the collar. His pants were

too short. His shoes had been patched with something that looked like leather and a lot of patience.

He looked at me. I looked at him. And I felt the strangest thing: I knew his face.

It was the face from every picture in Abuela's hallway. The one boy in the old, curled photographs, with the crooked grin and the big ears. He had the same ears. He had her chin.

"You," said the boy, "are very loud."

I hadn't said anything.

"Your *shoes,*" he said, and pointed at my sneakers. "They squeak."

"Sorry," I said.

"It's all right. It's been a long time since anything squeaked."

His voice was quiet and dry, like a person who'd forgotten how to be heard. And when he got to his feet, slowly, using the wall for balance, I saw the thing that had been bothering me.

His left hand wasn't finished.

It started out normal. A wrist, a palm, a thumb. But past the second knuckle the fingers got fainter, like a drawing someone had begun in pencil and never gotten around to coloring in. The sleeve of his shirt did the same thing, going from solid gray cotton to thin, pale mist at the cuff. When he moved his arm, the mist moved a little late.

He saw me looking.

"I know," he said. "I try not to look at it either."

Nobody spoke. I couldn't. Behind me, Danny's cable went taut, and I heard Xolotl take one small, shaky step forward and stop.

"I know you," said the boy. He was looking past me. "I'd know you anywhere. You still have your tie."

"Joaquín," said Xolotl. His voice cracked like an old record. "I..."

"Don't." The boy held up his good hand. "Please. Don't say sorry yet. I've had a very long time to imagine what you'd say, and I'm not ready."

Xolotl closed his mouth. His whole body sagged.

"You looked at me like I was already gone," said Joaquín, quietly. "In the museum. When I turned around. I remember that part better than anything. Everyone else was looking at the glass, and you were looking at *me,* and your face said you'd already decided." He shrugged, a thin, tired shrug. "I didn't like it."

"I know," said Xolotl. "I do not blame you."

"Good." He took a breath. "I'll tell you when I'm ready to hear it."

It was the most dignified thing I'd ever seen anyone do to a god.

Then he turned back to me, and the dry, careful look in his eyes sharpened into something I recognized, because I'd seen it on Abuela when I told her I'd already done my homework.

"Who are you?" he said. "And don't say a priest."

"I'm not a priest."

"You've got the look. You came down here to finish it." He took a step back, the unfinished hand rising a little. "They sent another one. Didn't they? They sent another kid to do what I wouldn't."

"No!" I said. "No. Nobody sent me. I'm not here to put you back."

"Everyone says that."

"I'm Mateo," I said. "I'm Remedios's grandson."

For one second his whole face went blank.

"Remedios," said Joaquín.

"She's alive. She's eighty. She's... she's okay." I swallowed. "She's pretty much the toughest person I know."

The boy didn't move. He seemed to be holding his breath.

Then, in a tiny voice, he asked the last thing I expected.

"Did she ever learn to drive?"

I'll tell you what I thought I'd have to explain.

The Binding. The sun. The mirror. Sixty-four years of things nobody told him. I'd spent two chapters of my life, in this book alone, rehearsing the speech.

What I actually said was: "She drives a Buick."

"A *Buick*."

"A blue one. She drives thirty-eight miles an hour. She parks on flower beds if she's in a hurry."

Joaquín stared at me. Then, very slowly, the corner of his mouth went up, and I saw it, the crooked grin, the big ears, the face from the hallway wall.

"She was so scared of the car," he said. "In Puebla, when Papá taught her. She stalled it in the plaza eleven times. I counted." His voice wobbled. "I used to laugh at her. She'd chase me around the fountain with a shoe."

"She still does that," I said. "With me."

He made a sound I'd have called a laugh if it hadn't come out of such a broken place. His good hand went to his mouth, and for a while he didn't say anything at all. He just stood there, a boy in patched shoes, with his shoulders shaking, and I stood there with him.

Danny, behind me, was very carefully looking at the ceiling.

"Okay," said Joaquín finally, wiping his face. "Okay. So she's alive. And she's mean. That's good." He let out a long breath. "That's very good."

"Hi," said Danny, raising the hand with the cable on it. "I'm the friend. I tied myself to your great-nephew with this."

Joaquín squinted at the white cord. "That's... a rope?"

"It's a charging cable."

"A *what?*"

"Never mind. It's complicated." Danny waved it. "It keeps us from getting lost."

"It's very thin," said Joaquín, politely.

"It's got three prongs."

I decided not to explain that one.

We sat on the floor in a circle, around the silver footprint, which seemed to be the only thing in the room that felt warm. Joaquín sat cross-legged with his good hand on his knee and his bad one tucked into his lap. The brown dog lay beside him, chin on his sneaker, and I watched his fingers go absently to its ear.

"She knows you," I said.

"She's always known me." He didn't look up. "I thought she was a dream, at first. A very patient dream."

"I'm sorry, *she?*" said Danny.

"The dog."

"You can't just say that and not say *anything*."

"I can't," said Joaquín. "I don't know her name either." He looked up, a little ashamed. "I know she isn't mine. I know she's... on loan."

I wanted to push. But I'd learned something about asking in the last twelve levels, which is that sometimes people tell you things better if you leave a space.

"I've been trying to understand something," I said instead. "A man wrote me a message. He said, 'Ask him what the priests never asked.' I think I know what it is."

Joaquín waited.

"Did you want to?" I said. "Did you ever want to do it? Go into the mirror, be the lock?"

For a long time he didn't speak. I could hear the cable humming, and the very faint, very far sound of dry wind.

"No," he said at last. "Not like that. Not alone. Nobody asked me, you know. They told me what it was. They told me how brave I'd be." His eyes were distant. "I was twelve. I wanted to be brave. I wanted Remedios to be proud. And I remember thinking that if *everyone* said it was an honor, it must be."

"But you stopped."

"But I stopped."

"Why?"

His good hand closed around the dog's fur. The pale, unfinished one flickered at the edge of his sleeve, like a candle trying not to go out.

"Because I heard them," he said. "When I put my hand through the glass. When I was halfway in, and everyone was holding their breath." He frowned. "I heard hands."

"Hands?"

"Hundreds of them. Thousands." His voice dropped. "I saw them, too. I know that doesn't make sense. But I saw them all holding on to the same door, from every direction, all at once. Old hands, young hands. Hands that had never met each other. And I understood..."

He stopped.

His eyes went wide. The faint, mist-like edge of his sleeve went suddenly ragged, as if someone had pulled a thread, and I saw his unfinished fingers fade a little more.

"I understood that it wouldn't," he whispered. "That it *couldn't.* Not like that. Not..."

"Not what?"

"I can't." He pressed the heel of his good hand against his forehead. "I can't. It goes away. It always goes away when I try to say the last part. It's like trying to hold smoke." His voice broke. "I know I knew. I knew for about a second. And then it was gone."

"It's the toll," said Xolotl, very quietly.

"I know it's the toll." He sounded furious. "I've had sixty-four years to know what it is."

Danny cleared his throat.

"Okay, question," he said. "You can't say it here. But what if you weren't here?"

Joaquín looked at him.

"The thing I've figured out," Danny said, "is that Mictlan takes what you carry. It takes it down here, where it's stored. But Mateo's been losing stuff and I've been losing stuff, and we keep... getting it back. By saying it to each other. By holding it for somebody else." He swallowed. "Maybe if you said it to somebody up there, in the light, instead of down here in the dark..."

"I can't leave," said Joaquín. "That's the point."

"Why not?"

He nodded toward the silver footprint in the middle of the floor, and I saw, for the first time, that the light around it wasn't coming *from* the footprint. It was coming from a thin, bright thread that ran from the center of the print up through the dark ceiling, vanishing into the stone.

"That's not me holding it," he said. "That's what's left of what I started. When I stopped halfway, the lock caught me. I'm not holding the door open on purpose. I'm just the part that got stuck." His good hand trembled. "If I step out of it, the crack closes. And I don't know what it does to the sun."

"What *might* it do?" I asked.

"It might let it go faster."

I did the math. I did it fast, because I'd been doing a lot of math lately. A sun that was stuck

at 4:47. An hour above for every night below. A boy who'd been caught half-open for sixty-four years, with one hand he couldn't see.

"You've been holding it the whole time," I said.

"I haven't been holding it," said Joaquín. "I've been *stuck*. It's different. It's much less brave."

"It sounds pretty brave to me."

"It sounds *tired,*" he said, and gave me a small, crooked smile that wrecked me.

I remember what happened next very clearly, even though it only took a few seconds.

I took the clay bowl out of my pocket. It was warm. The little ember in it was still glowing, steady and gold, the way it had since the beasts. I held it out to Joaquín on my open palm, the way I'd learned to.

"Light it anyway," I said.

He looked at the bowl. He looked at me.

"That's Mamá's," he said. His voice was barely there. "That's what Mamá used to say. *If you can't find a sunrise, light it anyway.*"

"Abuela said it to me. Before I came down."

"She *remembers*."

"She never stopped saying it."

Joaquín's eyes filled. He reached out slowly with his good hand and touched the rim of the bowl. The ember brightened, flared, and sent up a thin, straight thread of smoke. It went *up*. Of course it did. This was the first thing in Mictlan that had.

"I don't know how long I can stay out," he said. "I don't know what happens when I leave. I might fade. I might not. And I might be wrong about everything I think I know."

"You might."

"But nobody asked me," said Joaquín. "Not once, in sixty-four years. And now somebody has."

He stood up.

I held my breath. Danny's cable went tight. Xolotl, behind us, made a tiny sound, like a man seeing a ghost.

Joaquín Ibarra, who had been twelve when he vanished and looked fourteen now, stepped out of the silver footprint.

The light in the room changed.

The thread that ran up through the ceiling snapped, with a note like a plucked string. The silver footprint dimmed to a smear. And the unfinished half of Joaquín's body, which had been flickering for as long as I'd known him, *filled in*. His fingers went solid. His sleeve turned to gray cotton. His breath came in a long, shocked gasp, and he looked down at his own hand like someone seeing it for the first time.

"Oh," he said. "Oh, I'd *forgotten*."

"Does it hurt?" I asked.

"No." He laughed, shaky and astonished. "It feels like pins and needles. It feels like waking up."

He tried to take a step and his knees folded like a lawn chair. Danny and I caught him before he hit the floor.

"Sorry," he said, laughing weakly. "I think I forgot how legs go."

He pressed his hand to his temple. "The rest of it didn't come back with my fingers," he muttered. "The hands I saw. The last part. It's still gone."

Then the ceiling began to tap.

Tap. *Tap*. *Tap*.

Not from the mirror frame. Not from the floor. From above us, from the thick black stone of the roof, slow and patient and perfectly even, like fingernails on a tabletop in a very large room.

Xolotl's ears went flat.

"He has been listening," he whispered. "He has been listening this whole time."

Joaquín grabbed my sleeve. He was fourteen, and thin, and solid, and very, very scared.

"Mateo," he said. "I think I've just opened the door."

Chapter Eighteen: The Man With One Foot

For a long moment, nobody moved.

The tapping had stopped. The stone above us hung low and black and silent, and the only sound in the chamber was Joaquín's breath, ragged and fast, and the faint hum of the cable between Danny's wrist and mine.

"Okay," said Danny, in a very small voice. "Is anyone else hearing the part where it stopped?"

"Yes," said Xolotl.

"That's worse."

"Yes."

Joaquín was sitting against the wall, flexing his restored fingers like he was checking they'd stay. He looked up at me, and I saw that he wasn't a scared kid anymore. He was something quieter. A person who'd been scared for so long that he'd run out of ways to show it.

"He's here," he said. "I know his step. I've been listening to it for sixty-four years."

"*Who's* here?"

"Come out, little brother," said a voice from the ceiling. "You're standing on the part of the floor I'd like to see."

The voice was warm. That was what got me.

I'd expected a growl or a hiss or the same cold, amused purr I'd heard in the mirror in the museum. This sounded like the nicest teacher in school, the one who stays late to help you with fractions. It came from everywhere at once and from nowhere, soft and unhurried, and it made my skin crawl in a way I couldn't explain.

The stone over the silver footprint rippled like the surface of a pond. A smear of smoke curled down from the ceiling and thickened into something that stood. Then a man stepped out of the dark, one slow step at a time, and the smoke peeled off him like a coat.

He was tall. He wore a long gray jacket and a loose white shirt open at the neck, and his hair was black and wavy and a little too long, the way old photographs of poets look. He was handsome in a tired, thoughtful way, with deep-set eyes and high cheekbones and a mouth that seemed on the verge of a joke. His skin was dark with spots, faint as freckles, on his arms and neck: the same spots as the jaguar eyes in the mirror.

And his right foot wasn't a foot.

Where it should have been, there was a disk of polished black stone, as wide as a dinner

plate. It had been fitted to the end of his leg with silver bands, and it clicked softly on the floor with every step, like a coin spinning on a table.

In its glass, I could see the whole room reflected, upside down.

"Hello," said Tezcatlipoca, and smiled at me. "Little Quetzal. You walked through my wind. You held the bowl open. I watched." His eyes crinkled. "I will admit I nearly stopped you. And then I was glad I hadn't."

I couldn't speak.

"Brother," said Xolotl.

"Little dog." Tezcatlipoca didn't look at him. "I was wondering when you'd find the courage."

I'd like to tell you we did something brave. In truth, nobody did anything. Danny's hand had found my sleeve, and Joaquín had gotten to his feet and was standing very straight, shoulders back, like a boy who'd decided in advance that he wouldn't look afraid.

"You're Joaquín," said Tezcatlipoca, turning to him, and his voice dropped to something gentle. "Remedios's little brother. The boy who stopped."

"Yes," said Joaquín.

"I should like to say thank you."

Joaquín blinked. "What?"

"For stopping." Tezcatlipoca took a slow step closer, the stone foot clicking. "I have watched a great many children walk up to that glass. Some of them were brave. Some of them were frightened. All of them were told it was an honor. And you were the only one who turned around."

"I'm sorry?" said Danny. "Is the bad guy saying he *likes* him?"

"I am saying he was right," said Tezcatlipoca, without looking away from Joaquín. "I have never once said otherwise. The Binding is a cruelty. It was always a cruelty. A world so afraid of the dark that it feeds a child to the lock every fifty-two years." He shook his head sadly. "My brother helped build it. Did he tell you that?"

I looked at Xolotl. Xolotl didn't answer. His ears were flat to his skull.

"I tried to stop it," Tezcatlipoca said. "More than once. They called it rebellion. I called it mercy. We have been fighting about it for a very long time."

He crouched in front of Joaquín. He did it slowly, the way you do with a nervous animal, and his black foot-mirror tipped up on its edge, so that I could see a reflection in it that wasn't of the room.

It was a roof. A flat roof patched with tar, at sunrise, with a ring of bricks and a clay bowl and a tiny woman in a faded blue dress with her back to us, one hand pressed to her hip, climbing a ladder very slowly in the dark.

"Remedios," Joaquín whispered.

"Every morning," said Tezcatlipoca. "Sixty-four years. She does not know you are alive. She does not know she is the last. She goes up that ladder because she made a promise to a little brother she could not save."

Joaquín made a small noise. His hand came up to his mouth.

"You could see her," said Tezcatlipoca. "Truly see her. Not through glass. In the flesh. As she was, in Puebla, in the plaza, with a shoe in one hand and her hair coming down." He smiled. "I could give you that."

"How?" said Joaquín.

"There is a place I have been building. A place the old priests would have called a mistake, and I call a mercy." He opened one hand, palm up. "It is quiet, and it is kind. In it, nothing is taken. No one goes up a ladder in the dark. No one is asked to be brave. No child ever stands at a mirror again. Every moment that was ever good is simply... kept."

"The Still Sun," said Xolotl.

"Do not say it like that," said Tezcatlipoca, almost laughing. "You make it sound like a prison."

"It is a prison."

"It is a *rest*."

I looked at Joaquín's face. I'd seen him angry and scared and heartbroken in the last half hour. But I hadn't seen him tempted. It crossed his face like a shadow across a window, and it was the worst thing I've ever watched. Because I understood it. I understood exactly why a boy who'd been alone for sixty-four years in the dark, who'd never gotten to see his sister grow up, who'd had nobody to ask, might want a place where nobody ever got taken away from anybody.

"It's real," said Tezcatlipoca, to me, softly. "That's what they will not tell you, little Quetzal. It is not a trap. It is a gift. I only want to take away the part that hurts."

"You sent a cloud," I said, in a voice I hardly recognized. "And star demons. They chased us down Broadway."

"I sent an *invitation.*" He tilted his head. "You declined. I am nothing if not a patient host."

"You told Dr. Quiroga the sun would only pause."

"I told Dr. Quiroga the truth." His eyes glittered. "That it would pause. I never said for how long. People are so eager to hear the part they want."

"That's not..."

"And you," said Tezcatlipoca, turning his head. His gaze landed on Danny. Danny went very still. "Rain on hot iron. Do you know, I haven't smelled that in three hundred years." He smiled, and this time it was a thin and strange thing. "I know whose blood is under that rain, boy. I know why the nails sing for you. Ask your Watcher what he made, and what he swore."

"Leave him *alone,*" I said.

"I would never hurt him," said Tezcatlipoca. "I have never hurt anyone. I only ever ask."

"That's what people say when they get to decide what 'hurt' means," I said.

He only smiled.

It was Joaquín who broke the silence.

He'd been staring into the black foot-mirror, where the small, tired figure of his sister was still climbing, step by step, toward a sun that wouldn't rise. His jaw was working. His restored hand was clenched at his side. When he finally spoke, his voice was small and level, like a boy reading something very difficult out loud.

"What happens to the people still alive?"

Tezcatlipoca's smile didn't move. "I beg your pardon?"

"When the world stops changing. The ones who are still alive." He swallowed. "My sister's eighty. When you say 'kept,' do you mean she stays eighty? Or does she go back to sixteen?"

"Whichever she would like."

"But she'd *have* to stay," said Joaquín. "Wouldn't she. She'd have to stay in one of them forever. Nobody would be allowed to... get older. Or go away. Or get better."

"Nobody would be hurt."

"Nobody would be *anything,*" said Joaquín.

For the first time, something in Tezcatlipoca's face flickered, a quick, thin crack in the warm veneer, like glass under a hot light.

"You are asking me," Joaquín went on, "and I want you to know I noticed. It's the first time anyone has asked me anything in sixty-four years. I've been waiting a very long time for someone to ask what I want." His eyes were bright and furious. "But you're not asking *me.* You're asking me to say yes for her. And for Mateo. And for the man with the ladder. You want me to say yes for everyone, so you don't have to ask them."

The room was perfectly silent.

"I was told what it was," said Joaquín. "I was told it was an honor. And now you're telling me what it'll be, and it sounds so *nice.*" He shook his head. "I'm sorry. I'm so tired. But no."

"No?" said Tezcatlipoca, softly.

"I'm not going to be your answer, either." He lifted his chin. "I've been a lot of people's answer. I'd like to find out what I am when I'm not."

For a long moment, the man with the foot of glass looked at him.

Then he straightened up, brushed the knees of his gray trousers, and sighed, long and sad and patient, like a man whose favorite student had just failed a test.

"I am sorry to hear it," he said.

The air changed. I felt it in my teeth. The room went colder, and the little smears of silver around the footprint dimmed. The thread of light that had held the door open for sixty-four years was gone, and in its place, a crack ran across the stone ceiling, thin as a hair, and began to widen.

"You've opened the door, Joaquín," said Tezcatlipoca. "That was kind. That was very kind of you. But I'm afraid you've let in more than you realize, and the sun is moving a great deal faster now." He glanced at me. "Three days, Mateo. I give you one."

"One what?"

"One day." He smiled. "To think. To rest. To decide whether you would rather save a world that has never once asked you what you want, or help me build one that will."

Xolotl lunged. A crackle of lightning flared along his shoulders, white and furious. "*Brother,*" he snarled. "*Enough.*"

"Careful, little dog." Tezcatlipoca didn't flinch. "You would hurt the boys."

He was right. The lightning wavered. Xolotl's ears flattened, and the light died along his fur.

And then the brown dog stood up.

It hadn't made a sound. It crossed the chamber and sat down on the silver footprint, in the exact center of the room, directly between us and the man with the foot of glass. One white ear flicked. It looked up at Tezcatlipoca with eyes that were calm and old and very, very kind.

Tezcatlipoca went still.

I'd seen him smile and sigh and flinch. I had not seen him hesitate. He looked at the dog for what felt like a full minute, and the stone foot clicked once against the floor, and he took one small step *back*.

"Not you," he said, very quietly. "Not here."

The dog didn't move.

"I did not know you would come," said Tezcatlipoca.

It was the first time I'd ever seen him look surprised, and I wasn't sure I liked it.

"Three days was before he stepped out of the footprint," Xolotl said, low and quick. "I do not know what it is now."

"The frame," said Xolotl. "*Now.*"

I didn't understand until I looked. The tall black-glass frame at the back of the chamber, the thing I'd taken for a stone arch, had begun to glow. The empty middle of it had gone a deep, shining silver, like a mirror full of moonlight, and through it, very faintly, I could see steps. A long, narrow stair of tiny silver footprints, climbing up and up into a warm, yellow light.

"It's a door," said Joaquín, in wonder. "It's the *rest of my door.* I started it, and I never finished it, and..." He turned to us. "It goes up!"

"The footprint was where I stopped," he said. "The frame is the door I started. When I stepped out, it finished opening on its own."

"Then *go!*" said Xolotl.

We ran. Danny and I went first, tied together, bumping into each other like kids in a three-legged race. Joaquín followed, still unsteady on his newly working legs, with the brown dog at his heels. Xolotl came last, backing up with his eyes on his brother, his shoulders crackling.

Behind us, I heard Tezcatlipoca speak one last time. His voice was soft, sad, almost fond.

"When you are tired, little Quetzal, come and find me. I will be exactly where she left the sun."

I looked back.

He was standing in the middle of the room, in a gray jacket and a white shirt, with a foot of black glass and a crooked, kindly smile. And in the mirror of his foot, very small, very far away, a woman in a blue dress reached the top of a ladder and set a candle on a roof.

Then the glass swallowed us, and the stairs began to rise.

Far below, in the dark, I heard it one last time.

Tap.

Chapter Nineteen: The Shoe

The stairs went up for a very long time.

They weren't like the spiral ramp. This was a narrow, steep, ordinary staircase, like the one in our apartment building, except that every step was a silver footprint and every landing smelled like a different decade. One smelled like new carpet. One smelled like a bus station. One, I swear, smelled exactly like my abuela's kitchen at six in the morning, and I stopped on it for a full second without meaning to.

"Keep going," Xolotl said gently, behind me. "You will be there soon."

Joaquín climbed slowly, one hand on the wall, the brown dog pacing beside him. He'd stopped talking a while ago. Every few steps his knees would wobble, and Danny, who was closest, would silently put out a hand until he steadied.

"Here," said Danny, digging in his backpack. "You need to eat something."

Joaquín stared at the foil-wrapped bar in his hand. "What is it?"

"Granola. It's got oats and honey and chocolate chips."

"It's *shiny.*"

"That's the wrapper. You don't eat the wrapper."

"I'm not an animal," said Joaquín, with dignity. He peeled it open, took a bite, and went completely still. His eyes got very wide.

"Is it okay?" I asked.

"It is," he said, in a tiny voice, "the best thing I have ever tasted."

"It's from a *gas station,*" said Danny.

"I don't know what that is, and I never want to be told."

I used the climb to ask the question I'd been holding in since the chamber.

"Xolotl. The dog."

He didn't pretend not to understand. He was walking last, ears low, and every so often I caught him glancing at the brown dog with the same expression I'd seen him wear around Abuela. Respect, mostly. And something under it that looked a lot like fear.

"I will tell you what I know," he said. "Not all of it. I swore to tell you everything I know, and I will honor that. But I do not know very much about her." He took a breath. "She has no name I can say. She walks the road of the dead. That road is hers, in a way that no god owns anything. My brother cannot lay a hand on anyone who walks it beside her. That is why he stepped back."

"So she's like a... bodyguard."

"She is not a guard. She cannot choose where anyone goes. She cannot stop a god from speaking. She cannot make anyone do anything." His ears flicked. "She can only walk beside you, and make certain that the road stays a road."

"That's a lot."

"It is the most important thing in the underworld," said Xolotl quietly. "And it is not enough to save a sun."

I looked down at the brown dog. She looked up at me, one white ear flicking, tail swinging once, slowly, like a wave. I got the same feeling I'd had at the river, of being looked at by someone very old who had decided to be kind about it.

"Who is she?" I asked.

"It is not mine to say."

"That's a cop-out."

"It is also true." He sighed. "And I am afraid of the answer. Do you want that on the record, too?"

I did, actually. I just didn't say so.

Danny walked beside me without talking. He had his phone in one hand, though there was no signal, and he kept thumbing the screen like it might say something useful.

"You okay?" I asked.

"Yeah."

"Danny."

"Okay, no." He let out a breath. "He said 'ask your Watcher what he made, and what he swore.' And the Watcher said he was sorry I'd *inherited* this. That's a weird word. You don't inherit a thing you're born with. You inherit a thing somebody *leaves* you."

"Yeah."

"So what did he leave me?" He kicked a silver footprint, lightly. "What did he *make?*"

"I don't know."

"And what did he *swear?*"

"I don't know that either." I bumped his shoulder with mine, which tugged the cable. "But he didn't hurt you. The nails sang for you. The gate waited for you. And a three-hundred-year-old guy behind an iron door was relieved to hear your name."

"Relieved isn't the same as safe."

"Nope." I thought about it. "But it's not the same as *scary,* either."

Danny didn't say anything for four or five steps. Then he said, "I'd like to meet him again."

"Okay."

"When this is over. I'd like to ask him a lot of questions."

"I'll hold the flashlight," I said.

The staircase ended in smoke.

It was warm and thick and smelled like copal and marigolds and the very faint cinnamon of a woman who'd been standing in the same place for far too long. I felt it before I saw it: a hum in the air that wasn't a sound, like the moment just before a bell finishes ringing.

"Is it...?" said Danny.

"It's her roof," I whispered.

"It's her *bowl,*" said Joaquín. He'd stopped on the last step with his good hand on his chest. "The smoke goes *up*."

We climbed into it.

I don't know how to describe the next few seconds, except to say that it felt like swimming up through a warm lake toward a patch of orange light. The stairs thinned, and thinned, and then my head broke through a ring of bricks, and I was standing on Abuela's roof, in the middle of her offering bowl, with smoke curling off my shoulders and the sun hanging low over San Antonio.

It was still 4:47.

But it wasn't *right*. The bottom edge of the sun had gone dull, like a coin that had been dipped in ink. A slow, thin crescent of shadow was creeping up from the horizon, and I could see it, actually see it, inching along the rim.

I turned around.

Abuela was standing at the ladder with a tin lantern in one hand and a ledger under her arm. Ofelia was beside her, in her gray cardigan, with the phone to her ear and a pencil in her hair. They both stared at us. Abuela's mouth was already open to say *Mateo*.

Then Joaquín climbed out of the smoke behind me.

I'd like to say there was music, or a gasp, or a cry. There wasn't. There was just wind.

Abuela didn't run. She stood perfectly still, the lantern in her hand, and her face did something I'd never seen it do. It wasn't surprise. It was something slower than surprise. It was the face of a woman who has been carrying a very heavy thing for so long that when someone takes it away, she doesn't know where to put her arms.

"Joaquín," she said.

"Remedios," he said.

She took a step. He took a step. They were about ten feet apart, and neither of them seemed to be able to cover the distance.

"You're so *small,*" said Abuela.

"You're so *old,*" said Joaquín, and then clapped a hand over his mouth. "I'm sorry. I didn't mean... I meant..."

"I am eighty years old," said Abuela. "It is allowed to say."

He laughed. It came out wet and strange. "You've got my chin," he said. "Or I have yours."

"It was always mine."

"It's a good chin."

"It is a *stubborn* chin," said Abuela. "And you left it, and you went into a mirror, and you never came *back*." Her voice shook. "Sixty-four years, *niño*. I put out water. I put out candles. I climbed that ladder every morning, with these *knees,* and I said your name to the sun."

"I know," he whispered. "I saw."

She took off her slipper.

I had a very bad moment. I thought she was going to cry, or faint, or say something I'd never be able to forget. Instead she crossed the last ten feet in about two steps, holding a pink rubber house slipper in her fist, and smacked her little brother on the shoulder with it, once, hard.

"*Ay!*"

"That," said Abuela, "is for the plaza."

"I was *twelve!*"

"You are *still* twelve!"

"I'm fourteen!"

"You are a *fool,*" said Abuela, and dropped the slipper, and threw both arms around him so hard that his feet left the ground.

I looked away. Danny looked away. Ofelia, who had been trying to hold the phone and a pencil and a ledger and her composure all at the same time, finally gave up on the composure.

Xolotl stood at the edge of the roof with his head bowed, ears flat, so still he could've been a statue. Even from where I was standing, I could see his shoulders shaking.

It took a long time. When Abuela finally set Joaquín down, she didn't let go of his sleeve. She looked at him, and looked at him, and then she put both hands on either side of his face, the way she does with me when I've had a fever.

"I do not know how to hold you," she said quietly. "You are not who I remember. And I am not who you remember. I think that must be a very strange thing."

"I don't know how to *be* held," said Joaquín.

"Then we will learn." She wiped her eyes with the heel of her hand. "I am very slow. I will have to teach myself."

"I'm very slow, too."

"Good," said Abuela. "Then we are the same."

I thought that might be the end of it. But Joaquín took one step back, still holding her hand, and looked at the roof, the sun, the strange creeping shadow on the horizon.

"I'm so sorry," he said. "I opened the door."

"I know," said Abuela. She looked at me, and her face did the other thing it does, the one that's stronger than sad. "Mateo. Tell me."

So I told her.

It took about ten minutes. I told her about the wind and the beasts and the ink, and about Aurelio, and Ofelia sat down very suddenly on the edge of the roof and said "He's alive" and then "No, he's *late,*" and then she didn't say anything else for a while. I told her about the man with one foot, and the Still Sun, and the offer.

I told her about Joaquín saying no.

"*Ay, mijo,*" said Abuela, to her brother, in a voice I'd never heard. "Good."

I told her about the sun.

"One day, he said. And that's if he wasn't lying. Xolotl says three days was before the footprint broke."

"It is not a lie," said Ofelia, very quietly. She looked pale. She'd gotten off the phone. "I've been calling the others. The thirty." She glanced at Abuela, then back at the ledger. "Of the thirty, eleven answered. Nine lit their candles."

"And the other two?"

"One said she had forgotten how." Ofelia swallowed. "The other said she did not believe in it."

Nobody spoke. The shadow on the sun crept a little further up the rim.

"Nine out of thirty," said Danny. "That's... not enough."

"It is nine *more* than there were this morning," said Abuela. "Do not count what is gone, mijo. Count what is lit."

It was Joaquín who said it, in the end.

"I don't remember the last part," he said. "What I heard. The hands. But I think... I think I could, if I heard it again. If I were in the right place." He rubbed his temple. "The old woman on the phone. Citlali. She's the first candle. She'd know."

"She told me the same," I said slowly. "Doña Citlali said you light a candle from another candle. And that the first telling is where the flame must be lit again."

"Then we go to her," said Danny.

"It is eight hundred miles," said Ofelia. "To Mexico City. And everything is slowing down. The planes are not flying. The roads are..."

"There is another road," said Xolotl.

Everyone turned. He'd come in from the edge of the roof, and his ember eyes had cleared, steady and sharp.

"Under this city," he said, "there is a very old road. It was walked by soldiers and priests and merchants and mules before any of your highways. It was called the Camino Real. It ran from the capital to the north, and it carried a thousand things that were not written in any book." He glanced at Ofelia. "Your family's mirror came to this town along it."

Ofelia stared at him. "That's... the *trade* road. It's a historical marker."

"It is also a *road,*" said Xolotl. "It remembers its travelers. And the dead walk it, too. If the boys travel it in the company of one who knows it, they can reach the capital in a single night."

"A single night," said Danny. "That's one hour up here."

"If we are lucky."

"We never are," said Danny.

"We were last time," I said.

"That was *before.*"

Abuela didn't argue. She did the thing she does when she's already decided: she went to the little altar at the edge of the roof, took a thin wax taper from her apron pocket, and lit it from the ember in her own bowl.

She cupped her hand around the flame and carried it, slowly, across the roof, to the tin lantern. She slid it inside, closed the little door, and handed it to me.

"For Citlali," she said. "Her candle went out yesterday. It was lit from her mother's, who lit it from hers. She has not had a flame in her kitchen for a day." Her voice was very steady. "Tell her this one is lit from my mother's. It is not the same one. But it is from the same *hands*."

I took the lantern. It was warm. The little flame inside danced and settled and held.

"What about you?" I asked.

"I stay." She said it plainly. "I have the roof, and the phone, and nine candles that are lit. Ofelia will help me. And I have a brother." She glanced at Joaquín, and her face softened, and then she looked at me, and I knew exactly what she was going to say. "You are going to take him with you."

"Abuela, you just got him back."

"Sixty-four years I waited," said Abuela. "I can wait three more days." She turned to her brother. "You will go."

"I'll come back," said Joaquín.

"I know you will." She picked her pink slipper off the roof, brushed it off, and slid it back on. "I will put out the water."

I think that was the nicest thing she could have said. I'm not sure Joaquín understood it. But the old god of the dead, at the edge of the roof, put one paw over his mouth and turned away.

Chapter Twenty: The Road Remembers

Ofelia drove us to the marker.

It was a small bronze plaque on a stone post, tucked beside a parking lot behind a taquería, the kind of thing you'd walk past a thousand times. *El Camino Real de los Tejas,* it said. *This historic trail network linked the Spanish missions and settlements of Texas with the interior of New Spain.* A faded orange cone sat next to it. Someone had left a Dr Pepper can on top.

"This is it?" said Danny.

"I told you it was a historical marker," said Ofelia, a little defensively.

"It's got a *can* on it."

"It's a very *old* can," said Xolotl, and put his paw on the post.

The air changed. The parking lot didn't go anywhere. It was still there, still painted with its faded yellow lines, but the lines began to wander, and the asphalt grew thin, and underneath it, like a picture coming up in a darkroom, I could see stone. Old flat stones, worn smooth, running off into a dusk that was a lot longer than any dusk in San Antonio.

"It remembers its travelers," said Xolotl. "Keep your eyes open. Keep your feet on the stones. Do not follow anything that calls your name."

"Does it call your name a lot?" said Danny.

"Constantly."

Ofelia hugged Joaquín, quick and awkward, and shoved a paper bag of sandwiches into my hands. Then she got back into the Buick, and I watched her taillights shrink to two red dots and disappear, and the old road took us in.

I'd expected something grand. What I got was *busy*.

The road was full of traces. Not ghosts, exactly, more like the way a room feels right after everyone's left it. A line of mule prints, deep and fresh, cut across the stones and vanished into the dark. A rosary lay in the dust, its beads still swaying. Somewhere ahead, voices murmured in Spanish, and Nahuatl, and a dozen other languages I couldn't name, all talking at once about weather and prices and who had married whom.

I stepped on a small blue marble. It rolled under my sneaker and, for a moment, I heard a child laugh.

"Don't pick it up," said Xolotl.

"I wasn't going to!"

"Everyone wants to pick it up."

Joaquín walked beside me, and he'd gotten a little steadier in the last hour. His eyes kept widening at things. A passing wagon-wheel rut. A fragment of tile with a faded blue pattern. A tin cup that rolled out of nowhere and clanked to a stop at his feet, and he stared at it like he'd been handed a jewel.

"You've been here before," I said.

"Not *here.*" He picked up the cup, turned it over, and set it carefully back down. "But Papá used to say roads aren't just for walking. They're how people *remember* each other. Every footprint is a little hello."

I thought of Abuela's flame, carried across a roof in a tin lantern. I held it a bit closer.

We'd been walking for an hour, or a night, or something in between, when Danny finally said it.

"Okay. I have to ask."

"No, you do not," said Xolotl.

"You didn't even hear it."

"I did not need to. You have been wearing a hole in the road with that question since the stairs." He sighed. "Ask."

Danny had been quiet for a long time. His sandwich was still in his hand, uneaten. He swallowed.

"Tezcatlipoca said, 'Ask your Watcher what he made, and what he swore.' And the Watcher said he was sorry I'd inherited something. And the nails sing for me." He took a breath. "I'm not asking you to tell me who I am. I'm asking what you *know.* About the guy behind the door. The whole thing. Please."

Xolotl didn't answer right away.

"I will tell you what I know," he said. "I will also tell you where my knowing ends. That is the promise I made, and I mean to keep it."

"Okay."

"I did not meet him," said Xolotl. "I was not there. I came to understand the Valdivia door only in the last hundred years, when it began to *hum.* Everything I know about him, the road knows better. And the road is not a teller of tales. It is a *keeper* of them."

"It keeps only what was spoken on it," he added. "He talked to his iron by the fire. That is how I know where his father came from, and why I do not know the village. He never said it aloud."

He glanced at me. "If you want, I can ask it to show you."

"Show us?" I said.

"Do not be afraid. It will not hurt you. It will only remember out loud."

Danny looked at Joaquín. Joaquín looked at me.

"Okay," said Danny. "Show us."

The road went quiet.

The voices stopped. The mule prints stopped. A thin, warm wind came down the stones from the north, smelling of horses and dust and woodsmoke, and somewhere ahead of us, faint and then clearer, I heard something I recognized from every movie I'd ever fallen asleep to.

Clink. Clink. Clink.

A hammer.

A line of figures came walking out of the dusk, made of gray light and dust, and every step they took stirred the old stones. First came a man on a horse, in a stiff black coat and a wide hat, riding with his back straight and his eyes fixed on a chest strapped to a mule behind him. I knew that chest. I'd seen its twin at the bottom of Mictlan.

"Tomás Valdivia," I whispered.

"Do not look at him," said Xolotl. "Look behind."

Behind the horse and the mule and a pair of silent soldiers walked a man on foot.

He was tall and broad-shouldered, maybe thirty, in a plain linen shirt with the sleeves rolled up. Over his shoulder, wrapped in a gray cloth, he carried something heavy, and I realized it was a small anvil. He walked slowly, but not like someone who was tired. He walked like a man listening.

His hands were scarred. His forearms were thick as rope. And when the wind caught his hair, I saw that his face was calm and watchful and a little bit amused, the face of a person who's looking at the whole situation and quietly *deciding*.

"That's him," said Joaquín. "That's the Watcher."

"He was not called that then," said Xolotl.

"What *was* he called?"

"That," said Xolotl, "is the part I cannot give you."

The road showed us the rest in pieces, the way you remember a dream.

We saw him at a campfire, hammering a horseshoe on that little anvil while a soldier held a lantern. We saw him laugh at something, sharp and sudden. We saw him run his thumb along a half-finished hinge and tilt his head and say a few words, low, to the iron, like you'd say them to a child. I couldn't understand the language. It sounded like water running over stone.

"His father came from the Mande lands," said Xolotl, "across the ocean, and carried the forge in his hands. He taught his son. In those lands, a smith is not an ordinary craftsman. A smith stands near fire, which is near the powers, and so a smith is both honored and feared." He glanced at Danny. "I do not know which river his father was born beside. I do not know the name of his village. The road does not keep what no one wrote down."

"Why not?" said Danny, in a small, tight voice.

"Because the people who held the pens did not think it worth writing."

Nobody said anything for a while.

We saw the Valdivia house in the dusk. We saw a ledger on a desk, and a quill scratching across a line, and I could read it over Danny's shoulder: *Bartolomé, negro herrero, tasado en trescientos pesos.* Bartolomé, a Black smith, appraised at three hundred pesos.

"*That's* his name?" Danny whispered.

"That is the name the ledger gave him," said Xolotl. "It is the one the Church baptized. It is not the one his mother gave him, or the one his father used when he spoke to the iron. His own name was never written. He told it only to the forge."

Danny stared at the ink. For a second, I thought he was going to be sick. Instead he reached out, very slowly, and traced the letters in the air with his finger.

"Three hundred pesos," he said.

"Danny."

"I'm okay." He wasn't. "I'm okay. Keep going."

I'd like to tell you the rest was less awful. It wasn't.

We saw Valdivia in a courtyard, pacing, gripping the chest, his brother's grave still fresh in the dirt behind him. We saw the smith standing patiently in front of him, hands folded, while the clerk talked in a low, urgent voice. We saw a door described in chalk on a wall. A door of iron. A door with hundreds of nails, and a bar across the middle, and no handle on the inside.

"Valdivia asked him to forge it," said Xolotl quietly. "He wanted something that would keep the mirror's trouble below his house. He did not ask whether the smith wished to do it."

"Did he have a choice?" said Joaquín.

"He had a family in Puebla who could be sold." Xolotl's voice was flat. "He had a master with soldiers. He had very few choices. What he did with the ones he had is what I would like you to see."

The scene shifted.

Night. A forge in a stone cellar. A fire in a pit, a barrel of water beside it, and a rope of iron nails, cooling on a bench. A storm rolled overhead, thunder shaking the stones, and rain pouring in through a high window.

The smith didn't close the window.

He picked up a glowing nail with tongs, held it a moment in the air, and then plunged it into a bucket he'd set out in the rain, into water that had fallen from the sky. Steam hissed up in a thick, hot cloud, and the smell of it filled my nose before I could stop myself.

Hot iron. Rain.

"That's it," said Danny, and his voice had changed. "That's the smell. That's what Xolotl smelled on me."

"Quenching," said Xolotl, softly. "A smith plunges hot iron into water to harden it. The old ones said that iron remembers the fire, and the water teaches it to *keep*." His ears had gone low. "Rain on hot iron is not the smell of a god, Danny. It is the smell of a *craft*. It is the smell of someone who has made something to last."

"But I'm not a smith."

"No," said Xolotl. "But you were born under that rain."

The road went on, slow and dim. The scene shifted to the iron door, standing complete in a cellar, and the smith stood in front of it with his hands at his sides. He was alone. Valdivia had gone upstairs.

I watched him do a thing I didn't understand until much later.

He stepped up to the door and laid both hands against the iron, flat, like you'd steady a frightened horse. He bowed his head. His lips moved. The cellar went very still. And a thin, bright line of heat ran from his palms into the metal, and the whole door shivered, once, like a bell.

Then he turned around, and for just a second, he looked straight at us.

I felt my heart stop. His eyes weren't made of dust. They were warm and brown and very tired, and they didn't see Mateo or Joaquín or Xolotl. They landed on Danny.

He said something. Three words, soft, in a language like running water.

And Danny, beside me, made a small, startled sound.

"I *know* that," he said. "I know that. Mateo, I *know* that rhythm."

I hadn't heard a rhythm. I'd only heard the words. But Danny was already tapping his fingers against his leg, quick and light, a pattern I'd seen a thousand times in a thousand classrooms. Two short. One long. Two short.

"You always do that," I said. "On your desk. You've done it since second grade."

"My mom says I got it from my grandmother," said Danny, dazed. "She says everyone on her side does it. She calls it *'the old knock.'* She says her family's been in Texas since before Texas was Texas." He laughed, a thin, shaky little laugh. "I thought it was a joke. She says it like it's a joke. It's never been a joke."

"Before it was Texas," said Joaquín slowly, "it was Spanish Texas. And it was full of *people*."

"Full of everybody," said Xolotl. "Soldiers. Priests. Craftsmen. Children. And a great many whose names went into no book at all." He shook himself. "I cannot tell you that Bartolomé is the father of Danny's mother's line. I do not know. I can tell you that the iron knows his hands, and that the nails knew yours."

The road went dark again.

I thought the story was over. But the dust gathered one last time into the figure of a man standing alone in the cellar, hand pressed to the cold iron. His head was bowed. And we heard, very faintly, a voice, the same running-water language, and a single English word that the road translated for us in a warm, tired whisper that sounded like it came from all around.

Promise.

"What did he swear?" asked Danny.

"I do not know," said Xolotl. His voice shook. "That is the true edge of my knowing. I know what he *made.* A door. A ring of nails. A lock that would not open for any hand that did not ask. I know he stood in front of it and gave his word. And I know that for three hundred years, something in that cellar has hummed whenever a child with his hands came near." He looked at Danny. "I do not know what the promise *was.* Only he can tell you. And only if you

ask."

"Then I'll ask," said Danny.

"You will have to find the right way to do it."

"Can it play the voice again?" Danny asked quietly. "Not the pictures. Just the voice."

Xolotl asked the road. The wind came down the stones, and very faintly, those three soft words came again, like water over stone. Danny shut his eyes and didn't say anything until they faded.

"I'll find it." He wiped his face with the back of his hand and stood up straighter, and for the first time since I'd met him, I thought he looked like someone who'd decided something. "He gave me a lot of questions. But he also gave me his *name.* Or, you know. Almost. I'm going to find the rest."

"What name?"

"The one the ledger didn't write," said Danny. "I'm going to find it. I don't know how. But somebody remembers. Somebody always does."

I thought about the nine candles on Abuela's roof. I thought about a ledger with four hundred names, crossed out one at a time.

"I'll help," I said.

"Yeah?"

"Hand."

Danny looked at the cable on his wrist, white and a little frayed. He gave a short, astonished laugh. Then he held out his arm, and I tied the knot a little tighter.

Chapter Twenty-One: The Woman Who Lit It Alone

The Camino Real let us out under a bakery.

I mean that exactly. One second we were climbing the last of the old stones, and the next, a trapdoor opened over our heads and a wave of warm air hit us in the face, smelling of sugar and cinnamon and fresh bread. We climbed up into a stockroom full of flour sacks while a baker in a white apron stared at us with a tray of conchas in his hands.

"*Buenas,*" said Xolotl, in his most dignified voice.

The baker looked at a god in a tie. He looked at four dusty kids, one of whom had a charging

cable tied to his wrist. He looked at the tin lantern in my hand.

"*Doña Citlali?*" he said, and pointed with his chin toward a door at the back.

That was all. I think he'd seen stranger things. This was Mexico City.

I'd never been. My dad's family was from Puebla, but we'd always driven up to see them, and I'd always slept through the last hour. So I'd pictured something huge and gray and a little scary.

It was *loud*. Even slowed down, it was loud. The sun hung where it always hung, thick and orange and a little crumbly at the bottom, and under it the whole city seemed to be moving in syrup, but you could still hear it: a radio playing somewhere, a man calling out something about tamales, a dog arguing with a pigeon. Colors were stacked up everywhere, yellow and blue and pink, laundry hung across balconies, a courtyard full of potted geraniums.

Doña Citlali lived at the back of that courtyard, in a one-room house with a green door and a tin roof and a single wooden chair on the step.

The door was open.

"*Pasen,*" said a voice, thin as paper. "*Don't track mud on my floor.*"

I wiped my shoes four times. Danny wiped his five.

She was the smallest person I'd ever seen who didn't seem small.

She sat in a rocking chair at the back of a one-room kitchen, wrapped in a gray shawl, with a face like a walnut and hair as white as the flour on the baker's sacks. Her hands were folded in her lap. They were tiny and brown and covered in tiny scars, and they didn't move. In front of her, on a low wooden shelf, stood a clay candle holder.

It was empty.

I'd learned to recognize an empty candle holder by then. I'd seen one on Abuela's roof.

"So," said Doña Citlali. She looked at each of us in turn: Danny, Joaquín, Xolotl, me. Her eyes were black and bright and very unimpressed. "A dog. Two boys. And a *third* boy who is not a boy."

"I'm fourteen," said Joaquín.

"You are sixty-four."

"Technically."

"I like technically." She sniffed. "I do not like gods in my kitchen. They get in everything."

"Doña Citlali," said Xolotl, with a small bow, "I have known you for sixty years."

"And I have known you for sixty," she said. "And in all that time you have never once brought a *flower*."

I'd been rehearsing what to say for a hundred miles. I'd planned a speech about the sun, and the candle, and Abuela. I took a breath and held up the tin lantern.

"I have a flame for you," I said. "From Remedios Ibarra. She lit it from her mother's, who lit it from hers."

I'd expected tears, or relief, or a hug. I got silence.

Doña Citlali looked at the lantern for a very long time. Then she looked away, at the empty candle holder, and her mouth went tight.

"No," she said.

"No?"

"I will not take it."

I glanced at Danny. He shrugged, a tiny, bewildered shrug.

"Doña Citlali," said Joaquín gently, "the sun is..."

"I know what the sun is." Her voice cracked like dry wood. "Do not tell an old woman what the sun is. For fifty years I lit that candle in this room. Every morning. In the rain. In the *earthquake*. I lit it when my husband died and I lit it when my daughter stopped calling." She rocked, once, hard. "Fifty years! By myself! In a city of twenty million people! And not one of them asked. Not one of them came to the door and said, 'Doña, what are you doing with that candle?'"

The room was very still. A fly buzzed somewhere in the slow, thick light.

"And then it went out," she said. "And do you know what I felt, little Ibarra? I felt *relieved*. I felt like someone had finally let me put it down." She turned her black eyes on me. "I will not light it again for people who dropped it."

I opened my mouth.

I'd planned to argue. But I looked at her tiny scarred hands, and I thought of Abuela on the

ladder, and I thought of what it would be like to do something that important for fifty years, alone, with nobody in the world noticing.

"I'm sorry," I said instead.

Doña Citlali blinked.

"That's it," I said. "I'm just sorry. You're right. Nobody asked. We should have."

"Hm," said Doña Citlali.

She made us sit. Of course she did. She put us at a table the size of a cutting board, and gave each of us a mug of something thick and sweet and brown. It tasted like chocolate and cinnamon and a little bit like regret.

"You," she said to me. "Tell me what your grandmother taught you."

"The sun has to be fed," I said. "And remembered. You light it from another flame. You don't carry the fire alone. If you can't find a sunrise, light it anyway. Smoke goes up."

"Say it again."

"The sun has to be fed..."

"No." She raised one small hand. "*As she said it*."

I stopped.

I knew what Abuela said. I could have said every word she'd ever said to me, in order, with commas. I knew the way she paused before *sunrise*. I knew where her voice usually went up.

I couldn't hear it.

I tried. I shut my eyes and reached for her, the warm rough scrape, the little roll on her *r*s, and there was nothing in the place where it should have been. Just words, flat on a page.

"I can't," I whispered.

"No," said Doña Citlali, not unkindly. "I thought not." She tilted her head. "You have been in the underworld."

"Yes."

"And it has taken her voice from you."

"How did you...?"

"Because it took my mother's from me. In the earthquake of eighty-five, when I went down

for a night, looking for my mother. I did not find her." She said it very flatly, like she was reading a shopping list. "I came home and I could not remember what she sounded like. I still cannot. I have her words. I recite them. They are like a house with no one living in it."

I stared at her.

"That is the cost," said Doña Citlali. "That is what it takes. Not the words. The *voice*. The thing that makes a person who they are." She picked up her mug and sipped. "Words are bones. The voice is the blood."

"So that's it?" said Danny. His voice was small. "It's just... gone?"

"Gone? No." She set the mug down. "That is what your friend does not yet understand. The voice is gone from *his* head. But he still has the words. And the words are what you hand to the next person." She looked at me sharply. "Who have you told them to?"

"Nobody."

"Then you are the last link in a chain with no one after you. That is why it is so heavy."

"What do you mean?"

"I mean that you are carrying the whole chain *backwards*. You think the chain is the people who came before. The mothers. The grandmothers." She shook her head. "The chain is only the people who come *next*. You are not holding a rope. You are *handing* something."

I stared at her.

Handed.

It was Joaquín who made a sound. A very small sound, like a breath.

"Say that again," he whispered.

"Handing."

"No. Before that. The part about holding." He was gripping the edge of the table, his knuckles pale. "Say it exactly."

"You are not holding a rope," said Doña Citlali, puzzled. "You are *handing* something."

Joaquín stood up. His chair scraped. He was shaking from head to foot, and his eyes had gone very wide, as if somebody had turned a light on in a room he'd been standing in for sixty-four years.

"It won't hold," he said.

Nobody breathed.

"I remember. That's what I heard, at the mirror, when I was halfway through. The hands. Hundreds of them. They weren't *holding* the door. They were passing it." His voice cracked. "They were passing it along. Hand to hand to hand. And I understood, I understood all at once, that it won't hold. It was never meant to be *held*. It was meant to be *handed*."

"*Handed,*" said Xolotl, in a strangled voice.

"It was never one person's job," said Joaquín. "It was supposed to be everybody's. Just for a little while. And then you hand it to the next one. And they hand it to the next. And it doesn't ever get heavy, because nobody ever has to carry it very far."

For a long moment, nobody spoke.

I looked at Doña Citlali. Her face was perfectly still. But her tiny scarred hands, folded in her lap, had begun to tremble.

"The first telling," she said at last, "is not a text."

I'd been afraid of that.

"It is not a scroll, or a stone, or a ritual. I know what the priests said. They said it was a sacred formula, handed down from the beginning." She snorted. "The priests said many things. The truth is that the first telling is not one thing. It was never told once. It was told *a thousand times,* in a thousand voices, by a thousand people, and each of them changed it a little. And that is why it was strong."

"Changed it?" said Danny.

"Every teller makes it theirs," said Doña Citlali. "That is the difference between a telling and a recording. A recording is the same every time, and it rots. A telling is different every time, and it *lives*."

I thought about the milk, and the ladder, and Abuela's apron. I thought about the way she said *light it anyway,* which was her mother's phrase, and Joaquín's phrase, and mine, and had never once been exactly the same.

"So there's no first one," I said. "There's just the next one."

"There is a *place,*" said Doña Citlali, "where the first people sat down together and made the promise. The Mexica found it already old. They called it Teotihuacan, the place where the gods were made. It is an hour northeast of here, on an ordinary morning. Nobody remembers what its builders called it." She looked out the window. "Today I do not know how long it is. But that is where the first flame was lit, from nothing, by people who had no

candle. That is where you must go."

"And do what?"

"What do you think?" said Doña Citlali, with the tiniest curl of her mouth. "You tell it. Again. In your own voice."

"I don't have a voice for it," I said. "I lost it."

"You lost *hers,*" she said sharply. "You never had to keep hers. You had to learn to say it in yours."

I took the lantern out of my lap and set it on the table in front of her.

She looked at it for a long time.

"You were right to be angry," I said. "I'm not going to tell you not to be. But I think you should take it anyway. Not because we need it. Because Abuela wants you to have it." I swallowed. "She said she wanted you to know it's lit from the same hands."

Doña Citlali's jaw worked. She reached out, slowly, and touched the tin edge of the lantern with one finger.

"Fifty years," she said.

"Yes."

"I did not know anyone else was *there*."

"Abuela didn't, either," I said. "Neither did I. We were all kind of... doing it alone."

She was quiet for so long that I thought she'd decided to say no. Then she opened the little door, took the flame between thumb and finger, as casually as plucking a flower, and lit the empty candle on the shelf.

The kitchen changed.

It wasn't dramatic. The light was the same pale gold as before. But the corners of the room seemed to unclench, and the air felt thick and warm, and the old woman in the shawl sat back in her rocking chair and shut her eyes.

"Ay," she whispered. "*Ay, mija.* It is *warm.*"

On the shelf, the flame stood straight and bright, and the smoke went up.

"Eight minutes," said Doña Citlali, after a while. She had opened her eyes and was wiping them on her shawl. "That is how long you have before you must leave. The slow is catching up to the city. I felt it this morning, the street clocks going. You must be at the pyramid before the sun finishes."

The candle flame had begun to lean toward the window. "Fire knows when the sun is leaving," she said. "Look at it."

"How do we get there?" asked Danny.

"The baker's son has a truck."

"A *truck?*"

"He is fourteen," said Doña Citlali. "He drives like a god. Do not tell his mother."

I grinned. I couldn't help it. It felt like the first time I'd grinned in a hundred years.

Danny hauled himself up from the table and tucked his sandwich into his backpack. Joaquín was already at the door, his shoulders squared. Xolotl bowed to the old woman, very low, and she waved him away with the back of her hand.

"Go," she said. "And little Ibarra."

I turned.

"When you get there," said Doña Citlali, "do not look for what to say. Look for who is listening."

We stepped out into the courtyard.

The geraniums hung motionless. The laundry sagged on its lines. The sun was a tired, copper smear low over the rooftops, and its bottom edge had gone black.

Danny stopped in the middle of the courtyard.

"Mateo," he said, very quietly. "Look."

I looked at the window of the house next door. It was a plain glass window with a blue curtain, and in it I could see our reflections: Danny, Joaquín, Xolotl, me.

And behind us, in the reflection, a man in a long gray jacket leaned against the wall of the courtyard with his arms folded and his head tilted, smiling.

I spun around.

Nobody was there.

When I turned back to the window, he was still there. And so was he, in the next window. And the one after that. And every window in the courtyard, up and down the whole narrow street, and every single one of them was showing the same gentle, patient, tired face, and every single one of them was lifting one hand.

Tap.

Tap.

Tap.

Chapter Twenty-Two: Nobody Asked Chuy

The baker's son drove a truck the color of a tired lemon.

It was a pickup with one working headlight and a bumper held on by a bungee cord, and he'd parked it across two spaces, both of which were already occupied by a taco cart. He was a short, round-faced kid with a gap in his front teeth and a Chivas cap, and he leaned against the hood eating a concha like it was a Tuesday.

"You're the ones my dad said," he said. "I'm Chuy. Doña Citlali told me you'd be in a hurry. Are you?"

"Yes," I said.

"Cool." He opened the driver's door. "I'm fourteen, by the way."

"So am I," said Joaquín.

Chuy looked him up and down. "You look twelve."

"It's complicated."

"I'm not gonna ask," said Chuy, which I decided was the smartest thing anyone had said all day.

We squeezed into the cab. Chuy drove, Danny sat by the window with the backpack on his lap, and Joaquín and I wedged in between. Xolotl rode in the truck bed, sitting up very straight with his tie flapping behind him like a flag, like the most dignified dog in the world.

"Is that a *dog?*" said Chuy, glancing in the mirror.

"He prefers 'god,'" said Danny.

"Does he bite?"

"Only people who deserve it."

Chuy shrugged and turned the key. The engine coughed, shuddered, and settled into a rumble like a very large cat.

"Okay," he said. "Hang on. I don't brake much."

I turned to Danny. "We're trusting a fourteen-year-old with our lives."

"We've been trusting a fourteen-year-old with our lives all book," said Danny, nodding at Joaquín. "At least this one has a license."

"I don't have a license," said Chuy, cheerfully.

"Then at least he's *confident,*" said Danny.

"That's worse," said Xolotl, from the back, and I'll admit I laughed.

For the first twenty minutes, nothing happened.

We rolled out of the courtyard and down a street full of stopped traffic. A bus stood frozen at a green light, a man's hand raised in a wave. A pigeon hung in midair over a fountain. Chuy wove around all of it like he'd been born to, his elbow out the window, one hand lazily on the wheel.

The sun sat low and swollen over the hills, with the bottom third of it gone black.

It was Joaquín who broke the silence.

"Mateo," he said quietly. "Who are you going to tell?"

"Tell what?"

"The story. At the pyramid. Doña Citlali said to look for who's listening." He turned his head. "Who are you going to ask?"

I opened my mouth, and nothing came out. Because I'd planned the climb. I'd planned the words. I'd run the speech through my head forty times in the last hour. But I hadn't planned a single *person*.

"Huh," I said.

"Yeah," said Danny, gently. "That's kind of a big one."

"I was going to... I don't know. Yell it from the top?"

"At who?"

"At the sun."

"The sun's not a person."

"That's *exactly* my problem," I said, and Joaquín smiled a little, the crooked smile, and I realized that I'd just been told something very important by somebody who'd been told it by a woman in a rocking chair.

Look for who is listening.

It was Chuy, of all people, who gave me the answer.

"Can I ask something?" he said. "You guys have been going on about a sun. A story. And I'm sitting here thinking, I don't know any of it. And nobody asked me." He glanced at me, a quick, sideways look. "Not that I mind. But you're sitting there trying to figure out who's gonna listen, and I'm *right here,* and I'm listening."

Nobody said anything.

I looked at the side of his face. He had flour on his cheek. He was fourteen, and kind of round, and wore a cap with a goat on it, and I realized that I'd been so busy planning to save the world that I'd forgotten it was full of people.

"Okay," I said. "Can I tell you something?"

"Sure."

"It's about my grandmother."

I'd like to say I told it beautifully. I didn't. I'd lost her voice, and I had to say it in my own, and my own is not a good voice for stories. It cracks in the middle. I rush the parts I like.

I told him about the milk. I told him about eight-year-old me laughing so hard it came out of my nose, and about Abuela crossing herself, and refilling my glass. I told him about the ladder on the roof.

I told him the sun has to be fed.

When I stopped, the truck was quiet, except for the rumble of the engine.

"That's it?" said Chuy.

"That's... it."

"That's a *good* story," said Chuy, and his voice was strange. "My abuela puts out marigolds

on the windowsill every morning. I always thought it was for the dead. I never asked her why *every morning*."

"Maybe it's the same thing."

"Maybe." He swallowed. "I'm gonna ask her."

"You should."

"Yeah." He wiped his nose on the back of his hand, and then, for no reason I could tell, he started grinning. "Okay. I'm *in*. Whatever this is."

I looked at Danny. Danny was looking at me, with the face he makes when you finally get a question on the quiz right. And I understood, with a funny, warm feeling, like a candle turning up, that I'd just handed somebody something, and it hadn't weighed anything at all.

That's when the tapping began.

At first it was just one window. The side mirror, outside Danny's door, a soft little tap like a raindrop on a roof.

Tap.

Danny turned his head very slowly.

"It's not raining," he said.

"I know."

"It's coming from the mirror."

"I *know*."

Xolotl had stopped sitting up straight. In the rearview mirror, I saw his ears go flat and his body drop low in the truck bed, and behind him, in the glass, a man in a long gray jacket stood in the road, getting smaller and smaller as the truck pulled away.

He lifted one hand.

Tap.

On the passenger window, I saw him. On the windshield, a faint, patient shape, leaning on a fence. In the little round mirror on Chuy's dashboard, in the shine on the hood, in the lens of Danny's phone, in the bright chrome bumper of a frozen car we passed at a stoplight, the same man, the same tired smile, the same raised hand.

"What does he want?" whispered Joaquín.

"To be noticed," said Xolotl, from the back, in a voice I couldn't read. "My brother has always wanted that."

"Is it a trap?"

"It is a *reminder*."

Chuy glanced at the rearview mirror, then at the dashboard, then at the sixteen different reflections of a stranger in a gray jacket. His grin was gone.

"Guys," he said. "I don't want to be a bother. But I'm kind of seeing a man in my truck."

"Don't look at him," said Danny.

"That's *so* hard."

"I know."

It happened about fifteen minutes later.

We'd come out onto the highway, a long straight ribbon of gray, with the hills rolling up on both sides and the black sun hanging ahead of us like a hole in the sky. Chuy was driving steady, both hands on the wheel now, and he'd stopped glancing at the mirrors.

"Almost there," he said.

"Time's bent," said Xolotl, from the truck bed. "That felt like half an hour to us. To the sun, it was less than five minutes."

"It's one road, basically," Chuy went on. "Straight shot all the way. There's a bridge, and then it's a left at the sign for..."

"Chuy," said Danny.

"What?"

"Look at the mirror."

Chuy looked at the side mirror. In the glass, a wide, gray road curved away to the left, smooth and clear, with a sign that said *TEOTIHUACAN* in big white letters.

Then he looked at the windshield. In the glass, a second sign appeared, in front of the first, with the same word and the same arrow, but pointing a different way.

Then in the dashboard mirror. Then the rearview. Then the shine on the hood. Every reflection in the truck showed the same curve, the same exit ramp, the same left turn, getting closer and closer.

"That's the exit," said Chuy, uncertainly. "Right?"

"It's a *shortcut,*" said Joaquín. His voice was strange. "It's showing us a shortcut. It looks so..." He swallowed. "It looks *easy.*"

"It's what you want," said Xolotl, from the truck bed. He'd gotten to his feet, and his ears were pinned flat. "It always is. The mirror does not show what is. It shows what you hope."

My heart was hammering. The exit ramp was a few hundred yards away now. In the glass, it looked as if it led straight to the pyramid, with a clean wide road and a perfect view of the stars.

I looked at Chuy's hands. They were tightening on the wheel.

"There's no left turn," said Chuy.

I turned my head.

"There's no left turn," he said again, slowly, like a kid doing math. "I've driven this road a hundred times with my dad. There's a bridge and a gas station and then a sign. The turn's another *mile.* There's no exit here."

"But the mirrors..."

"The mirrors are *wrong,*" said Chuy.

Everyone in the truck went still.

I knew what I was supposed to do. I was supposed to be the hero, to take command, to say something clever, to figure out the secret. I'd had a speech ready. But for once in my life, I didn't.

I did the only thing I could think of. I listened.

"Chuy," I said. "Are you sure?"

"I'm sure."

"How sure?"

"I'd bet my truck." He swallowed. "It's my dad's truck. But yeah."

"Then don't turn."

"Okay."

"Don't look at the mirrors."

"Okay!"

"Look at the road *you* know."

He took a deep breath and did something I'll never forget: he put his eyes on the windshield, past the glass, past the reflections, and kept both hands steady. The exit flashed by on our left. For one second I saw, through the window, a wide, lovely road curving off into a bright, starry nothing, and where the pavement should have been, a perfectly smooth black surface, like a lake.

Then it was behind us.

Every mirror in the truck went dark. And in the silence, I heard, very faintly, a long, patient sigh, like a man putting down a book.

We drove in silence for a while.

My hands were shaking. Danny's were, too. Joaquín had both fists clenched in his lap, and he was staring out the window like a boy who'd seen a ghost, which, technically, he was.

"It was what I wanted," he whispered. "The road. It looked like the way home."

"It was a lie," said Danny.

"I know." He swallowed. "I wanted it anyway."

"That's not weak," said Danny. "That's just *human*."

Chuy let out a long breath. "So, uh," he said, in a small voice. "Does that happen a lot?"

"More than you'd think," said Danny.

"Cool. Cool, cool. Great." He cracked his knuckles on the wheel. "I'm gonna want a raise."

I started to laugh. I couldn't stop. And somewhere in the middle, I realized that Danny and Joaquín and Chuy were laughing too, in that high, slightly hysterical way people laugh when they've almost died and haven't. Even Xolotl, in the back, made a sound I'd never heard from him before, a little wheezy *huff* that could only have been a chuckle.

It's the nicest sound I've heard in a very long time.

We saw the pyramid before we saw anything else.

It rose out of the dusk ahead of us, enormous and flat-topped and pale as bone, so big that it made the hills look small. It stood at the end of a long, wide road lined with ruined walls. Even at this distance, I could see the stairs climbing up its face, hundreds of them, going up

and up toward the black sun.

"Pyramid of the Sun," said Chuy, quietly. "My dad took me once. I was six. I cried because it was so big."

"It's okay," said Joaquín. "I'd cry, too."

The truck rolled to a stop at the end of the road. The engine ticked. Chuy turned it off.

For a moment nobody moved.

At the bottom of the stairs, in the shadow of the pyramid, stood a single flat stone. And on the stone, small and black and shining, there sat a mirror about the size of a dinner plate.

It was exactly as I remembered it.

And in its glass, I could see the whole sky behind us, and the little yellow truck, and five very small, very tired travelers.

And a man in a gray jacket, standing right beside me, smiling.

Chapter Twenty-Three: The Voice in the Glass

The mirror was waiting on a flat stone at the foot of the pyramid, and it knew my name.

I'd like to tell you I stayed brave. I got out of the truck with my knees shaking, and Danny got out behind me, and Joaquín, and Chuy, who kept saying "oh wow, oh wow" under his breath in a very small voice. Xolotl hopped down from the truck bed and stood at my shoulder with his ears flat. Nobody said anything. The stairs of the pyramid rose behind the mirror, hundreds of them, pale as bone under a sun that had gone two-thirds black.

In the glass, I could see all of us. And I could see the man in the gray jacket, standing at my left, smiling gently.

I turned my head. Nobody was there.

"Hello, Mateo," said Tezcatlipoca, from the mirror. His voice was warm and soft, like a teacher at the end of a long day. "You came a long way. You must be so tired."

I was. That was the terrible part. I was so tired I could have lain down on the stone and slept for a week.

"I won't take long," he said. "I only want to give you something."

"What?" I said.

"What you lost."

The glass rippled. In it, our reflections faded, and in their place came the plain little kitchen on Zarzamora Street, bathed in morning light. There was the table, and the clay lamp on the altar, and the old clock over the stove. And standing at the sink, with her back to me and her gray braid down her back, was Abuela.

She turned around.

"*Mateo,*" she said.

My heart stopped.

It was her voice. It was her *voice.* The warm rough scrape of it, the little roll on her *r*s, the way she dropped a half beat before my name, as if saving it. I hadn't heard it in a hundred years. I hadn't known how badly I'd missed it until it came out of the glass and filled the whole space between my ears.

"*Mateo Quetzal Ibarra,*" said Abuela, and smiled.

I'm not going to pretend I didn't cry. I did. It came out of me in a thick, ugly sob, and Danny's hand found my shoulder, and I couldn't hear anything else.

"I could give you this forever," said Tezcatlipoca softly. "Not just the voice. Her kitchen. Her laugh. The smell of the cinnamon. Joaquín's lost years, every one. Citlali's mother. All the voices the dark has taken, kept safe, in a place where nothing ever slips." His eyes were kind. "No more toll. No more losing. You would never forget anything again."

"At the cost of what?" said Xolotl, hoarsely.

"At no cost, brother." Tezcatlipoca did not look away from me. "At no cost to *him.* He would only have to stop it. The slow. The failing sun. He would only have to let it rest."

"And everyone else?" said Joaquín.

"They would be kept, too."

I stood there. My nose was running. My fingers were clenched at my sides so hard they hurt. And a small, quiet, treacherous voice in the back of my head said: *Why not?*

What happened next, I can't take credit for.

"Mateo," said Danny.

I couldn't answer.

"Mateo, can I ask her something?"

"What?"

"Just a question. Please."

I didn't understand. But I nodded, because it was Danny, and I trusted him more than I'd ever trusted anyone. He stepped forward, and he cleared his throat, and he said, very politely, to the woman in the mirror:

"Excuse me, Abuela. What did you have for breakfast?"

"*Mateo Quetzal Ibarra,*" said Abuela, smiling.

Danny waited. "Okay. What's your favorite thing to cook?"

"*Mateo Quetzal Ibarra*."

"Do you want me to say hi to Doña Citlali?"

"*Mateo Quetzal Ibarra*."

The same four words, in the same warm voice, with the same half beat before *Mateo.* The same soft smile. And as I stared at her, I started to notice other things: that the clock on the wall hadn't moved. That her braid hadn't swayed. That a single sunbeam on the floor had been hanging in exactly the same place since the glass had begun to glow.

"It's a loop," said Danny.

"A loop is a mercy," said Tezcatlipoca.

"A loop is a *recording,*" said Danny. His voice was shaking, but it was steady. "Doña Citlali said that. A recording is the same every time, and it rots. A telling is different every time, and it lives." He looked at me. "She wouldn't say that, Mateo. The real Abuela would've asked what I wanted. She would've told me to take my shoes off."

I looked at the woman in the glass, so warm and so still. She wasn't Abuela. She was only the part of Abuela that I missed the most, with everything alive about her cut out.

Words are bones, I thought. *The voice is the blood.*

And this wasn't blood. It was a very good photograph.

"No," I said.

I said it quietly, and it came out raw, and it was the hardest thing I'd ever said.

"I'm sorry?" said Tezcatlipoca.

"I said no." My voice shook. "I want her voice back. I want it so much I can't breathe. But I don't want *that* one. I want the one that changes. The one that scolds me. The one that gets older." I wiped my face with the back of my hand. "I want the one that might say something I haven't heard yet."

The man in the gray jacket looked at me for a long moment. His smile had gone thin.

"You will lose it," he said. "You know that. Everything the underworld took will stay taken. You will go home and she will speak to you and you won't be able to remember how it sounded."

"I know."

"Then why?"

"Because it's *hers,*" I said. "It's not mine to keep. It's hers to give."

The mirror went dark.

It didn't shatter. It just stopped, the way a screen goes black, and for a moment I saw only my own reflection, small and ordinary, with a stain on its collar.

Then, very softly, from somewhere beyond the glass, I heard him sigh.

"Very well," said Tezcatlipoca, and I swear he sounded almost proud. "Let us see what you do with an empty hand."

I didn't know what to do.

I stood in front of the pyramid with the sun going dark over my head and the three people I trusted most standing beside me, and I realized with a horrible lurch that I'd refused the thing I wanted and had absolutely no idea what came next.

Chuy shuffled his feet.

"Um," he said. "Should I... go? Is this the part where I go?"

"No," I said. "Stay."

"Okay."

I looked at them. Danny, with his scraped knee and his three-pronged cable. Joaquín, fourteen and sixty-four, with Abuela's chin. Chuy, flour on his cheek, in a cap with a goat on

it. Xolotl, a god in a tie, who'd lied to me and promised not to.

I thought about what Doña Citlali had said. *Do not look for what to say. Look for who is listening.*

"I can't do this by myself," I said.

"No," said Danny. "You really can't."

"I don't know how to do it with you, either." I swallowed. "I don't think there's a trick. I think we just... tell it."

"Tell what?"

"What we remember. Whatever we've got. In our own words." I could hear my own voice cracking, and I didn't try to stop it. "I'm not going to tell you what to say. You don't have to. I'm just... asking. If you want to."

Nobody said anything. For one long, horrible second I thought no one would.

Then Joaquín stepped forward.

"My sister stalled a car in a plaza," he said.

He said it quietly, in a voice like someone testing a very thin sheet of ice. "Eleven times. I counted. She was fifteen, and Papá was teaching her, and I sat on the fountain and laughed until I fell in. She chased me around the whole square with a shoe." He took a breath. "I haven't thought about it in a very long time. I thought it was gone. But it's *here*."

He touched his chest, over his heart.

And on the flat stone beside the mirror, something small glowed.

It was a tiny spark, no bigger than a grain of rice, warm and gold, like a candle on a very faraway window. It flickered once, and held.

I stared at it.

Danny stepped up next to Joaquín. "My mom has a saying," he said, slowly. "'You come from people.' I never asked what she meant. I don't know all of it yet." He swallowed. "But my grandmother taps this rhythm on the kitchen table, and so do I, and I think somebody taught it to somebody who taught it to somebody. And I'd like to find the first guy." He tapped it on his knee, two short, one long, two short. "That's all I've got."

A second spark appeared on the stone, next to the first.

"I'm Chuy," said Chuy, uncertainly. "I... don't have a story. Not like that. But my abuela puts out marigolds on the windowsill every morning. I never asked her why. And I think I'd like to." He rubbed the back of his neck. "That counts, right? Saying I don't know yet?"

"It counts," said Xolotl, softly.

A third spark.

Xolotl looked at me. His ember eyes were very bright.

"My turn?" he said.

"If you want."

He lifted his chin. "I was a god of the dead for five hundred years," he said, "and I was a coward for sixty-four of them. I kept a boy in the dark so I would not have to look at what I'd done. I am sorry, Joaquín. I am sorry, Remedios, wherever you are. I am sorry, Mateo." He bowed his head. "I will not do it again."

A fourth spark, bright and sharp. It flared up like a struck match, and for the first time since we'd arrived, I felt the air around the pyramid *warm*.

I looked at the sun.

It was still two-thirds black. But the edge of the dark had stopped moving. It hung there like a held breath. And in the very thinnest rim of the shadow, no wider than a hair, a line of gold had come back.

"It's working," whispered Danny.

"It's not enough," said Xolotl. "Four candles will not light the sky."

He was right. I could feel it. The sparks flickered on the stone like a handful of fireflies in a very large field. We needed more. We needed more people than there were in this whole *valley*.

"We need to reach the others," I said. "The thirty. Abuela's phone tree. Ofelia. Anybody."

"We can't," said Joaquín. "There's no signal. We're at a pyramid. In the middle of nowhere."

"Danny," I said. "Your phone."

He pulled it out of his backpack. The screen lit up, bright and cheerful, and in the corner of it, a tiny red icon: *4%*.

"Of course," said Danny, in a hollow voice. "Of *course*. I've been watching it die since the

Camino Real."

"Do you have a signal?"

"One bar." He stared at it. "One bar, which is, like, a *miracle,* and four percent, which is, like, ninety seconds." He looked at the truck. "Please tell me Chuy's truck has a USB port."

"It has a cigarette lighter," said Chuy.

"I have an adapter," said Danny, and rummaged in the very bottom of his backpack, and pulled out a small white plug.

I want you to know that I've never loved a piece of plastic as much as I loved that adapter. Danny held it up like the Holy Grail. He looked at the white charging cable still tied to his wrist, and then at me, and a slow, helpless grin spread across his face.

"My mom," he said, "is going to be *so* smug."

It took us about forty seconds to plug in the phone. Chuy put the truck key in the ignition. The dashboard lit. The little red icon flickered, thought about it, and turned green.

Calling Ofelia.

It rang. It rang. And rang.

"Hello?" said a voice, crackling, ragged with static. "Mateo?"

"Ofelia!"

"Where *are* you?" She sounded close to tears. "We've been trying to call for an hour. It's so strange. The sun has been..."

"Listen," I said. "I need a favor. A big one. I need you to put the phone tree on speaker. All nine. Whoever lit a candle. And I need you to ask them something."

"Ask them what?"

I took a deep breath.

"Ask them if they'd like to tell it."

I can't explain what happened over the next ten minutes, except to say that I've never been so scared in my life, and I've been chased by star demons.

Ofelia put the call on speaker. One by one, the line filled with voices: old, young, cracked,

shy, a man's, a woman's, a child's. Nine of them. A woman in Oaxaca whose husband had died the winter before. A man in a village in Guerrero who hadn't told anyone he still kept the old dawn. A girl in Houston, fifteen, who'd learned it from a great-aunt on a laptop. Two I couldn't place at all. They crackled in and out like a very old radio.

"Hello?" said someone. "Is this the... is this a prayer meeting?"

"Sort of," said Ofelia. "Please listen to this boy."

They all fell quiet.

I looked at the little stone with its four glowing sparks. I looked at Danny, Joaquín, Chuy, Xolotl. I looked at the phone, with its tiny green light, and my heart was pounding so hard I thought I might be sick.

I said, "My name's Mateo. I'm twelve. I don't know a lot of things." My voice shook. "But my abuela taught me that the sun has to be fed. I laughed at her. I'm sorry. I'd like to tell you what I know now."

And I told it.

I didn't tell it well. I told it in my own voice, which cracks and rushes and gets lost. I told them about the milk, and the ladder, and the smoke that ran the wrong way. I told them about the wind and the beasts and a hand that wasn't there. I told them about a boy who'd stopped halfway through a mirror, and about a man with one foot, and about a woman in a rocking chair who'd lit it alone for fifty years.

When I got to the end, I said, "I don't have a rule. I don't have a trick. I just think if everybody tells it a little, and everybody hands it on a little, it won't be heavy."

Silence.

Then a small, dry, broken voice came through the speaker, thin as a thread.

Ofelia had put Abuela on from the roof, too. Counting her, there were ten voices on the line.

"*Mateo,*" said Abuela. "*Did you eat?*"

I can't tell you what it was like.

I heard it. I want that on the record. I heard my grandmother's voice, tinny and distorted and a little bit slow, coming out of a phone speaker in a pyramid in the middle of a valley at the end of the world. It wasn't the voice in the mirror. It was *worse.* It was scratchy and cracked and tired, and it asked me whether I'd eaten.

"Yeah," I managed. "Yeah. I had a concha."

"*A concha is not a meal.*"

"I know."

"*Eat a real thing.*"

"Okay."

"*Good,*" said Abuela. I heard her sniff. "*Now. Tell me what you want us to do.*"

I stood there, with my nose running, and I knew, with a clear, sad, perfect certainty, that when the call ended I'd lose it again. That the sound of her would slip out of my head like water through a net. I'd have her words, but not her voice.

I listened anyway. I listened with everything I had.

"I want you to tell it," I said. "Tell it to someone else. Right now. Anyone who's near you. Your neighbor. Your kid. A stranger at the bus stop. Don't do it the way I did. Do it your way." I swallowed. "And then ask them to tell it to someone."

"*That is all?*"

"That's all."

"*Mijo,*" said Abuela, "*that is very small.*"

"I know."

"*That is the best thing I have ever heard.*"

The sparks on the stone began to multiply.

Five. Eight. Nineteen. Little gold fireflies, flickering up from the rock, one for every voice on the phone and one for every person they spoke to. A spark didn't appear when someone heard the story. It only appeared when someone said yes, out loud, to the next person. They rose into the air and drifted toward the pyramid and hung there, a slow, shimmering river of light.

On the horizon, the black edge of the sun gave a long, shuddering heave, and *shrank*.

It was only a hair. But I saw it, and Danny saw it, and Joaquín grabbed my arm so hard it hurt.

"It's moving," he whispered. "Mateo. It's *moving.*"

"I know."

"We're doing it."

"We're *starting,*" said Xolotl, very quietly. His ears had gone up, and his tail was swinging. But there was something wrong in his face. "Do not celebrate yet."

I looked at him. Then I looked at the sky.

Above the pyramid, in the part of the heavens where the sun had gone black, a handful of stars had begun to appear.

They were small and white and brilliant, and they twinkled in a way that stars don't twinkle. They were falling. Slowly at first, then faster, one by one, spinning as they fell, and as they got closer I saw that they weren't stars at all.

They were long, thin arms. Wide skirts. Grins too wide for their faces.

"Tzitzimime," said Xolotl, and for the first time since I'd known him, his voice cracked with something very like joy, and under it, something very like fear for us. "He has sent the star demons. That means it is working. He would not do it otherwise."

"They do not come for us," he added quickly. "They come for the *voices.*"

"That's the *good* news?" yelled Danny.

"That," said Xolotl, "is the very best news I have had in five hundred years."

Behind us, in the dark glass of the mirror, someone started to clap.

Chapter Twenty-Four: The Loud One

The tzitzimime didn't attack us.

That was the first surprise. I'd braced for claws and teeth and a replay of the bus. Instead, the star demons landed on the flat plaza around the pyramid in a slow, spiraling shower, like leaves falling off a very tall tree, and stood there with their long arms hanging and their wide skirts rustling. There were maybe twenty of them. Their bodies glittered with little white lights.

They weren't looking at us.

They were looking at the phone.

"*Eat the loud one,*" whispered a voice from somewhere in the crowd. Thin and dry and far too happy. "*Eat the voices.*"

"They don't want us," said Danny. His voice was high and strange. "They want the call."

"Of course they do," said Xolotl. "They are the keepers of the dying sun. They feed on the end of things. The telling is the end of the end." He lowered his head. "Protect the voices. Everything else is secondary."

That was when I realized how little I'd planned.

I had a plan for four people and a phone. I did not have a plan for twenty demons.

Danny had the phone in both hands, sitting on the hood of the yellow truck, with the white cable running from his wrist to the dashboard. The little green charging icon glowed on the screen. One bar of signal flickered like a bad lightbulb. In his hands, from the tiny speaker, ten voices were murmuring, half-overlapping, telling stories to each other in a dozen different ways.

Joaquín stood next to me with his shoulders back. In my hands, the clay bowl glowed warm and steady.

Chuy was behind the wheel of the truck. He gripped it with both hands. "What do I do?" he whispered. "I don't... I can't fight."

"Keep it running," I said.

"That's it?"

"That's the most important job." I swallowed. "If the truck stops, the phone dies. If the phone dies, the call ends."

"Okay." Chuy took a deep, shaky breath. "Okay. I can do that. I'm really good at sitting."

The first tzitzimitl lunged.

It went straight for Danny. A long, bony arm shot out, trailing white sparks, and a hand like a spider reached for the phone. Danny yelped and held it up out of reach. Xolotl crashed into the demon from the side, a streak of gray fur and crackling light, and knocked it flat.

"*Hold the line!*" Xolotl roared. "*Do not let them reach the voices!*"

The plaza erupted.

I don't remember it in order. It happened in flashes, the way you remember a car crash.

I remember a skirt of white stars brushing past my face, close enough to taste. I remember Joaquín dragging me backward by the collar just as a long, thin arm swiped the place where my head had been. I remember Chuy leaning on the horn, a single flat honk that made every

demon in the plaza flinch, and him looking shocked, and then honking again, delighted.

I remember the phone.

"*Mateo,*" said a voice from the speaker, crackling. "*Mateo, there is something wrong with the...*"

The voice stopped.

I whirled. A second demon had landed on the hood of the truck, long and gleaming, with a hand wrapped around the phone. Its fingers were sparking. Blue static crawled up the screen. The little green icon flickered, flickered, and went red.

"*No!*" Danny yanked it away, but the damage was done. The speaker hissed once, a long, ragged breath of static, and then the line went dead.

The voices were gone.

"*Zero bars,*" said Danny, in a very small voice. He held up the phone. The screen was black. "It's gone. It's all gone. I'm so sorry."

"It's okay," I said.

"It's *not* okay! That was the whole... they were all on the line! We had them! Mateo, we *had* them!"

"I know." My heart was pounding. I stood there in the middle of the plaza with a clay bowl in my hands and twenty hungry demons circling, and I did what I'd have done two days ago: I panicked.

I'd been the one who planned it. I'd been the one who gathered them, the one who asked them to tell. And now the line was dead, and all those people were somewhere out there, alone, with a candle and a story and no idea what happened next.

"Stand still," said Xolotl. He had landed beside me, panting, with one ear torn. "Mateo. Look at the sun."

"I can't, I have to fix the..."

"*Look at the sun.*"

I looked.

It was still two-thirds black. But the thin line of gold at the edge, the one that had come back when the sparks began, hadn't gone away. It was still there. It hadn't shrunk, or flickered, or faded.

And around us, on the stone, the little gold sparks were still rising.

"It's still working," I whispered.

"It was never the phone," said Xolotl. His ember eyes were fierce and warm. "The phone was only the match. The call was how you *started* it. But the telling is not the call. The telling is what the people *do*."

I stared at the sparks.

They hadn't stopped. They'd kept coming. One by one, out of the dark, little gold lights were popping up in the far, far distance: on the hillsides, in the windows of the farmhouses and tin-roofed shacks around the valley. Faint. Flickering. Candles.

People had heard. And they had chosen.

I'd lost control of it. I couldn't tell them what to do. I couldn't reach them. And it didn't matter at all.

"*Mateo!*"

It was Joaquín. His voice was sharp with fear. He was pointing at the sky.

The demons had stopped circling. All twenty of them had turned, together, toward me. Their star-lights blazed. And I understood what they were looking at.

Not the phone. Not the truck. *Me*.

Because I was the one still speaking. Because I'd said it out loud, in my own voice, in front of ten strangers on a phone, and then in front of a sky full of listening candles. I was the loudest thing in the valley.

They eat people, Xolotl had said, a hundred years ago, in a parking lot. *Mostly the loud ones*.

"Okay," I said. My mouth was dry. "I can work with that."

"*What?*" said Danny.

"They want a loud one. I'll be the loud one." I took a long, ragged breath. "If they're all looking at me, they're not looking at the phones. Or the candles. Or Chuy." I swallowed. "That's the thing I'm good at."

"*Mateo,*" said Joaquín. "That's *insane*."

"It's not a *plan,*" I said. "It's a... it's a *job*. I'm just doing a job." I could feel my voice shaking,

and I didn't care. "Danny, I need you to do the other thing."

"What other thing?"

"The rain."

Danny's face went gray.

It had cost him last time. We both knew it. It had cost him a nosebleed and a long gray hour of shaking. He'd held a storm in place for three hundred and seventy-two breaths, and it had taken the strength out of him like a drain.

"I don't know how much I've got," he whispered.

"I know."

"If I use it, I might not be able to..."

"I know." I looked at him. "I'm not going to tell you to. I'm just... I'm asking."

For a long second he looked at me. Then he looked at the demons, at the shimmering, hungry circle of stars, and I saw something shift in his face. Not fear. Understanding.

"Quenching," he said slowly.

"What?"

"The smith. In the road. He put the hot nail in the rain. It made the steam." He swallowed. "The tzitzimime are hot. They're *star-fire*. They're basically really hot iron." His mouth twitched, half a smile. "I can quench them."

"Can you?"

"I don't know. But I can try." He slid off the hood and planted his feet. "If it doesn't work, I'm going to look really stupid."

"You look stupid all the time," said Chuy, from the driver's seat.

"*Thank* you."

Danny raised both hands. The sky went dark.

The rain came down like the world was being poured out of a bucket.

It wasn't the mist from the obsidian wind. It was a downpour, thick and warm and smelling of hot iron, and the second it hit the tzitzimime, they screamed. Steam exploded off their

bodies in great white clouds. Their star-lights hissed and spat and went dull. The nearest one stumbled, dropped to its knees, and began to shrink, like a candle drowned in water.

"*It's working!*" yelled Chuy, leaning out the window.

"*Don't stop!*" I yelled.

Danny didn't answer. He was shaking. A thin line of blood ran from his nose, and his knees were buckling, and I could see him fighting to stay on his feet. A storm like this wasn't a drop. It was a *lie,* and he was holding it up with his bare hands.

"*Joaquín!*" I screamed. "*Count for him!*"

Joaquín was already there. He'd dropped to one knee beside Danny, one arm wrapped around his shoulders, holding him up. "*One,*" he said. "*Two. Danny. Breathe. Three.*"

"*Four,*" said Chuy, from the truck, and honked twice.

"*Five,*" said Xolotl.

He leaped.

He wasn't leaping at the demons. He leaped up, a shape of gray and lightning, and flung himself at the black, boiling clouds that Danny had called. The air cracked. A bolt of white fire speared down from the sky, thick as a tree, and struck the middle of the plaza, and the entire valley went white.

When my eyes cleared, the demons were gone.

Not gone. *Quenched.* A scatter of gray ash on the flat stones, and a few last sparks, fading. Steam rose in great, slow clouds. The rain thinned. Stopped.

Danny fell.

Joaquín caught him. They went down together in a heap on the wet ground, and for one horrible second I thought he wasn't moving.

"I'm okay," said Danny, in a voice like a tired kitten. "I'm... that was..." He blinked at the sky. "Did I do it?"

"You did it," I said. I was on my knees beside him. I didn't remember getting there.

"Did *you* do it?"

"I was loud."

"You're *always* loud," said Danny, and laughed, and coughed up a tiny bit of blood, and passed out on Joaquín's shoulder.

We sat there for a while. I'm not sure how long.

Xolotl dropped back to the ground, trembling, his tie in tatters. Chuy climbed down from the truck and stood there with both hands in his hair, whispering "oh my gosh, oh my gosh." The brown dog, who'd been sitting by the mirror the whole time, got up, stretched, and padded over to Danny's side.

Joaquín held him. His shoulders were shaking, but he was smiling.

"We did it," he said. "We actually..."

"Not yet," I said.

The phone sat on the hood, dark and dead. The truck's charger had never come unplugged. The dashboard light was still on. It only needed to restart. I picked it up and pressed the button. Nothing. Then, very faintly, the little screen glimmered, and the tiny green icon came back.

Reconnecting...

Call from: Ofelia.

My hand shook as I pressed it.

"Mateo?" said Ofelia's voice, thin and ragged. "Mateo, are you still there? The call dropped, and I didn't know if... Something has happened. The woman in Oaxaca..."

"What happened?"

"Her candle went out."

My heart sank.

"A gust of wind. Right when the line cut off. She's very upset. She says she's too old, she can't light it again, she doesn't want to be the one who ruined it." Ofelia took a ragged breath. "Doña Remedios is talking to her now."

"Put her on."

There was a long, crackling pause. Then, from the speaker, thin and trembling but unmistakable:

"*...I do not know if I can,*" said a woman's voice. "*My hands are so shaky. And my husband always did it...*"

"*Do not count what is gone,*" said Abuela's voice, gentle and firm. "*Count what is lit. And you are not alone, mija. I am here. The boy is here. Ten voices were on this line before the*

wind took it. We will hold it for you until you are ready."

A long silence.

"...*My daughter just walked in,*" said the woman, slowly. "*She says she has a match.*"

"*Good,*" said Abuela.

"*She says... she'd like to learn.*"

I closed my eyes. The sparks on the stone had gone out, one by one, in the rain, and now, very slowly, in the dark, one tiny gold light flickered back to life.

Then another.

I don't know how long it was before I noticed the clapping.

It was slow. Patient. Not mocking. Just three or four steady claps, echoing across the plaza like a man at the end of a very long recital.

I opened my eyes.

The obsidian mirror had changed. It wasn't sitting on the stone anymore. It was standing upright, tall as a door, and in the middle of it, where the glass should have been, the surface shimmered like water. And stepping out of it, one slow stride at a time, was a man in a long gray jacket and a white shirt open at the neck.

He had a smile on his face. It wasn't a cruel one. It was tired, and fond, and a little bit sad.

His right foot was a disk of black glass, and with every step it clicked on the stone.

"Well done, little Quetzal," said Tezcatlipoca. "Very well done. I did not expect the phone."

He stopped, three paces from me, and clasped his hands in front of him.

"Now," he said, "let us talk about the part where it isn't enough."

Chapter Twenty-Five: What the Mirror Wants

"It isn't enough," said Tezcatlipoca.

He said it gently, like a doctor. He stood on the flat stones of the plaza with his hands clasped in front of him, and behind him, where the obsidian mirror had been, stood a tall doorway of black glass. The middle of it shimmered like water in a very dim room.

And the doorway was growing.

I could see it. A thin silver line was creeping out along the stone from the bottom of the frame, a hair's width wider every second, like frost on a window. The air around it had gone strange: thick and slow and clear. A raindrop from Danny's storm hung motionless in the air above the plaza, a perfect sphere, with the pyramid reflected in it.

"The sun is moving," said Tezcatlipoca. "A little. I won't pretend it isn't. You've done something wonderful tonight, all of you." His eyes crinkled. "But a candle is not a sun. It will take thousands of hours of telling, and years of belief, and a great many people who must never grow tired or forget. And I know what people are like."

"We're not..." I started.

"You're *twelve,*" he said, not unkindly. "You are very good. And you'll be a wonderful old man someday. But the sun is dying *now.*"

Behind me, I heard Xolotl take a ragged breath. He was bleeding from one ear. His tie was in strips. But he stood there, shoulders squared, in front of Danny, who was sitting against the truck's front wheel with his head back and his eyes half closed.

"Brother," he said hoarsely. "Say what you came to say."

"I have never denied that you were right," said Tezcatlipoca, and he looked at Joaquín. "The Binding was cruel. A child in a lock. A whole world resting on one set of small shoulders. They called it a sacrifice, but a sacrifice is something you choose. They took it from you, Joaquín. And they took it from every child before you, and they would have taken it from this one."

Joaquín didn't say anything. His hands were shaking.

"And you were right to be angry," said Tezcatlipoca, to Danny. "The people who built that door did not ask the man who forged it. They did not ask his family. They put a name in a ledger and a price beside it." His voice dropped. "I have been angry about that for three hundred years."

Danny's eyes opened.

"I have been angry for longer than any of you have been alive," said Tezcatlipoca. "That is the only thing you and I have ever agreed on."

I realized something with a horrible lurch. I realized he *meant* it. Every word. That was what made it so hard.

"So here is my offer," he said. "I am not going to take your voice, Mateo, or anyone's. I will

not touch the candles or the phones. I have never done anything but ask." He opened one hand toward the doorway. "I only want you to *look*."

I looked.

Through the shimmering glass, I could see a world.

It was beautiful. That was the first thing. It was the most beautiful thing I'd ever seen. A plaza, a lot like the one we were standing on, but whole and bright and golden, with a pyramid that wasn't in ruins. The sun hung exactly overhead, gentle and warm, and in its light, people stood in small happy clusters, perfectly still.

I saw Doña Citlali's kitchen. I saw Abuela at the sink, with her braid over one shoulder, and Joaquín beside her, a boy of twelve, laughing, and the clock above the stove stopped at a quarter to five. I saw Danny's mother, whom I'd never met, in a bright yellow dress, with a plate of food, and I knew it was her because she had his chin. I saw a girl with Chuy's gap-toothed smile. I saw a woman in a gray shawl, with a candle in each hand, who looked like she'd finally been allowed to sit down.

Nobody moved. Nobody ever would.

"It is not a prison," said Tezcatlipoca softly. "It is a *garden*. Nobody is ever lost. Nobody is ever afraid. A sparrow is a sparrow, forever. A child is a child, forever, and a grandmother's voice is hers forever." His voice was almost pleading. "Mateo. You could step through. Right now. Not as a sacrifice. Not as a lock. As a *guest*. And you could keep her."

The silver line crept another inch along the stones. Behind me, Chuy's truck engine coughed, slowed, and ticked. The raindrop in the air didn't fall.

I looked at Abuela's frozen face, at the little half-smile she wore in the glass.

I wanted it.

I don't want to lie to you. I wanted it more than I'd wanted anything in my life.

I've thought a lot about what I did next. I'd like to tell you it was brave. I think, mostly, it was *tired*.

I looked at the golden world. I looked at Tezcatlipoca, who was standing in the middle of the plaza with his empty hand outstretched, and for the first time I really *saw* him.

He wasn't smiling. He was *waiting*. He had the face of someone who has asked a question a thousand times and is afraid of the answer.

And I understood something that nobody had told me.

"Can I ask you something?" I said.

His eyebrows went up. "Of course."

"What do *you* want?"

For a moment, nobody moved.

"I beg your pardon?"

"You've asked everybody what they want. Joaquín. Danny. Me. You've been asking for three hundred years." I swallowed. "But I don't think anybody's ever asked you."

"I want..." He stopped. His mouth opened and closed. The smile slid off his face like water off glass. "I want the world to stop hurting."

"That's what you want *for* us. What do you want for *you*?"

I saw it hit him.

It wasn't dramatic. His shoulders sagged, just a little. His hand dropped to his side. The click of the black glass foot against the stone was suddenly very loud.

"Nobody has asked me that," he said slowly, "in a very long time."

"I lost a brother," said Tezcatlipoca.

He said it so quietly that I almost didn't catch it. He was staring at the golden world through the doorway, not at us. His voice was thin and dry, like paper.

"Not Xolotl. Xolotl was only ever my little dog." There was a sound that might have been a laugh. "My *other* brother. The tall one. The one who laughed at everything. The one with the feathers." His eyes were bright. "We fought. About the world. About what it should be. And I was cruel, and I was clever, and I won. I drove him out. I told myself it was because he was wrong." He swallowed. "And then I stood in a very quiet house for a very long time, and I could not remember what his laugh sounded like."

I stopped breathing.

"I built the Still Sun to keep him," said Tezcatlipoca. "I thought, if I could only stop the world exactly as it was, with him still in it, I could never lose him. I have been standing in a perfect garden for more years than there are stars in the sky. And he is not there. Because a thing that is kept is not the thing you lost. It is only the shape it left."

"*Quetzalcoatl,*" said Xolotl, very softly.

"They named you after him," said Tezcatlipoca, to me. His voice cracked. "The day you were born, the sun flickered, and I heard a laugh. A very small one. In a house on a street in a city I didn't know. And I thought..." He closed his eyes. "I thought, *there you are*."

"I'm not him," I whispered.

"I know." He opened them. "I knew it the moment you looked into the glass. You have his name, and you don't have his laugh. You have your own, which is much worse. It cracks in the middle."

"It does," I said. "I rush the parts I like."

Tezcatlipoca made a small, broken sound.

"I can't stay," I said. "I'm sorry. I'm not your brother, and I can't be your guest. I'd forget how to laugh if I stayed there, and then I wouldn't be anybody." I took a breath. "But I can ask you something."

"Ask."

"Would you like to tell it?"

"I beg your pardon?"

"The story. The one about him." I held out the clay bowl in my open palm, the way I'd learned to, with the little ember glowing in its black crust. "You don't have to tell me why. You don't have to do anything. But I think it's been a really long time since anybody heard it."

For a very long moment, Tezcatlipoca didn't move.

Then he took a single step forward, and another, and he stood in front of me, close enough that I could see the faint gray freckles on his cheeks, and the dark smudges under his eyes. He looked at the ember. He looked at my face.

He didn't take the bowl. But he knelt down in front of me, in the dust, with his black glass foot tucked under him, and he started to talk.

"He laughed at everything," said Tezcatlipoca. "That was the first thing. When we were small, in the old dark, before there was a sun, he laughed at the *silence*. It made him giggle. He said it was so loud. He used to make me stand very still, so he could listen to it..."

On the stone beside him, very slowly, a tiny gold spark began to glow.

It was small. It was shy. It flickered, and went out, and flickered again, as if it had forgotten how. It hadn't come because he was sad. It had come because he'd decided to keep going.

Tezcatlipoca stopped. He stared at it, wide-eyed.

"I did not know," he whispered, "that it would *hurt*."

I won't tell you what he said next. Some of it wasn't mine to share.

He talked for a long time. About a boy who laughed, and a house full of feathers, and a fight about a world nobody understood yet. Xolotl came and sat beside him, silent, with his head against his brother's shoulder, and neither of them said a word. At some point Joaquín sat down on Tezcatlipoca's other side. At some point Chuy came out of the truck, and Danny dragged himself up on one elbow, and Joaquín began to tell the story of the plaza and the car, and Danny tapped the old knock on the stone, and Chuy said, very quietly, "My abuela makes this *really* good atole, and I never ask her how."

And the sparks came.

They rose off the stones like dandelion seeds, dozens, then hundreds, gold and warm and small. They drifted up past the pyramid, and up past the stars, and away across the valley, and when I looked out over the hills, I saw that every window was lit.

Every window. In every village. Every house.

The doorway of black glass trembled. The silver line that had been crawling along the stones stopped, shivered, and began, slowly, to pull back.

In the sky, the black edge of the sun gave a long, shuddering sigh, and the gold came back.

I'd like to tell you that was the end of it.

It wasn't. Tezcatlipoca stood up, in the end, and brushed the dust from his knees, and for a moment he looked like a very old, very tired man. He looked at the doorway, still open, still glimmering, a little narrower than before. He looked at the sun, rising a hair at a time into the light.

"It will not be enough," he said softly. "Not yet. You must know that."

"I know."

"The door is not closed. I cannot close it. Not alone." He turned to me. "That is the trouble with a lock. It needs someone who was *asked*."

I glanced at Danny.

He was sitting against the truck's wheel with his eyes shut, drained, shaking, a smear of blood under his nose. But his hand was still tapping, two short, one long, two short, on the stone. And very far away, I thought I heard something answer: a thin, bright ringing, like a hundred iron nails humming in a doorframe three hundred miles to the north.

"It's not ours to close," I said. "Is it? Not yet."

"No." Tezcatlipoca almost smiled. "That is a story for another day, little Quetzal. And I think, perhaps, another telling."

He turned to the doorway. He paused at its edge, and I saw his right foot, a disk of black glass, gleam in the light of ten thousand candles.

"Understood is not the same as forgiven, brother," Xolotl said quietly.

"I know," said Tezcatlipoca. "I would not ask for the second."

"Thank you," he said, without looking back. "For asking."

Then he stepped through, and the glass swallowed him whole, and the doorway folded in on itself like a closing book.

On the stone where it had stood, a single obsidian mirror lay face up in the dust. It was cracked straight down the middle.

In the crack, a tiny gold flame was burning.

Chapter Twenty-Six: The Sun Sets (Properly)

I'm not going to tell you about the ride home.

It took a night and part of a day, and it involved a lot of sandwiches, a truck that smelled like cinnamon, and a very long stretch on the old stones where Danny slept with his head on Joaquín's shoulder and nobody said anything. (Roads like that don't care about clocks. For us it was a night and half a day. For San Antonio, it had only been about three hours since the sun started moving again.) Chuy dropped us at the baker's. Doña Citlali stood in her doorway in her gray shawl and looked us over, one by one, like a general inspecting her troops.

"You are alive," she said.

"Yes," I said.

"And the sun?"

"It's moving."

"Hm." She nodded, as though that were the least she'd expected. She looked at Xolotl, who was limping, and whose tie was in ribbons. "Next time," she said, "bring flowers."

"I will bring a *garden,*" said Xolotl.

"Do not overdo it," said Doña Citlali, and shut the door. Through the window, I saw her sit down in her rocking chair, in front of a candle that burned straight and bright, and fold her small hands in her lap.

Chuy hugged me, quick and hard, with flour on his hat.

"I asked my abuela," he whispered. "About the marigolds. She cried. Then she told me for two hours."

"What did she say?"

"I'll tell you when I've got it right," said Chuy. "It's long."

I'll tell you what I did remember about getting home, because it's the only part that matters.

We came up out of the old road into the parking lot behind the taquería. The Dr Pepper can was still on the post. The yellow lines were still painted on the asphalt. And over the low roofs of the buildings, huge and slow and red, hung the sun.

It was setting.

I want you to understand how strange that sounds. For days, that sun had hung at 4:47 like a coin in a vending machine. Now it was dropping, a little at a time, down toward the horizon, bleeding orange and pink and gold across the sky.

A sunset. A real, ordinary, overcooked sunset.

I stood in that parking lot and I cried like a baby. Danny, who'd been woken up by the stop, put his arm around me, and Joaquín stood on my other side with his hands in his pockets, and Xolotl sat at our feet with his chin on his paws, and nobody said a word until the sun slid out of sight.

"It went down," said Joaquín, in a small, wondering voice. "It really did."

"It's allowed to," said Danny.

Ofelia drove us the rest of the way.

She'd been waiting at the marker, in the Buick, with a thermos of coffee and a face I'd never seen on her: tired and wrecked and so happy she looked a little seasick. She asked us nothing. She just opened the doors, and we climbed in, and she drove through the dark streets of San Antonio with both hands on the wheel, while the clocks ticked steadily on every dashboard and the traffic lights changed from red to green like they'd never done anything else.

Somewhere along Zarzamora, she cleared her throat.

"Dr. Quiroga turned up," she said. "This morning. At the museum. He walked out of the basement like he'd been asleep, and he doesn't remember anything past the afternoon with the mirror." She swallowed. "He asked a guard what day it was, and then he burst into tears."

"Is he okay?"

"He will be." She glanced at me in the mirror. "I told him it wasn't his fault. He didn't believe me. I told him again." A tiny, wobbly smile. "I think that's how it's supposed to work."

"What about your dad?" I asked.

Ofelia didn't answer for a long time.

"There's a letter," she said finally. "It came this morning. Same handwriting. Same ink, still wet." She kept her eyes on the road. "It only says two words."

"What?"

"*Not yet.*"

I looked out at the sleeping houses, the porch lights, the little lawns. I decided that was a problem for another book.

Abuela was on the roof.

I knew she'd be there before I climbed the ladder. It was five in the morning, the sky was a thin, dark gray, and a single light burned in the small window above the back door. I took the rungs one at a time, past the rusty bolts, up onto the old tar paper roof.

She was standing at the ring of bricks with her back to me.

She had her blue housedress on, and her gray braid down her back, and her pink slippers. A fresh marigold lay next to the clay bowl. A pinch of copal glowed in the bottom of it, orange and quiet.

The sky in the east was going pale.

She didn't turn around.

"You are late," said Abuela.

"Sorry."

"The sun is not."

"I noticed."

She still didn't turn. But I saw her shoulders move, and I understood that she was trying very hard to be calm. I walked across the roof, my sneakers squeaking, and stood beside her at the ring of bricks, and we both looked down at the little bowl.

The smoke was rising.

It rose in a thin, straight, perfect thread, up from the copal, up past our faces, up into the cooling dark, and it didn't waver, and it didn't turn, and it didn't run down the bricks like water. It just went *up,* the way smoke is supposed to.

"Every day for forty years," I said.

"Today it came back," said Abuela.

We stood there, shoulder to shoulder, and watched it go.

"I lost your voice," I said.

I hadn't planned to say it. It just came out, the way things do at five in the morning, on a roof, when you're too tired to be anybody but yourself.

Abuela didn't say anything.

"In the underworld. It takes things. It took the sound of you. I know all the words. I know what you said. I just can't *hear* it anymore, when you're not here." My voice cracked. "I thought I'd be able to get it back. I thought if I won, it would come. It didn't."

"No," said Abuela.

"I'm sorry."

"Why?"

"Because it's yours. It's the thing that makes you *you,* and I lost it."

She turned around. She looked at me for a long moment, in the soft gray light, with her wrinkled face and her bright black eyes. She took my hand in both of hers, those rough,

warm, scarred little hands, and she held it.

"Mateo," she said. "I am standing right here."

"I know."

"Then stand closer."

I did.

I stepped in until my forehead nearly touched hers, and I listened. Not to what she said. To the *sound* of it, the slow rough scrape of her breath, the little catch in her throat, the way her *r*s rolled and her sentences dropped half a beat before my name.

"You don't need to keep it," said Abuela. "It will not rot in a jar. It is not a thing for keeping. It is a thing for *hearing,* when I am here, and for remembering, when I am not." She squeezed my hand. "You will forget some of it. That is all right. You will hear it again tomorrow, and it will be different, because I will be a little older, and you will be a little bigger. That is the whole point."

I laughed. It came out wet and cracked.

"That's what Doña Citlali said."

"She is a very smart woman."

"She said you're not holding a rope. You're handing something."

"Hm," said Abuela. She let go of my hand and nudged the clay bowl with a slipper. "Then hand."

I'd like to say I did it perfectly.

I knelt on the roof, the way she showed me, and took the bowl in my open hands, the way I'd learned to hold it. The little ember glowed. The copal smelled like cinnamon and smoke. The sky was turning pink in the east, and the first sliver of the sun was just beginning to clear the roofs.

"You say the words," said Abuela. "Whichever ones you have."

"I don't know the old ones."

"Then say yours."

I took a breath.

"Hi," I said, to the sun. "It's Mateo. I'm Remedios's grandson. I laughed at her when I was

eight, and I'm sorry." My voice shook. "I don't know if you can hear me. I don't know if this does anything. But my abuela's been doing it for forty years, and I think that's got to count for something. So... here." I lifted the bowl. "This is for you. Please keep going."

The sun came up.

It didn't come up all at once. It rose a little at a time, the way it was supposed to, lifting its edge over the rooftops and the telephone wires and the tops of the old live oaks. It was orange, then gold, then a clean, warm white. Down in the yard, a rooster who had no business being in the neighborhood started up, and every dog in a three-block radius yelled back.

Behind me, Abuela said, in a voice I'll never be able to describe:

"*That is not how I say it.*"

"No," I said.

"*Good,*" said Abuela.

Breakfast was a disaster.

I mean that lovingly. Abuela made eggs. Joaquín, who'd never seen a modern stove, tried to help, and set a dish towel on fire. Abuela hit him with a spatula. Joaquín, who was fourteen and sixty-four and very much her brother, yelled something in Spanish that I decided not to translate, and she chased him around the kitchen table with a pink slipper.

Danny, wearing someone's old bathrobe and one of Abuela's good mugs, watched the whole thing with wide eyes.

"Is this normal?" he whispered.

"This is *very* normal," I said.

"It's like a sitcom."

"It's our *family.*"

"I like it," said Danny, and he sounded surprised.

Xolotl sat on the back step with a bowl of water, in the early sun, his tie draped over the doorknob. The brown dog lay beside him, one white ear in the shadow, watching the kitchen through the screen. When Abuela came out to refill the bowl, she paused.

"Perro," she said.

"Doña Remedios."

"There is a place on the porch for you. Whenever you like." She didn't look at him. "I will not put out the water for a stray."

"I understand," said Xolotl, and the way his ears went up I knew he'd heard the other thing she hadn't said.

The minivan pulled up at around nine.

It was silver and a little dented, and it stopped in front of the house with a squeal, and a woman got out of it so fast she left the door open. She was tall, with a bright yellow scarf and a coat thrown over scrubs, and she was *furious.* She looked like she'd been awake for three days.

She had Danny's chin.

"*Daniel Chukwuemeka Okafor,*" she said.

Danny, who'd been trying to disappear into his bathrobe, froze.

"*Mom,*" he said.

"Do you know," said his mother, in a voice that could have cut glass, "how long I've been looking for you? Do you know how many hospitals I've *called?* Your teacher said there was a *field trip* and then there wasn't a field trip and then the bus was in somebody's *rosebush*..."

"*Mom,*" said Danny, and burst into tears.

She stopped. All the anger drained out of her face. She crossed the lawn in three steps and caught him in both arms, bathrobe and mug and all, and for a long time, neither of them said anything.

I looked away. So did Joaquín. Abuela, in the doorway, crossed herself and went back inside, and Xolotl lowered his head, ears flat.

When Danny finally pulled back, wiping his face on his sleeve, his mother was crying too. She held him by the shoulders, at arm's length, and looked him over, and made a little sound that wasn't quite a laugh.

"Where *were* you?" she said, quietly.

"Mictlan," said Danny.

"Don't be smart."

"I'm not." He swallowed. "I'll tell you all of it. I promise. But I need to ask you something first."

"What?"

He took a breath. And, very quietly, he tapped it on his own chest. Two short. One long. Two short.

His mother went still.

I saw it. I saw the blood leave her face. She stared at his hand, and then at his eyes, and her lips parted, and she didn't say anything at all.

"The old knock," said Danny. "Mom. Who's it from?"

She was quiet for so long that I thought she wasn't going to answer.

"Who told you to ask?" she said finally, very softly.

"A man in a cellar."

She closed her eyes.

"Get in the car," she said. "It's a long story, and I only know the middle."

I watched them go.

The van pulled away from the curb in a cloud of exhaust, and Danny's face appeared at the back window, red-eyed and tired and grinning. He held up his wrist. The white charging cable was still tied to it, frayed and gray. He waggled it at me, once, like a wave.

I held up mine.

The van turned the corner and was gone.

On the porch, in the early sun, Joaquín was sitting very still with his hands in his lap. He was looking at the street where the minivan had been, and when I sat beside him, he didn't say anything.

"You okay?" I asked.

"I'm fine." He wasn't. "I was just thinking. About what the man said. About the door. That it needs someone who was asked."

"Yeah."

"I think it's going to be him." He nodded toward the corner. "Not now. Not soon. But

someday."

"I think so too."

"That's the part I don't like," said Joaquín. "I know what it's like. To be the one that gets asked." He looked at his hands. "I hope somebody remembers to tell him he can say no."

"I will," I said.

"Promise?"

I thought about Abuela on the roof, and a woman in a rocking chair, and a god in a ruined tie. I thought about a chain with no beginning and no end, and about the little clay bowl on the kitchen windowsill.

"Promise," I said.

Chapter Twenty-Seven: Somebody's Keeping a Candle Lit Near You

On Monday, I went back to school.

I want you to know that it was the strangest day of my life, and I once drove a stolen school bus through a living cloud. Nobody mentioned the field trip. Ms. Delgado had a headache and a vague memory of being very interested in a calendar. The district had found the bus in Abuela's rosebushes and decided, after a long meeting, that it was a prank by "persons unknown." Mr. Pruitt, the driver, told everyone he'd fallen asleep at a stoplight and woken up three hours later with a burrito on his lap. He'd lost his appetite for burritos, he said. He sounded sad about it.

Abuela, when asked, said she'd never seen a school bus in her life.

I was eating my lunch alone at the end of a long table when Brock sat down across from me.

I want to be clear that Brock is a sixth grader who once ate a sandwich off the gym floor because he'd "called it." He sat down with a tray, three Takis bags, and a look on his face like a person who had been thinking very hard for a week and had run out of other people to tell.

"Ibarra," he said.

"Brock."

"I need to talk to you about something."

I braced myself. I looked around for the nearest exit, and then I remembered that I'd stopped doing that.

"Okay," I said.

"I had a dream," said Brock. He leaned in. "About a dog in a tie. Standing behind the guide. Like, a *tall* dog. And the guide was a dog, too. And then everybody was asleep, and I was the only one awake, and there was a mirror, and I couldn't look at it." He swallowed. "Then I woke up and my sandwich was gone."

"Huh."

"I'm not crazy."

"I know."

"You *know?*"

"You're not crazy," I said. "You're just... a very good observer." I took a breath. "Would you like some of my lunch?"

He stared at me. Then he stared at the foil package in my lunch bag, and a very slow, very suspicious look crossed his face.

"Is that the thing that smells weird?"

"It's a tamale."

"It smells weird."

"I know."

"...Can I try it?"

I gave him half. He took a bite. His eyes went wide. He stopped chewing. The whole table seemed to go quiet.

"*Ibarra,*" said Brock, in a hushed, reverent voice, "this is the best thing I have ever eaten."

"I know."

"Why does it smell weird?"

"It doesn't," I said. "It smells *amazing*. You just didn't know yet."

Brock finished the tamale in silence. Then he wiped his hands on his jeans, looked me up and down, and said, quite seriously, "I take it back."

"Take what back?"

"The thing I said. About your lunch." He shrugged. "My bad."

It was, I realized, the nicest thing Brock had ever said to anyone.

"Hey," said Brock, a few minutes later, through a mouthful of Takis. "Weird thing."

"What?"

"My grandpa's been doing this thing." He frowned. "Every morning, he goes out on the porch with a cup of coffee, and he pours a little on the ground. And he says something. I asked him what it was, and he said it was 'for the sun.'" He rolled his eyes. "He's never done that before. He's eighty. I think he's finally lost it."

I put down my fork.

"What does he say?"

"I dunno. Something like, 'Keep going.'" Brock looked up. "Why? Is that a thing?"

I thought about it. I thought about a woman in a rocking chair, and nine candles, and a hundred small gold lights on a valley full of hillsides. I thought about how nobody had told Brock's grandfather what to do, and how he'd done it anyway.

"It's a thing," I said.

"Is it weird?"

"No," I said. "It's pretty great."

Brock looked unconvinced. But he nodded, and ate another Takis, and said, "Okay. Cool."

I wasn't sure what to say next. So I asked, "Do you want to hear a story about my abuela?"

"Is it long?"

"Kind of."

"Okay," said Brock. And he listened, with his chin on his fist, and his eyes on my face, for the whole lunch period.

I rushed the parts I like. My voice cracked in the middle.

He didn't seem to mind.

I'll tell you what else happened that week. It's only small things. But the small things are the point.

Chuy texted me a photo of his abuela, a tiny woman in an apron, laughing at the camera with a ladle in one hand. *She told me the whole thing,* he wrote. *It took three hours. I'm telling my cousins on Sunday. I've got it like 60% right.* A minute later: *She says 60% is a good start.*

Ofelia called to say the Valdivia Trust had begun accepting visitors, by appointment, and that the first guest had been a very old woman from Mexico City in a gray shawl who'd brought her own candle. "She refuses to explain," said Ofelia, a little helplessly. "She just sits in my father's study every Tuesday and corrects my pronunciation."

Joaquín had started driving the Buick.

He was terrible at it. He stalled it eleven times in the church parking lot, and Abuela, sitting in the passenger seat with her purse on her lap, counted every one of them out loud. On the twelfth try, he got it moving. Abuela said nothing. But I saw her face, from the porch, and I saw what was in it, and I decided to give them the afternoon.

The old dog sat on the back step in the morning sun, with a bowl of water and a ruined tie. He said he didn't mind being called a stray. He said it was a promotion.

And the brown dog lay beside him, one white ear flicking, watching the street.

She still hasn't told us her name.

I'm starting to think she's waiting for someone to ask.

It was Friday night when Danny called.

I was sitting on the roof, with the clay bowl in my lap, watching the last of the sunset go down over San Antonio, a real sunset, orange and pink and deep blue, on a day that ended when it was supposed to. Abuela had gone to bed early. Joaquín was snoring through the window beneath me.

The phone buzzed. I answered.

"Hey," said Danny.

He sounded tired. Not the bad kind. The kind you get after you've been talking for a long time to somebody who loves you.

"Hey," I said. "How's your mom?"

"We've been talking since Monday." He laughed, thin and shaky. "She knows the middle. She told me all of it. I don't think I'm supposed to tell you the whole thing yet, because some

of it's hers. But I can tell you one part."

"Okay."

"You know how the old knock goes? She said it came from a man. Her grandmother's grandfather's father. Somebody who worked with iron." He paused. "She said he was never written down."

I held my breath.

"And there's another thing." His voice dropped. "She says that the week I was born, somebody came to our house. In Sugar Land. A man in a gray suit and a gray hat. He didn't knock. He just left something on the porch and walked away."

My heart went cold.

"What did he leave?"

"A nail."

I closed my eyes.

"A little iron nail," said Danny. "Rusty. About two inches long. My mom kept it. She didn't know why. She says it hums." He took a breath. "She put it in a jar on the kitchen windowsill, and it's been humming for twelve years. Quietly. Like it was waiting."

"Danny."

"I'm sending you a recording. Hang on."

My phone buzzed. I held it up to my ear and I pressed play.

At first I heard nothing. Just the soft, empty sound of a kitchen at night, a refrigerator humming, a dog barking far off. Then, so faint I thought I'd imagined it, a thin, bright, steady tone began to rise, like a wet finger on the rim of a glass. It swelled. It rang. It shimmered, rising and falling in a rhythm I knew by heart.

Two short. One long. Two short.

"It's doing the knock," I whispered.

"There's more," said Danny. "Listen. Past the knock. Underneath it."

I pressed the phone to my ear.

And under the hum, so soft it was almost silence, I heard something else. Three syllables. A word, or a name, in a language like water running over stone.

I couldn't make it out. But it was there.

"Mateo," said Danny, very quietly, from three miles away, in the dark. "It's *saying* something. I can almost hear it."

I looked up.

The first star was coming out over the rooftops, small and white and bright, the way a star is supposed to. Down on the street, a light came on in a neighbor's window. Another. And another. Candles, I realized. Little yellow flames, one by one, in kitchens and on porches and behind curtains, all the way down the block, as far as I could see.

I held the phone a little tighter.

"We'll find it," I said. "Together."

"Hand?" said Danny.

"Hand," I said.

So.

Look. If you're reading this, you're probably fine.

I know. That's a terrible way to end a book. I spent the first page telling you that you were probably in danger, and now I'm telling you the opposite, and you're going to feel cheated. But here's the thing I learned: the world is a lot more dangerous than I thought, and a lot more full of people than I thought, and the second one turns out to matter more.

Somewhere near you, right now, someone is keeping a candle lit.

It might be your grandmother. It might be a neighbor. It might be a man on a porch, pouring coffee on the ground and saying something he doesn't quite understand. It might not look like a candle at all. It might look like a casserole, or a lullaby, or a recipe, or a way of saying goodbye.

Ask them what they're doing. Ask them why.

And when they tell you, listen. Don't rush the parts you like. Don't worry if your voice cracks in the middle.

And then tell someone else.

Because here's the last thing I know. It was never one person's job to hold up the sun.

It was always supposed to be handed.

The End of Book One

The Obsidian Mirror Chronicles will continue.